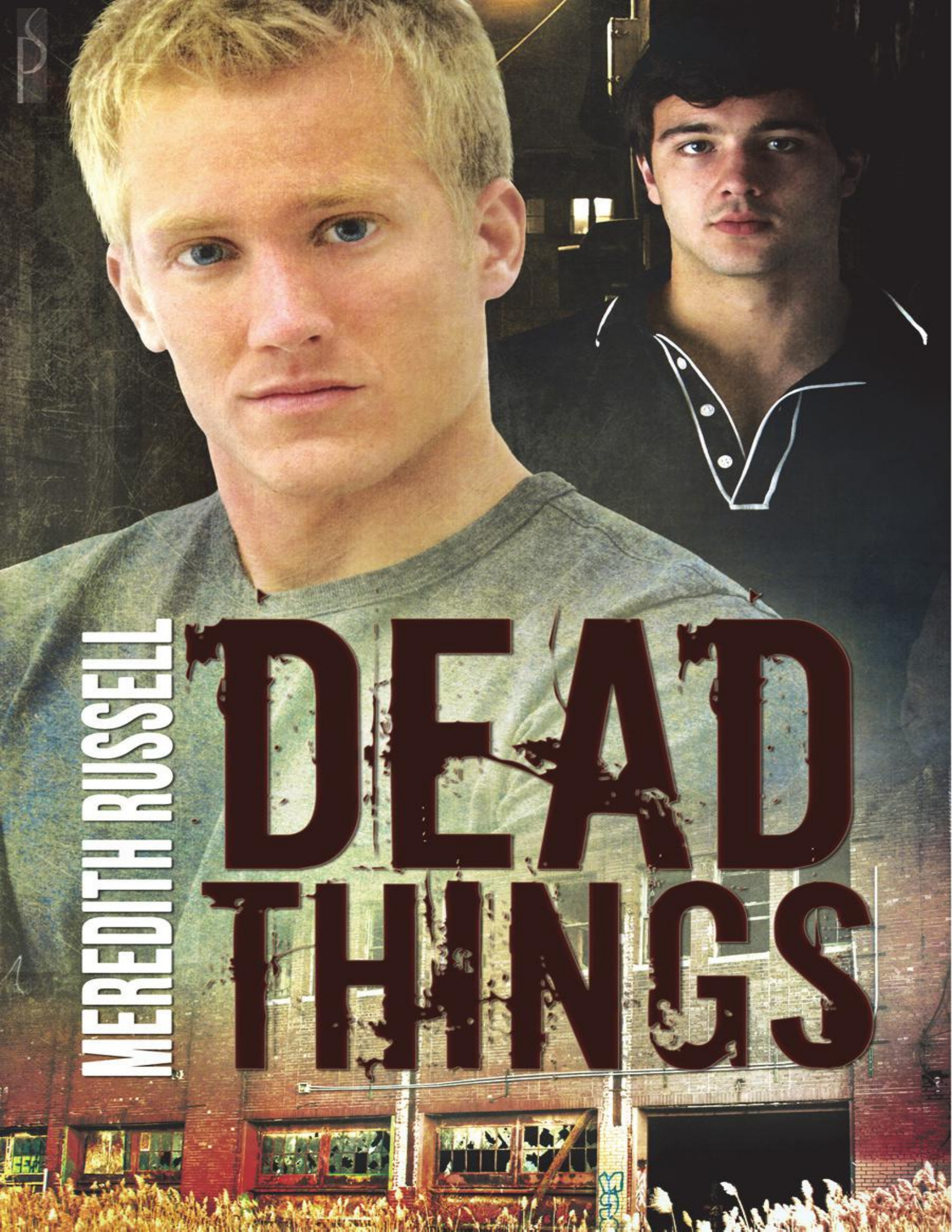




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MEREDITH RUSSELL

DEAD THINGS



DEAD DUMB THINGS

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Publisher of Erotic Romance

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DEDICATION

To Maia, my Queen of the May, for your friendship and support. Our baby is all grown up. And to Stephen, my rock, for your love and patience. You make me a better person.

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CHAPTER 1

"You're kidding, right?"

Devin Reid tapped his thumbs thoughtfully against

the steering wheel of the dark Mercedes-Benz SUV. No, he wasn't kidding. In fact, he was deadly serious. He guided the vehicle to the side of the road, and left the engine running as he considered the surrounding area. Through the SUV's dark-tinted windows he saw the old diner set back from the highway. The place wouldn't have seen a dime or a customer in almost nine months. The outer door hung crookedly on only one of its hinges, and the windows were filthy, covered in dirt kicked up from the highway and the strong wind that blew through the valley. Despite the few cars sitting out front in the parking lot, there was no one around. There were no lights on inside the diner or the adjoining gas station, and both buildings had an eerie stillness about them.

Aware of his partner, Lee, fidgeting in the

passenger seat beside him, Devin made a decision and cut the engine.

"Come on," he said and pulled at the door handle. The door swung open and he stepped out of the car.

Pushing his shades higher, he stepped back from the SUV

and closed the heavy door, his hand lingering around one of 1

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the metal strips welded across the dark glass of the driver's side window. He twisted his hand around the metal and checked the car up and down. Several similar bars secured the SUV's radiator and wheel arches.

"Omelet?"

Devin looked across the hood of the car and

frowned, silently disapproving of his young companion's attempt to lighten the mood.

"Get it?" Lee continued, quirking his head and smirking as he nodded toward the specials board beside the door. The writing was faint, bleached by the sun, but the offer of any omelet and fries for under three dollars could be made out beneath the layer of old dirt.

Devin pressed his mouth into a thin line as his

partner raised his automatic weapon and scanned it across the front of the diner. With a sigh he pushed his own gun into the holster he wore on his thigh.

"I get it," he said flatly and turned from the diner toward the horizon. He found it comforting as he looked across the large empty plain. There was nothing but miles of dry, sandy dirt spattered with tufts of tall grass reaching out in all directions from the diner. With a crooked smile, he walked to the back of the vehicle then opened and closed the trunk quickly, appearing with two gas cans in his hands. "Let's make this quick," he said and started toward 2

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the gas station. "Head up to the diner. See if they've got any canned food in the back."

"The diner?" There was fear in his young companion's voice.

Looking back over his shoulder, Devin gave a

heavy sigh. He lowered the gas cans and folded his arms across his chest as he turned to Lee. He watched the teenager shift nervously from one foot to the other and run a shaky hand through his short, auburn hair. The spatter of freckles across his youthful cheeks was darker than usual as his face paled.

"Lee, stop being a pussy and get over there," Devin said firmly, and nodded toward the diner. They didn't have time to mess around. He waited, watching as Lee eyed the dilapidated building, the idea seemingly daunting to the teenager. He hadn't wanted to bring the kid with him, but as he had been told, everyone needed to pull their weight.

There was no easy ride in this world. Not anymore.

Lee straightened up, took a deep breath, pulled at

the waistband of his pale blue skinny jeans, and wrapped his hand more tightly around the gun he carried.

"There's nothing in there," Devin insisted, noting Lee's hesitation.

"Nothing living," Lee said. He looked

uncomfortable as he kicked the toe of his heavy boot in the 3

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soft dirt.

"Nothing at all." Devin tried to sound reassuring, though from experience he knew very little should be taken at face value anymore. Too often something was lurking around the corner ready to bite you in the ass. Literally. He looked up at the diner, narrowing his eyes as he focused on the diner windows. There was nothing moving. "Though if you don't get your scrawny ass moving..." He pointed back toward the highway. "You know we won't be alone forever," he warned as he released the Velcro-strap of his Kevlar vest, and tightened the armor around him. "Now get to it."

Lee's shoulders dropped as he admitted defeat. "I hate this shit," he muttered as he stepped forward.

Devin watched Lee start toward the diner, before

reluctantly taking his eyes off him. Picking up the gas cans, he headed for the station. He'd try there first, and then move onto the parking lot. It was dangerous to stay in one place for too long so they had to make this quick. Kicking at the dirt, he stopped beside one of the pumps and checked the area around him. Still there was nothing. Placing the cans beside the pump, he quickly headed inside the station.

He remembered the first time he needed gas. He'd been clueless. There had been no attendant or help of any kind. It was just him. Eventually, he had found a release switch for 4

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the fuel dispensers inside the station's adjacent store. Also he discovered many gas stations were equipped with a secondary power supply, using

generators to bring the gas up from the tanks in times of power outages. Hopefully, this was one such station.

The door swung shut behind him and he stood and

silently assessed the deserted building. It was a small space—a cooler stood behind the door and a row of shelves split the station into two short aisles. There was nobody around. The contents of the shelves were strewn across the floor, and bloody footprints marked the pages and covers of scattered magazines and newspapers. He didn't have time to get distracted by things he'd seen over and over again. He was here for supplies—gas and food. With a steadying breath, Devin got to work, focusing on what he needed to do.

It was the moment of truth. Lifting the first nozzle, Devin held it over the opening of one of the canisters. He just hoped, after his efforts, the damn thing worked.

Squeezing the handle, Devin was relieved as the pump made a strange rumbling sound and started. The counter kicked over to zero and the fuel was released. He listened to the trail of gas as it ran into the gas can and he crouched down beside it. They had not been out this far in a long 5

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time, and from the look of it, neither had anyone else. It was becoming more difficult as time passed to find the resources they needed. If it was just him, maybe things would be different. But it wasn't. People relied on him.

"Devin, you there?" Devin jumped as an unexpected voice came over his radio. Loud and clear, the familiar voice spoke to him through the earpiece he wore. "Devin?"

Where you at? Hey, you there?"

Devin didn't reply straight away, waiting for the

first gas can to fill, before swapping to start filling the second. Raising his hand, he sighed and pulled

uncomfortably at the mic around his neck. "What?" he said.

"You didn't check in. Where are you?" Jack Torres asked.

"Twenty miles northwest of Topeka. Gas

scavenge," Devin said frowning as he noticed how the gas had slowed to a trickle.

"Find anything to eat?"

He could always count on Jack to make him smile.

"Jack, you ever think about something other than your stomach?" he asked and pulled off his shades to hook them in the front of his vest.

"Find any candy?" Jack added with a laugh.

Devin wiped the back of his hand over his brow.

"Crap," he said as the gas came to a complete stop.

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"S'up?"

"Nothing," Devin lied as he dropped the dry fuel lead. The metal nozzle clattered against the concrete plinth the pump was sitting on as it fell.

"You want to say that again, and sound like you mean it?"

Devin firmly screwed the cap on the quarter-filled

gas can. "It's nothing," he said as he twisted the cap as tightly as he could. Slowly, he leaned back and got to his feet, his eyes narrowing as a reflection in the metal casing of the pump caught his attention. "Can you hang on a second?" He cut Jack off before he could say anything.

"Just..." His hand went to his side as he focused on the moving shadow.

"What's going on?" Jack's voice was edged with concern.

"Shh," Devin hushed, and rested his hand on his gun as he gently fingered the catch on its holster. He counted to three as he watched the shadowy reflection grow, and then he sharply spun around. Holding his gun in front of him, he quirked his eyebrow as he met Lee's shocked eyes.

"Seriously?" He looked at Lee. Part of him wanted to slap some sense into the kid. Slowly, he moved his finger away from the trigger and pressed it to the side of his 7

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gun. "You do realize I could have shot you?" He kept his voice low and calm as he continued to aim at Lee's head.

Lee froze. His blue eyes were bright and glassy as

he stared down the barrel of Devin's gun. "I just thought—"

"That's the problem. You didn't think." Devin returned his gun to his holster. He sighed inwardly as he noted Lee had returned empty-handed. "We don't have time for games, Lee." He nodded toward the diner. "Find anything?"

Lee shook his head. "It's all locked up."

Devin looked curiously at the busted exterior door

of the diner. He closed his eyes and pinched the bridge of his nose as he realized Lee had chickened out. Not that he blamed Lee. The diner was creepy as hell. Once he had finished with the gas, the two of them could take a look around. "Okay, we'll go together. But we need to be quick."

"Okay," Lee agreed and lowered his head. "So how'd you know I was there?" Lee shifted on the spot as he shuffled his feet against the ground.

Picking up the first gas can, Devin eyed Lee

thoughtfully. The kid looked so young. "You weren't exactly quiet," Devin pointed out. His tone was serious.

"You need to be more aware of what's around you. You need to be careful. Okay?"

"What's going on?" Jack interrupted.

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Devin pressed the piece a little more firmly into his ear as he told him, "Just Lee playing games." Devin understood Lee hadn't been outside the secure walls of the penitentiary in months, but the kid had no focus and it was starting to annoy him.

"Tell him his mom says hey," Jack said, sounding cheerful. "She hopes you're looking after her little boy."

Snorting a laugh, Devin picked up the second gas

can and started back toward the SUV. "Yeah, yeah." He'd drop these at the car and then try some of the parked vehicles for gas, before checking out the diner.

"Where are we going next?" Lee asked as he fell in beside Devin and eagerly tried to match his stride.

"Did you tell Lee what I said? His mom has been on my case for the last hour waiting for you to check in," Jack continued. "Personally, I think he needs a kick in that skinny ass of his. I swear. He's such a dork. He'll end up shooting himself, or you. You should watch yourself."

"We just came looking for gas," Devin said as he tightened his hold on the gas cans. His hands were greasy.

"I know," Lee cut in. "Just, I really wanna see one."

Devin stopped and stared at the kid in disbelief.

Only moments ago, Lee had been crapping his pants at the thought of coming across something over at the diner. "No, really you don't," he said flatly and shook his head in 9

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disgust. What the hell was up with this kid?

"But to really get close. I mean, I bet they're really gross now. Those at the prison looked like normal guys, not that Mom let me anywhere near when it happened."

Devin tensed his jaw. As far as he was concerned,

Lee Wrexley was one of the lucky ones. When the world had started to crumble, Lee had been hidden and protected at his mother's workplace. From what Devin remembered, Lee had been off sick from school. His mom was a single mom and a guard at the Kansas State Prison. Things were already pretty messed up across the State and Devin understood why she had chosen to keep her son close, bringing him into work with her. As it turned out, it was the right choice. Lee sat safely in the guards' locker room as the world went to hell around him. Though he knew he shouldn't, Devin often felt jealous, bitter almost. Lee never had to fight his way to safety, and he never needed to kill anyone in order to survive.

"I've seen them on the camera monitors," Lee continued. "A shot to the head, right?"

"Is he serious?" Jack echoed Devin's own disbelief.

"You should do it. Drive him into the city and kick his ass out the car. See how he feels then."

"Jack," Devin warned.

"It's Jack?"

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Devin nodded. "He says your mom sends her love."

Lee sighed. "She thinks I'm such a kid. I'm sixteen."

I should be the one protecting her and—" He stopped as Devin raised his hand and looked back at the gas station.

"What?"

"Dev?" Jack and Lee said together.

Devin frowned, something was off. He shook his

head and tried to ignore the unsettling feeling that crawled over his skin. "Nothing. Look, forget the cars. We need to get back," he told them both. "We'll be attracting unwanted attention."

"Fine," Lee said with a smirk, and gave an animated salute as he bounded off ahead.

"Lee," Devin called after him and gave a frustrated sigh as the young man put distance between them. "Fuck."

Adjusting his grip on the gas cans, he quickened his pace.

"Lee," he called again, abruptly stopping as he saw something move out the corner of his eye. He gripped the handles of the gas cans more tightly as he looked anxiously around. His attention was drawn to a shock of red rushing toward them across the space between the diner and the car.

"Lee!"

Lee stopped and turned, frantically grabbing at the weapon hanging at his side as he saw too late what Devin already had.

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"Fuck." Devin dropped the gas and ran, drawing his gun to aim at the confusion of movement. He watched two bodies collide and fall out of sight behind the SUV. "Shit."

He ran as fast as he could. It was mere seconds, but the moment felt like an eternity as he rounded the car, skidded across the dirt, and fell roughly to his knees. He looked hopelessly at the mangle of red in front of him, and raised his gun.

Blood gurgled up and out of Lee's mouth and

covered the collar of his pale colored T-shirt, as teeth ripped into his throat. He struggled with the weight lying across his body, his fingers catching in a tangle of dirt-matted hair as he yanked back the growling boy's face. Lee lifted the boy higher, his eyes widening as the teenager's forehead violently exploded and blood splattered across his face. Devin had taken his shot.

Devin lowered his gun and started toward Lee.

Nervously, he looked around. More would come soon,

drawn in by the sound of the gunshot and the smell of fresh blood. He focused on where Lee had fallen. The youngster shoved at the dead boy's shoulders and toppled him from off his lap. Devin glanced down at the pale, blood-smeared face of the teenage monster, whose swollen lips hung awkwardly to one side. He looked over the boy's red, marching band uniform, which was torn and caked in grime 12

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and blood. The twisted, wire frame of glasses hung around the boy's neck, and sunlight glinted off mangled and bloody metal braces which lined his teeth. A fresh trail of dark, thick blood rolled down his forehead as he stared

sightlessly up at the clear blue sky. Cautiously, Devin kicked at his thigh. The boy was dead, and for good this time. A choking cough suddenly drew his attention,

snapping him back to the bloody reality of their situation.

Lee. He quickly crouched down and pressed his hand over Lee's shredded throat. It wasn't going to help stop the bleeding. Too much blood had already pooled around him in the dirt.

"Stay with me, kid." Devin wrapped his hand more tightly around Lee's in a desperate attempt to do something.

He lied, "You'll be fine. Okay?" He lowered his head and looked at the dark liquid collecting beside his boot. Lee's fingers curled around his. "It's gonna be fine." He watched as Lee opened his mouth as if to say something, but instead blood coughed up and ran down his jaw in viscous lumps.

It wasn't right. It had been the kid's first time outside the walls of the place they had come to call home.

In an attempt to comfort the boy, Devin laid a hand across Lee's sweat-coated forehead. There was nothing more to do. He watched Lee's eyes roll back in his skull, as the boy's other hand fisted in the dry, dirt ground.

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"Shit, Lee." Devin dropped his head and closed his eyes as he listened to Lee struggle to breathe. He waited, finally opening his eyes as Lee's hand went limp in his and the boy took his final breath. "Sorry, kid." Devin slowly got to his feet and stared down into Lee's eyes. They were already beginning to lose their color. Holding his gun out in front of him, Devin aimed it at Lee's head. He should already have taken the shot.

Awkwardly, Devin swallowed back the guilt rising

from his gut. He knew he shouldn't, but he waited. Maybe this time it would be different. He gripped the gun tightly, praying he wouldn't need to use it. Just this once, he wished for death to be permanent, and then he wouldn't have to take Lee's body home to his mom with a gaping bullet hole in his forehead. Devin narrowed his eyes and continued to stare at the dead boy. Lee was a bloody torn mess. Devin hesitated. Could it be different? No. There it was, just like always. Devin flinched as fingers wrapped around his ankle. Lee's eyes were wide and hungry, as his head jolted roughly to one side and his teeth snapped madly together.

Devin pushed any doubt from his mind and took his aim.

He wished it could have been different this time. He fired a single round, muting Lee's anguished cry as the back of his head was blown out across the dirt.

"Devin!" Devin was suddenly aware of Jack yelling 14

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in his ear. He had heard the commotion, the shot, and the cries. "Devin! Fuck. Are you there?"

Devin reached down and started dragging Lee's body to the rear of the car.

"Devin!"

"I'm here," Devin finally said, as he gently lowered Lee's head to the ground and glanced over at the dropped gas cans.

"What the hell happened?" Jack asked. There was panic in his voice.

Devin looked down at the dead boy as he secured his weapon at his thigh. This wasn't supposed to have happened like this. He sighed, rubbed a hand over his jaw, and said, "We're coming home."

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CHAPTER 2

Devin was standing alone. His arms were folded

across his chest and his eyes were fixed on the large notice board that resided in the locker room of the Kansas State Penitentiary. He leaned forward and scanned the dozens of newspaper clippings that covered the board. He read some of the headlines and smirked at some of the annotated notes he found around the edges of the collaged pieces of paper.

The last dated article was from almost nine months ago.

The newspaper reported outbreaks of violence and a

widespread flu-like epidemic on the eastern coast. Little did the journalist of the article know then what would become of the United States just two months later.

"Put me fifty on the Apocalypse."

Startled, Devin spun around. "Jack." He looked down at his friend.

"What gets your bet?" Jack asked.

Turning, Devin studied the handwritten notes. Each

line stated a different reason for the events going on around them. He looked down the list—the Apocalypse, a mutated flu virus, a government conspiracy, terrorism, the military, an act of God, or one too many scientists trying to be God.

Those were the more serious suggestions.

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"I'll take reality TV turning our brains to mush,"

Devin finally decided. It didn't matter what he chose. He doubted there was a soul alive who had the real answer. He just knew how it spread, through blood and saliva.

Jack laughed and maneuvered the chair he was

sitting in through the door and into the room. Folding his gloved hands in his lap, he looked up at his friend. "I thought I'd see how you were."

What did Jack expect to hear? Devin stared through

the notice board. He wished he could start the day over and scratch the sound of Kerry Wrexley's despairing sobs from his mind. He hadn't known what to say to her. What was the man who just shot her son through the forehead

supposed to say? It had been a simple exercise that ended in tragedy. There had been no sightings of infected in the area for the last week. He thought it was safe. He thought he could keep the kid safe.

"Dev."

Devin met his friend's dark eyes. He knew what was

coming.

"It's not your fault." Those damn words. "You couldn't have known what was going to happen."

Shaking his head, Devin said solemnly, "I should've known. I shouldn't have let him run ahead like that. I knew something didn't feel right."

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"You're not psychic," Jack pointed out. "If you were, I'd be out walking the perimeter. Instead, I'm sitting in this damn thing."

Devin looked at the wheelchair and then to the two

covered stumps where Jack's legs had once been. Two months ago, an attack from an infected dog had left Devin with no choice but to remove the torn, infected flesh at the knees. "I'm sorry," was all Devin could manage.

"Dude, I'd be dead, or worse one of those freaks,"

he said as he leaned back in his chair and spun around.

"Better this."

Devin was tempted to agree. Whatever the virus's

origin, the monsters it created were very real. Zombies were what the news stations called them before the

networks went down. The virus killed and then reignited life, or at least a small part of it. It was just enough so those once dead had some basic functions, enough to be up and walking about. It was hard to describe them as anything else. Something no longer human lurked behind their eyes as they sought out the freshest source of food, the living.

"You sure?" Devin said flatly. The guilt of what happened that day still had him waking in a cold sweat at times.

"Would I rather you'd left it long enough for the infection to spread through my body, kill me, and then have 18

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me wake up wanting to rip out your throat, for you to then shoot me in the head?" Jack had that look. The look that told Devin to shut the hell up or, despite his situation, Jack would find a way to kick his ass.

"How's Kerry?" Devin asked as he cleared his throat.

Jack dropped his chair forward and tensed his jaw.

"As you'd expect. She's angry, but I don't think it's totally aimed at you." He drew his mouth into a thin line as he ran a hand over his closely-shaved head. His eyes softened.

"Shooting her kid in the head probably means you should give her a wide berth for a little while."

"There was nothing I could do. He came out of

nowhere. Some fucking marching band freak," Devin said angrily. "He was taken out by a school boy." He closed his eyes as he remembered the boy's bright red uniform, blond, matted hair, and blood-coated mouth. Where had he even come from? He opened his eyes and looked at Jack. He tried to remember what his friend was like before the dog attack. He had known Jack for years, since they first joined the army together as recruits straight out of high school.

They were eventually posted together in Afghanistan, and having done their duty, seen and dealt with some horrible crap, they came home and tried to get on with their lives.

While Devin decided to go to college, study, graduate, and 19

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then set up a business in private security, Jack went back to serving his country and its people by enrolling in the police force. It was amazing and disheartening to see how much the guy's appearance had changed in the last nine months.

Jack had been just shy of six feet tall with black, curly hair, dark brown eyes, and olive skin. The first difference was the hair, and just days ago he'd shaved off his mass of dark curls. His skin was a little paler and his eyes were tired and dull. But Devin knew one thing hadn't changed. Jack would always have his back.

"So, I hear you're planning another run. And by yourself this time."

Devin met Jack's concerned eyes. "It's for the best."

"Being alone?" Jack started to get that look again.

"I don't want to be responsible anymore," Devin admitted tiredly.

"But we need you to be," Jack said. "You know that."

"I don't know shit, Jack." He felt useless. "I don't understand how any of this is real. The undead? Zombies? I know as much as you. Shoot them in the head and destroy their fucking brain." He knew he sounded agitated, but he couldn't help but snap at his friend.

"You're combat trained, hasn't that helped?"

"Like it helped you?" He looked at his friend and 20

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shook his head. "I know how to shoot. So does half the population."

"Yeah and how many of them actually survived?"

Jack asked. "We've got maybe twenty people here who know their way around firearms, another ten, fifteen that can make do, and then nearly thirty people who have never picked up a gun in their lives."

"Then they'll learn."

Jack sighed and started fidgeting with the wheels of his chair. "And for that we need you. Can you imagine Emily ever picking up a gun?"

Devin pressed his lips into a firm line before

pointing out, "Emily can't."

"No, but she doesn't have to be afraid because she can't. She's got you. That's the point. You can't stop being responsible for her, and you won't stop being responsible for the rest of them either. I know that, and you know that."

Devin straightened up and glanced back at the

notice board. "Maybe. But it doesn't mean I want that responsibility out there. I thought I could handle this crap."

He looked hopelessly at Jack. "I got it wrong. I didn't listen to my instincts, and I let myself get distracted. Lee paid the price for that."

"Lee shouldn't have run off without you. I've read the report you handed to Corden. Despite what you think, 21

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it's not your fault." Jack started to turn his chair around in the small space. He must have known he was wasting his time. "Look, I suggest you get yourself something to eat, and then get some rest. You'll need your head straight for tomorrow."

"Fine," Devin agreed. "But I need to see Emily first."

"Okay, but after," Jack said as he eased himself back through the narrow doorway. "See you get some sleep."

As if he was going to argue. Devin gave a tired nod and watched as Jack wheeled himself out of the guard's room. He had been running on empty for weeks. He

couldn't sleep, and even if he could, he wasn't sure he wanted to. What little sleep he had managed to get in the last couple of months had been filled with bad dreams and things he didn't need reminding of. With a sigh, he unfolded his arms and crammed his hands into the pockets of his dark jeans. Seeing Emily would make him feel better.

It always did.

* * * *

"I know you're there."

Devin didn't say anything at first. Instead, he stood 22

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and watched his sister work. Her delicate fingers ran in a smooth line across the thick paper, picking out the raised details of the page.

"I said, I know," Emily repeated impatiently and raised her head to look in Devin's direction.

"You always do," Devin finally said and walked up to her, wrapping his arms around her waist and laying a gentle kiss to her cheek. "What's that?"

"Jack's most recent blood work. No sign of

infection," she said and pushed the results across the desk.

"Although, I knew that twenty minutes ago. I had my little sidekick read it out to me."

"You didn't wait for the printer?"

"I have no patience. But you know that." Emily turned around in Devin's arms and raised her hand to his face. "You need a shave," she noted as she ran her fingers over the prickly stubble across Devin's jaw. "I'm told blonds and facial hair don't always mix."

Devin hugged Emily closer and rested his chin on

the top of her head. The solid feel of her in his arms already made him feel a little better. "I'll take that under advisement."

"You should. I told Jack about his too. It's all scratchy." She paused. Could she hear him grinning? "You have a filthy mind," she uttered.

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

"Hey, what you and Jack get up to is nothing to do with me. I just hope one day he makes an honest woman of you." He had introduced Jack to his sister almost fifteen years ago, when they were still in high school. Devin hadn't known it then, but Jack and Emily had kept in contact over the years and before he knew it she was moving to Kansas City to be with him and had an engagement ring on her finger.

Emily blushed and tucked a loose strand of her dark blonde hair behind her ear. The diamond in her ring caught the light. "You should shower. You smell."

Devin laughed. "Thanks."

"I'm your sister. If I can't be honest...?" She shrugged. "Besides, you should listen to me. I'm older and wiser," she added with a smile.

"Definitely older," Devin agreed and braced himself for a slap.

"Twelve minutes," she reminded him and pushed at his arms, freeing herself from his hold.

Only twelve minutes? Devin watched his sister

return to her work. It was strange how he always felt like the younger brother. He was a grown man, thirty-two years of age, and yet one firm word from Emily and he felt like a reprimanded teenager again. It seemed like there were years between them rather than minutes. She had always 24

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

been protective of him, especially when it came to their parents. She could do no wrong, whereas he was the

complete opposite.

"How's your pet?" he decided to ask. He had dwelled far too long on uncomfortable memories for one day.

"You mean John? He's grabby," she said with a chuckle.

"He has a name now?" Devin said with a frown.

"Seemed only right."

"Doesn't make him any more human," Devin said bitterly.

Emily lifted her head. She pursed her lips, looking annoyed. Her pale blue eyes focused over his left shoulder.

"It's not his fault. He is what he is."

Devin stayed silent and watched his sister. Her eyes were a paler shade than his own, though he couldn't remember if they had always been that way. At five years old, Emily had contracted meningitis when a sinus

infection had turned to something more serious, and she lost her sight. They both knew how much worse it could have been. At least he still had his sister.

"But then I don't suppose you'd agree with that."

She reached out to him across the bench she worked at.

"That it's not his fault."

25

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

He wasn't stupid. He knew what she was doing. The

news of Lee's death would have spread quickly among the group. Devin took a step back and looked around the building's infirmary. He remembered why he liked this room. It was so bright and clean.

"Didn't think so," Emily said as she cleared her throat and pulled back her hand.

"Why do you keep him alive? Dead? Whatever the hell he is?" Devin tried to steer the conversation back to John.

Emily shrugged. "It's not my call. You know that.

Corden feels that maybe one day John could help us."

Devin watched as his sister moved around the

bench, feeling out the hard edge as she made her way to the other side.

"Maybe he could help us find a cure."

"There is no cure," he stated. "And you know that.

Five months you've been stuck in this room. You've got nothing."

"I wouldn't say nothing," she disagreed. "I know what doesn't work." She gave a wry smile. She must know that small fact was not at all comforting. There was only one real solution to the problem. Shoot them in the head, or do whatever it took to destroy the brain and sever the small spark of life. The reanimated corpses would then return to 26

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

nothing more than dead, rotting flesh.

Devin continued to watch as Emily felt out the drawers in the front of the large desk.

"You probably know what I'm going to say." Emily didn't need her sight to see her brother. He had always been an open book where she was concerned. "We can't give up.

You never have, and neither will I."

"You didn't let me," he pointed out.

"Perhaps," she agreed. "But you have to stop blaming yourself for every little thing. Lee, Jack..." She paused. "Connor."

The last name stung at Devin's heart. Emily should

know better. Devin folded his arms across his chest and rolled back his head to stare up at the fluorescent strip in the ceiling. They had been lucky the penitentiary had its own generators, he thought, happy to distract himself from the conversation. Where had the months gone? He

remembered the first time they had heard a voice over Jack's police radio and the feelings of relief and

apprehension at finding other survivors.

"And you can stop ignoring me," she continued, snapping Devin out of his memory. "You need to get your head straight."

"You can't call them little things," he finally said.

"Lee's dead, Jack's in a chair and—"

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

"Connor is the one that got away," Emily finished for him.

Devin swallowed uncomfortably and shifted his position. He didn't need reminding. For months he had been trying to forget.

"You couldn't shoot him. Well, not in the head anyway." Emily must realize how hurt Devin still was.

"You loved him."

Devin closed his eyes. It seemed like a lifetime ago.

How had things changed so much in only a few months?

He had been happy and in love. He had everything he ever wanted. Then, in a blink of an eye, it was all gone.

"Have you ever wondered where he is?" Emily continued. "Running wild and free?"

"No," he said as he opened his eyes and dropped his head forward to look at his sister. He didn't want to think about it. It was better to accept that Connor was gone and never coming back. "And I hope I never see him again, because I don't think I could miss a second time."

Emily sighed as she pulled open the drawer and

reached inside, feeling for something. "I've wondered if I should give you this," she said as she pulled a metal chain from the drawer and caught the spinning pendant between her finger and thumb. "You asked me to look after this for you a long time ago." She held out her hand to encourage 28

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Devin to take it from her. "You swore one day you'd ask Connor to marry you and run away to Canada together. It was Grandpa's, right? His ring?"

Devin watched as Emily released the ring and let it spin on the end of the gold chain it was threaded on. He had not forgotten.

"Devin?" Emily waited for him to say something.

"Devin?"

He looked longingly at the ring, remembering sadly

the life he'd had before this nightmare broke out. That life was gone. There was nothing else to say. "Goodnight, Emmi," he managed and quickly walked away. He stopped at the door and glanced back over his shoulder. Emily was standing beside the desk with her hand closed around the ring.

"Goodnight," she said quietly. Whether she knew he was still there, Devin wasn't sure, but he watched as she slid the ring back into the drawer of her desk. He could remember the day he gave it to her. Their mother had begrudgingly carried out their grandfather's wish for him to have the gold wedding band. He had known Connor for about six months then, yet he already knew Connor was the man he wanted to share the rest of his life with. As it was, they'd had three years before the world went to hell.

Finally, he stepped out into the hallway and walked 29

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

over to one of the large windows. Narrowing his eyes, he stared out at the dusk sky and the large silver moon that was creeping from behind the horizon. For nine months he refused to think about Connor. It hurt too much to try and guess where Connor was, whether he was alive or dead.

Devin leaned his head against the cool glass. Connor wasn't alive. He knew that, and he would never forget it. He would always remember the rage and hunger in Connor's eyes from that morning. But that wasn't the Connor he wanted to remember, and yet it was the one memory he could never forget.

"Idiot," he chided himself and turned away from the window. Dwelling on things that couldn't be changed was pointless. There were people here who counted on him, people who were alive. Rubbing tiredly at his face, Devin decided he needed to get some sleep. Emily and Jack were right. He needed a clear head if he was going to be of use to anyone tomorrow. He glanced at the door that led back into the infirmary and gave a sad smile. "Night, sis."

30

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

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CHAPTER 3

"No way." Devin folded his arms across his chest and adamantly shook his head. "You can forget it." He looked at the woman standing defiantly in front of him.

"No."

"I'm going with you," Kerry Wrexley insisted, as she lowered the large pack she carried to the ground and rested it against the SUV. She folded her arms and matched Devin's stance. "I don't care what you say."

"Why?" Devin didn't understand how her going outside would achieve anything. "There's nothing for you out there."

Kerry fixed her narrowed eyes on Devin's. "My boy died out there. He's wanted to help fight these things since the minute he turned sixteen. But now he can't, and I want to take his place."

Devin looked Kerry up and down. Before things

went to shit she had been a guard here at the penitentiary, and from what he had seen and heard, it seemed she was quite capable of handling herself. She was one of nineteen survivors to remain at the prison—fourteen inmates, four guards, and Lee. The stories they had shared were just as harrowing as everyone else's. A guard had collapsed in the 31

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

yard, sick from a bite he'd received in an altercation at a bar the previous night. He turned and attacked several inmates and staff, before being put down. The remaining guards contained the people he'd infected in the yard. The warden made a difficult decision, and gave everyone the same choice. Stay or go. And the gates were closed behind them, Kerry and the others were the only ones to remain. But the controlled workings of the prison and the chaos out there were two very different things to deal with.

Shaking his head, he decided, "I don't think it's a good idea."

"Thing is, Devin, you don't get to think. I already cleared it with Corden. I'm your partner on this one."

Devin's jaw tightened as he searched her emerald

green eyes. Did she really want to do this? "What happened to Lee, I am sorry," he said slowly and clearly. He must have said it a dozen times since he returned with Lee's body.

Kerry cleared her throat and averted her eyes. "I don't blame you. You don't have to worry about me. I just want to do something." She raised her head and met his eyes again with a fiery determination that matched the flame-red coloring of her hair. "I need to do something."

And there it was. Devin gave a heavy sigh as he

pinched the bridge of his nose. He could feel the guilt 32

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

bubbling in his gut and stinging the back of his throat. He felt responsible for Lee and now he was going to be responsible for her. "You understand what's out there?"

"Yes," Kerry said firmly. "I'm under no illusions."

"Okay. But you do exactly as I say. You screw up, you're dead. And that's if you're lucky. No second chances."

He watched Kerry closely. What the hell was he doing?

Kerry smiled a sweet smile. The ten years she had

on Devin melted away behind wide eyes and dimples. "Of course," she said innocently. "You're the boss."

Devin pressed his lips together. Somehow he

doubted it this time. "Just get in the car," he said, noting how Kerry turned away and left the pack she had brought with her. "Great," he grumbled to himself as he picked it up and walked around the car.

Throwing the pack in the trunk, he closed the back

of the SUV with a loud thud and looked around. It was early and only a few other people were up and about, most of them checking out some of the couple of dozen vehicles parked in the fenced-off yard. A small group of men were working on one of the two prison buses. He watched the hypnotic spark of the welding torch for a moment as they worked to reinforce the bus's wheel arches.

Two months ago, he and Jack had taken the bus to

the far side of Topeka in search of survivors. It was then 33

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

the walking, rotted corpse of a Doberman had ripped viciously through the material of Jack's pants in search of flesh and bone. Devin took a deep breath as he tore himself from the memory. The nightmares were enough without having his waking moments plagued by old and new

atrocities. Disheartened, he looked through the back of what he had come to think of as his SUV, and watched Kerry's outline for a moment. This was a bad idea. He didn't want another partner.

"So, where are we going?" Kerry's head appeared out the passenger side window. She looked curiously at him as he made no immediate move to join her in the car. "We are heading out, right?"

Devin made a low noise as he cleared his throat.

"Of course," he said as he rounded the car and got in the driver's side. He gave Kerry a sideward glance, and silently cursed Corden for agreeing to this as he pulled on his belt.

"So, where to?" she asked again, giving him a smile as she started to twist a curl of her red hair around one of her fingers. Her short, bitten nails were painted a pale shade of pink, though it couldn't have been recently as the edges were chipped and peeling.

"A small city eighty miles out," he said as he started the engine. "It's getting too dangerous to stay local. It's like they know we're here." The prison was situated in the 34

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

north-west of Kansas, away from major cities and the larger packs of infected. It was secure for the most part, though some freaks did

occasionally stray into the area, drawn in by the activity of returning vehicles.

"I heard the group at the north border was... lost,"

she said reluctantly.

"It was a stupid mistake. One got in. Just one."

Devin hadn't been there, but he had heard the horrific stories from a group that had headed out that way.

Everyone was dead, or worse. Devin put the car in drive and pulled out of the parking bay. He rolled the car up to the large metal gates and waited for the two armed men, who were standing guard, to open them. The gears of the mechanism clattered and whined as the gates were pushed apart to give a clear view of the hundred yard driveway. As they rolled through the gates, he looked up, and squinted at the sun sitting high in the sky. On the roof of the building he noted the three rifles aimed down toward the main gates.

"You ready?" he asked.

Kerry took a deep breath and gripped her seatbelt

tightly. Startled, she looked over her shoulder as the gates closed behind them with a metallic clunk, securing the yard. "Are they outside?" She turned to look at the high, outer stone wall at the far end of the drive.

"Some," he confirmed as he drove toward the 35

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

second gate. During the early hours of the morning a small group of infected had appeared outside the main gate. "You might want to roll up your window." He guided the car a few yards short of the second gate and leaned out of his driver's side window to enter the necessary four-digit code.

Sitting back, he rolled up his window and waited as the electric gate whirled into life.

"Shit!" Kerry flinched as pale, blood-covered arms appeared abruptly through the gap in the gates.

The bloodied arms quickly made way for equally

bloodied faces, all at different stages of rot and

decomposition. Devin grimaced as he looked at the

youngest of the faces. The girl couldn't be more than ten years old. Her jaw was dislocated, and it hung awkwardly open as her mouth snapped together over and over.

"My God," Kerry said breathlessly as the gate continued to open and the infected rushed forward. Two of the animated corpses moved quickly past the SUV, and a third walked into the front of the vehicle, hitting it with a thud before dragging its boney, battered fingers down the front of the SUV's hood. It was a gruesome sight. Chunks of flesh were missing from the dead man's arms and

shoulders, blood had soaked through the front of his wife beater, and his eyes seemed swollen and too big for their sockets.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

"Hold on," Devin warned, revving the engine as the gates finally opened all of the way. The dead man

continued to claw at the front of the car, despite the warning. A thud against the rear of the car made Devin look over his shoulder. The engine had attracted the other two freaks to the car, and they began to paw with bloody hands at the rear window. "And I just got this thing detailed." He grinned. Kerry, however, didn't look amused.

"Can we go now?" Kerry asked in a strained voice.

She flinched as three pairs of hands scraped and clawed at the car, looking for a way in.

Devin gave a low chuckle. "Sure," he said and pressed the accelerator.

The hungry monster was nudged to one side until

the soft body snagged the corner of the car and stumbled to the ground. Once they had cleared the gates, Devin didn't stop. Gunshots rang out behind them as the gates started to close and the infected were picked off by the snipers on the roof. He glanced at Kerry, her face was pale as she chewed on her fingernail, and he noticed sadly how her freckles stood out against her skin, just like Lee's had. Two more infected appeared from the right and started chasing after the car. Depending on the state of their bodies, the freaks could move damn fast, but not that fast. He accelerated and the car kicked up dust as he turned and headed for the main 37

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

highway.

"See," he said. "Easy."

* * * *

Garnett once had a population of over three

thousand people. It took the virus less than a day to reset that to zero. Pooling the knowledge of the survivors, Garnett and several other towns and small cities had stood out as prospective locations to search for supplies.

Originally, the group had kept north of Topeka, but the need for more resources was forcing them to search farther out, and now south of the city. Devin had been ordered to check out Garnett and its immediate area. He just hoped, with an initially smaller population, Garnett would still have some of the essential resources the group in Kansas needed. Fewer people also implied, though did not

guarantee, a lower risk of coming across any infected inhabitants.

Devin checked a sign on the side of the road. There were only a few miles to go. He glanced at the clock on the dash. They'd been driving for a little over an hour and he suddenly realized just how quiet Kerry had been.

"You okay?" he asked, breaking the silence. He figured it must have been months since she had seen the 38

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

world outside the prison walls. It was probably very strange and alien to her.

"It's so empty," she replied as she stared out the passenger window, though Devin seriously doubted she was enjoying the scenery. Apart from small pockets of abandoned vehicles, the highway was deserted. "How do you keep coming out here?"

Devin sighed and made the turn he'd been waiting

for. "Because someone has to. We have some facilities up and running, but there's so much we need. Medical stuff, gas, food, toilet paper," he said with an amused tone to his voice. "The highlight of last month was finding an apple tree with apples on it."

"I remember." She turned to look at Devin. "Lee wanted me to make an apple pie, but I had nothing to make the pastry," she said with a small laugh. "He was heartbroken."

Devin nodded. "Maybe this time," he said quietly, as he guided the car around the few vehicles abandoned on the road into Garnett. He reduced his speed as he headed for the center of town. "Keep your eye out for anything we could use."

"Right now, I care more about anything moving

around out there," Kerry said as she narrowed her eyes, scanning the building fronts and side streets.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

"Food first, and then we'll find the local clinic or ER," he decided as he eyed the buildings they passed.

"Yeah, sure," she said, though she was more focused with what was outside than any conversation inside the car.

Devin guided the SUV to the side of the road as he

spotted what he needed. Bumping the car up the sidewalk, he pulled on the handbrake and waited. If there was anything out there, the sound of the engine would likely attract it pretty quickly. He gave it a moment more.

"Clear for now." He turned off the engine. He leaned back and looked at Kerry. "You sure you want to do this?" he asked as he reached behind her seat and pulled out a shotgun.

Kerry met his eyes with a firm look. "I'm fine. Let's just do this."

Devin nodded and leaned forward to the glove box.

He opened it and took out a handgun and handed it to Kerry. "The head, remember?"

"I know," she said as she ejected the clip and checked the rounds. "I know." Kerry deftly reinserted the ammo and released the safety. She looked at Devin with large green eyes and took a deep, steadying breath. "Okay."

Devin cautiously got out of the car, and leaned against its metal frame as he assessed the lay of the land.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

The silence and deserted street were unsettling. "After you." He nodded toward the store as Kerry closed the door on her side.

Kerry stood and looked at the front of the store. It was hard to see inside. The sunlight reflected off the large glass windows across the front of the building.

Devin noticed her apprehension. With the shotgun

in his hand, he made the decision to take the lead. Slowly, he approached the large automatic door, but wasn't

surprised when it didn't open. He raised his free hand, cupping it against the glass as he peered inside. Cautiously at first, he reached for the door and gave it a firm nudge.

Though stiff, the door opened slightly with a groan. When nothing was drawn out by the noise, Devin pushed more forcefully, opening the door and stepping inside.

The store was made up of several long, undisturbed

aisles and Devin found it unnerving to find everything perfectly in place on the line of shelves. Sunlight cast an ethereal glow throughout the store, and Devin checked each aisle as he walked the width of the building. There was no evidence anyone, or anything, was there. He gave a sharp whistle and waved Kerry inside.

"Essentials," he reminded her as she entered the store.

"Of course," she agreed as she hungrily eyed the 41

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

rows of food in front of her. "Essentials."

Devin laughed to himself as Kerry strolled down the first aisle and let out a small squeal of excitement as she grabbed something off a shelf.

"God, I loved these," she said happily and held the bag of candy to her chest. "Gumdrops."

Devin smiled. It had been a long time since he had

seen someone genuinely happy about something as simple as candy. "Let's get a couple of carts," he suggested. "We shouldn't hang around too long. Just in case."

"Okay, I guess I'll start on the right and—"

"I'll take the left," he finished for her. "Ten minutes?"

"Sure. See you in ten."

They both grabbed a shopping cart and headed to

each end of the store. Devin sighed as he stared at the long line of alcohol. "Essentials," he said to himself, giving a smile as he heard Kerry's voice from the other side of the store listing a variety of luxury items she'd missed for the last nine months. He pushed the cart down the aisle, stopping briefly as he picked up a bottle of Jim Beam. One wouldn't hurt, he decided, and placed it in the cart. Now to collect the things they really needed.

Ten minutes passed quickly, and Devin returned to

the front of the store with his full cart. Standing in silence, 42

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Things

Meredith

Russell

he leaned back against one of the checkouts and watched the street outside. It was still the same empty street they had entered town on. He swallowed uncomfortably as his eyes fell to the bottom of the glass window. He hadn't noticed it before, but a dirty, red-brown handprint was smeared a foot from the ground.

"You nearly done?" he called. "We should make tracks."

Kerry appeared from one of the aisles with a shopping cart crammed with canned food and bottled drinks. "I think I got plenty, but we should come back here.

I can't believe how much stuff there is."

Devin took a final look around the store. He'd been on plenty of supply runs but he had never seen anything quite like this before. Usually stores were left in disarray by frantic people making desperate escapes. Here everything was perfect. He could only think of a couple of reasons, the town was evacuated, or the grimmer reality, the infection swept through the population at an exponential rate.

Nobody had the time to swing by and grab supplies. His heart clenched as he thought about how quickly the virus infected his friends and neighbors. Bites had spread through his neighborhood like wildfire. People turned and infected more people. That day Devin woke to a world of chaos, and on that same day, he lost Connor.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Clearing his throat, Devin tightened his grip on the cart. He shouldn't let himself get distracted. He had a job to do. "We can suggest it to Corden when we get back." He started, with his cart, toward the door. "We'll pack this up and then head across town."

They quickly steered their carts through the

checkout and out to the car, pulling the heavy glass door closed behind them. Letting go of her cart, Kerry drew the gun Devin had given her from her belt, and stood guard as Devin opened the trunk. He quickly started unloading the supplies and slung item after item into the back of the SUV.

"This place is starting to give me the creeps," she said quietly as she held the gun out in front of her. She bounced restlessly on the spot, until suddenly she reached into her jeans pocket, pulling out a purple scrunchie to tie back her hair. "That's better," she decided, relaxing a little now her long curls were swept back out of her face. She continued to scan the streets for anything moving.

"Right," Devin said as he shut the trunk and shoved the shopping carts back toward the store. "Time to go."

Kerry walked around to the passenger side. "We looking out for an ER or walk-in clinic next?" she asked as they got in the car.

Devin shook his head. "I grabbed a bunch of stuff from the medicine aisle. There's supposed to be a handful 44

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

of farms as we head out of town. A couple of the guys we picked up last month apparently worked out here one summer. I thought we could check out a couple and see if there's anything left alive out there. Produce, animals and the like."

Kerry fastened her belt and slid down in her seat. "If I get eaten by a zombie cow, know I will hurt you."

Devin grinned and turned on the engine. Though he

really hoped they didn't come across one, the idea of a zombie cow was somehow amusing.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

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CHAPTER 4

"Looks kind of pretty." Kerry arched an eyebrow as she and Devin got out of the car. "In an 'everybody's dead'

kind of way." She pursed her lips as she surveyed the property with a thoughtful eye. The farm and its

surrounding land, as with the store, appeared completely deserted and untouched by recent events. It was as if it had been preserved in a bubble for the last nine months away from the hell of everything else. "So if there is a cow that isn't a slobbering, undead zombie-freak how do you intend on getting it back?"

Devin sighed and looked at her over the hood of the car. "We secure it in one of the barns, or something, see if there's a trailer, and if not, radio for a bigger boat," he said with a smirk.

"Boat?"

Devin raised an eyebrow. "Jaws? The movie?"

Kerry simply shrugged.

"You're kidding, right?"

"Never saw it," Kerry confessed as she pulled on a short, gray jacket and tugged down the sleeves to cover her arms.

"We need to head back to town and find a video 46

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

store." He laughed and pushed the car door shut with a thud. The sun caused him to squint as he eyed the house. It was the first farm they had come across on their drive out of town. An uneasy feeling simmered in his gut, making him tighten his grip on the shotgun he held. "We'll start up at the house, okay? Stay close."

Kerry nodded, pulled out the handgun, and held it securely at her side. "I'm not letting you out of my sight," she assured him.

The main house stood at the end of a long, gravel path. A low, painted fence ran in a line across the front of the lawn, though Devin saw no real reason for it as both sides of the garden were wide-open and exposed. The house was made up from an older main building and a newer addition on the side. Flowerboxes full of blooms stood either side of the green, painted door.

Devin stopped as they reached the front of the house and hesitated before trying the door handle. He looked at Kerry before pushing open the unlocked door.

They entered the building in silence. Devin took the lead, leaving Kerry to guard the rear. They quickly cleared the ground floor, finding evidence of a struggle. Furniture had been disturbed, traces of blood lay on the living room floor, and the contents of several cupboards were scattered around the kitchen, but there was nobody there. No infected 47

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

and no living.

"Upstairs?" Kerry whispered and craned her neck to look at the staircase behind them.

Devin reluctantly made his way to the bottom of the stairs and looked up at the dark landing. Slowly, he edged upward, keeping his back to the wall as he focused straight ahead. He hated searching inside buildings. Closed spaces made things awkward, particularly if anything decided to hide in dark corners. At the top of the stairs, Devin warily looked from one closed door to the next.

"Pick a door, any door," he whispered and approached the first of them along the narrow hallway. He checked with Kerry, and gave a silent countdown as he turned the doorknob and pushed open the door.

Kerry aimed her gun into the room and frantically

searched for anyone hiding inside. She gave a relieved sigh as all she was faced with was an empty bathroom. She looked at Devin and nodded, before taking cautious steps to the next door.

Having cleared five rooms, Devin stood quietly in

the last they had entered at the back of the house. It was the master bedroom and to Devin it still felt lived in. The bed was unmade, and the bed sheets lay in a rumpled pile on one side. The room's floral drapes were neatly tied back and a small patch of condensation had collected in the 48

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

bottom corner of the window. Family photos and trinkets were spread across the top of a large, wooden dresser.

"I wonder if they're alive," Kerry mused as she picked up one of the frames containing a photograph of a family. "Parents and three kids, you think?" she asked about the picture.

Devin glanced at the image. He skimmed over their happy smiles and the warm family embrace they shared.

"Farmers have guns, right?"

Kerry gave a sad smile. "It'd be nice to think that."

She walked over to the window and looked outside. "But their truck's still out back."

"We should probably keep looking." Devin sighed as he looked out across the empty field and toward the line of trees at the end of the property. He felt weary as he stared at the broken fencing. If there had been any animals in the field, they were long gone. He rubbed tiredly at his brow and headed to the door. "Let's head outside," he said as he made his way along the hallway and back downstairs.

There were still some buildings to check, and maybe something had survived. Even if they found just one chicken, it would mean the trip hadn't been a total waste of their time. When he reached the bottom he looked back over his shoulder, and flashed Kerry a smile as he said,

"Let's see if we can't find you that zombie cow—"

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

"Devin!" Kerry screamed as dirty hands grabbed Devin's shoulders and dragged him from her sight, past the open front door, and to the living room floor. "Devin!"

Blunt teeth snapped madly inches away from

Devin's head, as he struggled with an infected male. The guy was strong, and Devin could barely hold off the weight of the crazed monster as it lay across his chest.

"Run!" he ordered as he fought to free his shotgun from beneath the dead man. "Get to the car."

Kerry hesitated, but did as she was told and ran

outside. Devin pushed hard against the man's chest and managed to put some space between them. Quickly, he pulled the weapon free and slammed the butt of the shotgun into the side of the man's head. Blood sprayed from already mangled flesh and the infected freak crashed to the floor beside him, momentarily dazed as it waved its limbs in limp circles. Devin got to his feet. He was breathing heavily as he pulled his handgun from the holster on his thigh and moved over the man. He brought his boot down on the man's throat, forcing his head down to the ground.

The man looked like he was in his fifties. The skin that met his receding hairline was hanging in loose lumps and one eye was sealed in a bloody mess.

"Devin!" The sound of the front door slamming made Devin flinch.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Focusing, Devin aimed and took his shot. A double

tap, and the freak's skull and brains exploded across the cream rug.

"Kerry?" He had told her to run. "What the hell?" he asked as he found Kerry crouching down behind the door. Her eyes were wide and sweat clung to her pale skin.

"I couldn't. There was no way," she said and pressed a hand to her chest.

Devin leaned over her and looked through the

peephole in the farmhouse door. He watched as two more freaks ran up the gravel path. They looked recently turned and moved easily toward the house. "Come with me," he said, and pulled Kerry to her feet.

"Where are we going?" she asked as she was guided by the hand through the living room and into the kitchen.

Devin pushed a finger to his lips, silencing her.

"Back door," he whispered, flinching as he heard loud pounding from the front of the house. He held onto his 9mm handgun and handed Kerry the shotgun. He leaned close to the door and peered through the frosted glass pane, before he silently opened the door. Satisfied there was no one around, he motioned for Kerry to follow him outside.

Softly, he pulled the door closed behind them and crouched down at the back of the house.

"Do you trust me?" he asked Kerry, meeting her 51

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Things

Meredith

Russell

frightened eyes as she kneeled beside him.

"What do you mean?" Kerry moved closer.

There was a commotion inside the house and Devin

securely wrapped his hand around the door handle. It sounded like the infected had managed to get through the front door as a crashing sound echoed through an open window.

"Do you trust me?" he said again, slowly but clearly.

Kerry looked into his eyes and seemed to find

whatever it was she needed to see. "I trust you."

In a low voice, he said, "Take the car keys. You go ahead and get inside. Lock yourself in if you have to."

"But—"

"I'm not arguing with you." He pushed the keys into the palm of her hand and took the shotgun from her. He gently touched her shoulder and nodded. "It'll be okay." He waited for her to nod in agreement and then slowly leaned up to look inside. Something was definitely moving around in there. "You ready?" he checked as he ducked back down beside her.

"Aim for the head," she reminded herself and blew out a steadying breath.

"That, or shoot out their legs," Devin said as he continued to securely hold the door shut. "You go first. I'll 52

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

be right behind you." Kerry hesitated. "Go." Devin nudged her toward the corner of the house. "Don't look back."

Nodding, Kerry quickly got to her feet and ran the

length of the building. She had a head start on Devin, who let her go several yards, before releasing the door handle and chasing after her. He maintained the distance as they ran from the cover of the building and along the edge of the garden. It was going to be okay.

"Devin!" Damn. Kerry pointed toward the busted front door of the farmhouse. Two blurs of torn material and flesh rushed out onto the path. Rage and hunger radiated from the roaring monsters as they ran, uninhibited toward them.

"Run!" he ordered as the blood smeared faces came into focus. He stopped and took his aim, narrowing his eyes as he traced the path of one of the infected monsters closing in on Kerry. The sound of his heart was beating loudly in his ears as he dropped the shotgun and wrapped both hands around his 9mm. He steadied his hand and fired two

rounds. The living corpse fell hard into the dirt as it was hit.

One shot impacted its shoulder and the second pierced the base of its skull. It wasn't going to get up again.

Kerry took advantage of the commotion and turned

to aim her own weapon. The second freak was closer than she'd probably expected. She nervously fumbled with the 53

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

handgun, and quickly squeezed the trigger. Nothing happened. Had the gun jammed?

"Run!" Devin roared as Kerry quickly tried to back away. Her feet crossed over themselves as she stumbled and fell backward against the car door. "Fuck," he hissed.

Focusing on the second monster, he took a breath and fired.

The animated corpse let out an anguished whine as the round blasted through its jaw. Dazed, it fell to the ground, half-breaking its fall with its mangled arms. It raised its deformed head and reached out for Kerry. The rotted body twisted as it tried to drag itself in her direction. Instantly, Kerry was on her feet. In a moment of clarity, she released the magazine and reinserted it. Pulling back the slide, she cleared the chamber and aimed down at the fallen monster's head. She took the shot, flinching as a round was released and the danger was put down.

Retrieving the shotgun, Devin holstered his pistol

and looked across to where Kerry was standing, looking shaken. He stopped and stared curiously at his partner. Her eyes widened as she waved her gun in his direction and shouted his name. What the hell? He turned around. It was as if he had been hit in the gut with a sledgehammer. Half a dozen freaks rushed in his direction from the field behind the farmhouse. Where the hell had they come from? He lifted the shotgun as he began to retreat. Keeping his eyes

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

on the charging monsters, he fired into the mass of bodies.

Flesh was stripped from bone as the shell blasted through the oncoming attack. Pulling back the slide of the pump-action shotgun, Devin chambered a second round and fired again, winging what looked like a teenage boy as the wild youth's legs gave out and he skidded across the dirt ground.

His third and final shot brought down a large, well-fed hulk of a man. The exploding shell ripped through the guy's upper torso and severed his spine.

Devin glanced over his shoulder to see Kerry

running around to the driver's side.

"Hurry!" she yelled.

Devin discarded the empty shotgun and broke into a

sprint. He was only several yards from the car when he was suddenly knocked off balance by a heavy weight. It came out of nowhere. Another freak had rushed in from Devin's left-hand side and sent him sprawling across the unkempt lawn of the front garden. Clearing his vision, Devin flipped onto his back and desperately tried to scurry away. There were three of them now. The first had been joined by the remaining two monsters that had made it across the field; the ones with the strongest desire to reach their food. He had only a short moment's reprieve as they spontaneously burst into a frenzied battle with one another. Each was eager to claim Devin as their own. Suddenly, one of the 55

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

three broke free from the scuffle, rushing at Devin as he fought to get to his feet and away to safety.

He didn't get far. A blow struck his lower back and he fell headfirst across the lawn. With a painful grunt, Devin hit the ground, his head smacking off a decorative stone that edged one of two flowerbeds. Dazed, he tried to roll over and free his gun from its holster, but he was set upon by the hungry hands of one of his pursuers. His head was forced down to the ground and he could hear the terrible sound of teeth and fingernails tearing at the back of the padded jacket he wore. Frantically, he lashed out and struggled to get away, catching sight of Kerry as she rushed to the front of the car.

Kerry raised her gun. "Come on!" she cried and emptied the magazine over Devin's head. She didn't get the head shots she needed. Hell, she barely even slowed them down. Her rounds sliced through the rotted flesh of Devin's pursuers, impacting chests, stomachs and thighs. It was not enough to stop them. The hungry freaks continued to close in on Devin. "I'm out. Run—" She was cut short as she was surprised from behind and pushed to the ground. A large guy leapt over Kerry and ran in Devin's direction. He was going to die. Or worse, become just like them, a freak.

Devin awkwardly rolled over and looked down as
the attacking monster dragged itself up his legs.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Hopelessly, he pushed at the dead man's shoulders. His fingers sunk into warm flesh and he gagged as material and skin peeled away from the freak's arms. Yellow blisters covered the left side of the man's face, and his lips and cheek had been eaten away. With broken, bloody teeth, the man lunged at Devin's chest and neck, narrowly missing as Devin squirmed beneath his weight. Devin caught his breath as he struggled to hold off the heavy body

bearing down on him. The other freaks were on their feet and moving toward him. The guy who'd appeared from behind Kerry stopped beside him and Devin stared at the guy's dirty sneakers and ripped pants. Leaning back his head, he closed his eyes. This was it. He just hoped, somehow, it would be over quickly.

"Devin!" Kerry screamed.

The weight on his chest inexplicably eased, and

when the pain and blood he anticipated never came, Devin opened his eyes. The unexpected savior wrapped his blood-covered hands around the pale neck of Devin's would-be killer and dragged it, wildly growling to the ground. Devin rolled his head to one side as the sound of a neck snapping echoed beside him. What the hell? He stared at the lifeless eyes of the dead man. Devin didn't understand. He

cautiously leaned up on his elbows. Shaken and surprised, he caught his breath. He watched as teeth snapped and fists 57

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

thrashed, and three bodies collided in an all out brawl only a few feet away. Slowly, he moved backward across the grass, and gasped as his wrist gave out. Giving an

anguished grunt, he did his best to sit up and narrowed his eyes as he watched the fighting men. For a while it was hard to distinguish one bloody limb from another as the fight moved backward across the garden. However, very quickly a clear victor emerged.

The large, dirty man, who had rescued Devin mere

moments ago, pounded ruthlessly into the soft bodies and blood sprayed across the white, painted fence. One of the monsters fell down in a bloody mess, dead for good this time as its neck was twisted unnaturally back until its head hung limply to one side. The second was dragged sideways and straddled as it hit the ground. Fists pummeled into its face, splintering skull and bone until there was no face left.

Devin lay on the ground and stared fearfully across at the remaining man as he got to his feet. Blood and flesh hung in sticky lumps from his curled knuckles and he stared at Devin from beneath dark, matted bangs. The guy was tall and well built, if not a little undernourished, his unkempt hair hung over his face, and his clothes were stained with fresh blood and dirt. Devin looked at the marks across the man's skin and the familiar scabbed patterns of teeth marks. Fear caught in his throat as he 58

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

opened his mouth. Keeping his eyes on the man, he felt the ground around him in search of a weapon.

"Devin, you okay?" Kerry called breathlessly. She got to her feet and rushed to his side. She raised her gun with trembling hands as she took in the man's appearance.

Something flickered behind her eyes. It was the realization this man had been bitten. Old scars and fresh blood marked the man's arms and neck. He was surely another monster.

The man took a step toward them and Devin eyed

him curiously. Something was different. It was as if Kerry sensed it too. She dipped her gun for a brief moment, hesitating before taking her aim and

squeezing the trigger.

"No!" shouted Devin, too late as the shot rang out.

The man didn't go down. Instead, he raised his hand and pressed it to his forehead. The sight of fresh blood across his palm caused him to stumble sideways. His legs gave out and with a grunt, he fell and hit the ground.

"What did I do?" Kerry said, flustered as she dropped her gun. "He was bitten, right?"

Devin nodded. The guy had definitely been bitten.

Crap. Panic hit him like a freight train as he ran his hands over his neck, shoulders, and down his arms. His jacket was torn and stained, but it wasn't by his blood. He was okay. He closed his eyes and fell back on the grass. He took deep breaths as he tried to calm down. He was okay.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Grimacing, he pressed the back of his hand to the

corner of his brow. The skin was split, and the small gash stung beneath his touch. Kerry offered him a hand and he took it, sitting up and then getting to his feet. He looked at the three battered corpses. The guy had really done some damage. Holding onto Kerry, Devin took the few short steps to where the man had fallen. Devin stopped and crouched down beside the awkwardly positioned body.

Kerry stood behind him, resting her hand on his

shoulder as she asked, "Is he dead?"

Devin tentatively reached out and pulled back the

guy's dark bangs. The guy looked so human. Hesitating, Devin found the courage and pressed his fingers to the side of the man's neck. Surprised, he pulled back his hand and looked up at Kerry. He wasn't sure he believed it. The guy wasn't what they thought. He met Kerry's eyes. "He's alive."

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

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CHAPTER 5

"Get off me." Devin winced and pushed his sister's hand away.

"Baby," Emily teased as she pressed the antiseptic-soaked wipe to his brow. She gave a small smirk as she heard him gasp. "You shouldn't have told me about it," she suggested.

Devin sighed. She was right, but he never could

keep anything from her for long. Uncomfortably, he looked down at his bruised wrist. He hadn't realized at the time how much it hurt. Adrenaline and fear had coursed through his body, numbing him to the pain he now felt. "It hurts,"

he pointed out.

"You've had worse," she reminded him. "Remember that time at Grammy's? You climbed that tree with me.

Somehow you were the one who fell. You broke your arm and had it in plaster for what seemed like forever."

"I had Dad's handprint on my thigh for a week too."

Devin sighed. "Though, I seem to remember it was your idea to climb the tree." He looked at Emily. He had always been told to look out for her. In the end, it was always the other way around. "You always were getting me in trouble."

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Emily smiled and felt for a roll of bandaging.

"Here," she said. "You should do it, unless you want to end up looking like a mummy."

Devin laughed and took the bandage from his sister.

"It's not that bad," he said and put the roll on the bench beside him. He looked at his wrist. There was already a faint bruise starting to show. "I probably shouldn't be here at all. How is he?"

"Sedated." Emily felt her way around to the other side of the desk.

Devin chewed on his lip thoughtfully. "He's normal, right?" he asked.

"Define normal."

"Alive. Human," Devin said.

"He is very much alive and very human. I have his blood test here." She thumbed the corners of the pile of paper in front of her until she found the raised mark she wanted. "There's no sign of infection."

"But he'd been bitten, and more than once."

"Perhaps it wasn't by anyone infected," Emily suggested. "There are plenty of other things out there that would like to take a bite."

"I was there," Devin said.

Emily shook her head. "He doesn't have the virus."

"Then I'd like to see him."

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Emily shrugged. "I don't know if that's a good idea.

Corden ordered he be put under guard. He's downstairs with John," she said.

"You put him down there with that thing? Whose bright idea was that?" Devin asked.

"Like I said, Corden ordered it."

"He's a human being."

"I know," Emily snapped. She had obviously had this conversation before. "But it's not as if I can do very much, is it?" She looked angrily in his direction, her pale blue eyes attempting to meet with his.

"I didn't mean..." He looked at the floor. It had been a long day.

Emily sighed. "I'm just tired," she said. "And I'm worried about you. I'm worried that one day you won't come back."

Devin slid off the bench and gently rested his hands on her shoulders. "Nothing's going to happen," he said, trying to comfort her. "You know why?"

Emily leaned her head against Devin's shoulder.

"Why?"

"Because I know you'd kick my ass."

"You better believe it," she said with a small smile and hugged him.

Devin pressed his lips to the side of her face in a 63

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Things

Meredith

Russell

light kiss. "I'll catch you later," he said and reluctantly broke the embrace. He wanted to see the man who could only be described as his savior.

* * * *

A few months before the virus outbreak, the prison

population had been halved to around three hundred and fifty inmates. The penitentiary had been given the funding to have a long overdue refurbishment, so inmates had been spread across the State until the project was complete. The solitary cells in the basement level, however, had not been part of that scheme. Devin stood in the dank lower level and stared at the barred cell and its occupant. The conditions made the newer cells look like the penthouse suite he once stayed in during a trip to Vegas. Cautiously, Devin approached the first small cell and looked at the monster chained up inside. John, he thought to himself, like John Doe. He met the pale, blood-shot eyes of the monster, and a weird feeling washed through him as he watched it struggle for escape. Devin sighed. He had been part of the group that captured the thing almost a month ago. Corden had wanted something for Emily and the others to play with, and maybe find a solution to the spreading infection.

His team had got it here, lost a couple of guys in the 64

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

process, but they'd got it.

Devin ran his hand across the bars, causing a

metallic echo as his fingers hit one bar after another. He looked behind him at the closed, heavy door. An armed man would be standing on the other side. Passing several empty cells, he finally stopped. The body inside this one was warm and alive, and sitting against the back wall.

Devin rested his hands on the bars and looked at the man opposite him. He was amazed anyone had survived out there alone for so long.

"Where am I?" The guy lifted his head and looked accusingly at Devin from beneath his dark bangs.

Devin leaned in closer and eyed the man curiously.

The guy seemed smaller than out at the farm. He was sitting with his knees pulled up to his chest and his arms wrapped protectively around them. Beneath the layer of grime and blood, Devin could see the sharp edges of the guy's collarbones, a worrying sight to see on someone who had appeared so powerful before. Devin tilted his head slightly, noting how youthful the man appeared beneath the dirt. There was a clean patch on his forehead where adhesive strips had been applied to the graze the bullet had left.

"Where am I?" the man asked again as he unfolded his arms and pushed himself to his feet.

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Dead

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Meredith

Russell

"It's a high security prison several miles outside Kansas City."

"Devin?" the man said as he stepped forward.

"That's you. The woman called out your name."

"Yes," Devin agreed and took a cautious step away from the bars.

"That woman. She shot me," the man remembered.

Devin nodded. "It was a bit of a mess back there.

She saw you and those monsters—"

"I'm not one of them," the man interrupted. "They weren't either."

"They?" Devin asked curiously. The others at the farm had definitely been changed by the virus. "Apart from you, they were all—"

"No. Not those things. My family." The man moved up to the bars and eyed Devin with dark brown eyes. "But it's just me now. It has been for months."

"Your family is dead?"

The man shrugged as he looked around the cell. "I guess so." He wrapped his hands around the bars and met Devin's eyes. "Why am I here?"

Devin uncomfortably flexed his hand and rubbed at

his stiff wrist. "Security. We had to be sure you weren't one of them."

"And now?"

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

"What?" Devin asked.

"You must know I'm not one of them," he said.

"The blood test came back negative. But for now we feel it's best you stay here and get some rest," Devin lied.

The man shook his head. "I want to go home. I want to go back to the farm."

"I don't think that would be a good idea. You're safer here." Devin wasn't sure he believed what he was saying. There was something different about this man, and he was afraid Corden wouldn't hesitate to find out what that was.

"Am I a prisoner?"

"No," Devin said quickly. "Of course not."

"Then take me back."

"I can't do that." The man became agitated and stepped back from the cell door. "What's your name?"

Devin asked, trying to distract him with questions.

The man looked at Devin as he contemplated answering. "Noah," he eventually shared.

"Noah," Devin repeated and offered him a friendly smile. "Got a last name?"

"My family's name is Weber," Noah shared as he moved forward. "Well, it was." He leaned his head against the bars. "My brother, my sister, and my mom, they died."

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

He curled his hands around the bars again. "Dad, on the other hand, well, you know how these things go." He glanced down at his scarred arm. "But he's with them now."

"You killed him?"

Noah leaned forward. "Not like he left me much choice. He attacked and killed my family, even my dog, Tasha, and then he tried to do the same to me," he said all too easily. He looked Devin up and down. Noah's eyes on him made Devin feel uncomfortable. "So, who do I need to talk to about getting out of here?" Noah asked. "Because no offense. I doubt that's you." He winced as his taped wound caught the metal bar of his cage.

Devin couldn't argue with that. With a sniffed

laugh, Devin informed him, "He won't come down here."

"Who?"

"His name is Gabriel Corden."

Noah pursed his lips. "Never heard of him," he said in a sarcastic tone.

"You wouldn't have," Devin replied firmly.

"So, how come he's in charge?" Noah asked and wrapped his arms through the bars.

Devin sighed. "He just is."

Noah tilted his head. "Right."

"Look, I don't know what your problem is, but we brought you here so you'd be safe. You'd rather we left you 68

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there?"

"I was doing perfectly fine until you showed up.

You brought them with you, and if I recall right, your friend shot me in the head."

Devin lowered his head. He was too tired for this.

"Okay. I'm going to go," he decided. "I just came to say thanks. I'm pretty sure you saved my life back there." He hesitated, before adding, "I hope you get to go home soon."

And then he left. He had better things to do with his day than talk to a guy even more stubborn than himself.

* * * *

Devin rubbed his hand over the back of his neck as

he made his way along the row of vehicles. After a shower and a change of clothes, he felt a little calmer. The events at the farmhouse had left him shaken and uncertain. It had been a long time since he'd found himself in a situation quite like that. A situation he didn't think he could get out of.

"Hey," Kerry called to get his attention.

Devin looked up and smiled. Kerry was sitting on

the roof of their SUV. "How'd you get up there?" he asked as he stopped in front of her.

"I grew wings and flew," she said with a wide smile 69

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

and lifted her legs so one draped over each of his shoulders.

"How's your head?"

"I'll live," he assured her and rested his hands on her knees. "How about you? How are you doing?" His expression became serious as Kerry's legs dropped back down.

"Give me a hand?" she simply said.

Devin obliged and held out his hand, waiting as

Kerry took it and jumped down to the concrete floor. "So?"

He waited.

"Actually, I'm okay," Kerry said. "I won't lie and say I'm great, but I am okay."

Would she lie to him? Devin looked into Kerry's

eyes, comforted by the honesty that shone back at him. "I'm sorry you had to go through that."

Kerry shook her head. "I'm not." She placed her hand on Devin's shoulder and smiled. "It made me realize what happened with Lee wasn't your fault."

Devin lowered his head. If only he could feel the same way.

"I was hoping you would come by and say a few words this evening."

"Words?" he asked curiously, surprised as he lifted his head to find Kerry's tearful eyes looking hopefully at him.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

"Yes, for Lee. I need to say goodbye properly," she said, obviously fighting to keep back her tears.

"I'm not very good at that kind of stuff." Devin shyly lowered his head and focused on rubbing away the ache in his wrist.

"Please?" Kerry asked again. "He looked up to you."

Devin stared at his marked knuckles as he

considered the offer. "Okay," he finally agreed, though he had no idea what he could possibly say to comfort anyone.

"I'll try."

"Thanks," Kerry said as she smiled. She genuinely looked happy. "Thank you."

"Sure." He let out a heavy sigh and ran a hand over the cool, black wing of the car. "So," he said and cleared his throat. "We gonna play, or what?" He gave her a smile as he attempted to lighten the mood.

Kerry grinned. "You better believe it." In a show of friendship, she looped her arm in his and started to guide him back toward the main building. "I haven't played in years."

Wednesday night was poker night, and the few

hours of the week Devin actually let himself relax. It wasn't very often he got to just sit down and have some fun.

"Do you at least remember the rules?" Devin asked 71

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Things

Meredith

Russell

as they headed inside.

"Vaguely. But no harm in a quick recap, right?"

"I guess not," Devin agreed. They turned the corner and Devin couldn't help but smile. Already Jack's laughter was echoing from the guards' restroom at

the end of the corridor.

"Who else is playing tonight?" Kerry asked and unhooked her arm from Devin's.

"You know Jack, then Hank Donavon, Eddie

Cohan, and Jess Martin." He stopped outside the door to the poker game venue. "Jack likes to think he's good at bluffing. He's not." He held open the door for her and smiled at the other players. "Let's play."

After two hours of games, it finally came down to

the last hand of the evening. It was still early, but Kerry had arranged the small service to be held at ten in the prison chapel. Devin stared across the table at Kerry, his eyes narrowing as he considered his options. Should he simply call, or should he raise? He looked at his cards. He needed another diamond. "I'm all in. Two diet Cokes and a Mountain Dew."

Jack breathed in sharply. "Too rich for me," he said, and threw his cards in the middle of the table.

Kerry grinned and gently curled up the corners of

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

her cards. "Okay, just you and me. I can match that," she decided and tossed paper IOUs in the center. "Two bags of peanut M&Ms, a Sprite, and a cherry flavored condom.

Okay?" She raised an eyebrow mischievously.

"Okay," he agreed and turned over his cards. He gave a silent prayer. His biggest hand was currently a pair of fives. He waited for Kerry to show her hand. His palms started to sweat as she turned over a pair of eights. He looked at the four cards already in the center of the table.

That gave her three of a kind.

"This'll be good," Jack said excitedly as he rubbed his hands together.
"Down to the river."

Devin rested his head in his hand and focused on
the cards.

"Nervous?" Kerry teased and gently ran her finger around the top of the can of Coke she had won from Devin in the last game.

"Not at all," he said and leaned back in his seat.

"Ace of diamonds," Hank said, as the final card was turned over.

Devin grinned.

Huffing, Kerry sat back in her seat. "Lucky ass."

Jack laughed. "You are going to share the Twinkie, right?" He said, reminding Devin of what he'd won from him.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Devin collected the pile of paper together, and

smiled as he read some of the things that had gone into the pot. "You can pay up at the end of the day, guys," he said cheerily, and got to his feet. "You too." He winked at Kerry and pushed the paper into his jacket pocket.

"You're leaving? It was just getting interesting,"

Jack complained.

"Maybe next time," he told the group. "I have to prepare a few words for later." He gave Kerry a warm smile and headed for the door.

"Oh, Dev," Jack called after him. "I almost forgot.

Emily wanted to see you after we finished."

"What have I done this time?" he asked.

"Dunno. She just asked me to tell you." Jack leaned back in his chair and grinned. "Job done."

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

CHAPTER 6

"Em," Devin said as he tapped on the back of Emily's door. He slowly pushed open the door and squinted as he tried to focus on his sister in the dark room. "What's with the light?" he asked.

Emily was sitting on her bed with a file in her lap oblivious to the darkness. "Light?" she asked curiously.

"What about it?"

"It's kind of dark in here."

"Oh." Emily laughed and leaned across to turn on her bedside lamp. "Didn't realize," she said, and went back to reading the brailed sheets in front of her.

"Jack said you wanted to see me?" Devin stepped farther into his sister's room and looked around. They had brought very few personal belongings with them from Kansas City, so he was surprised to find a photograph of the two of them leaning against the base of the lamp. The picture was creased and the corners were damaged, and he wondered where she had kept it all this time.

"Yes. I need your help." Emily closed the file as she looked in his direction.

Devin turned his attention to Emily. "Has Jack been giving you trouble again?" He laughed. They had to be one 75

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of the oddest couples sometimes.

"No. Jack's great." She was hesitant, but finally admitted, "It's Noah."

Devin frowned. "The guy we brought in?"

"Yes." It was clear Emily was concerned.

"Is he okay? Has something happened?" He sat down on the end of Emily's bed and noted how she fidgeted with the corner of the file she had.

"He's in trouble, Dev. He needs our help."

"Our help? What's wrong?"

Emily reached for a sheet of paper on her bedside

and handed it to Devin. "Corden wants us to infect him."

"What?" Devin was surprised. Corden had done some questionable things in the last few months, but this?

"Why?"

"He believes Noah is immune. He wants to use John to test the theory."

Devin looked at the handwritten order on the paper

in front of him. "You can't let him do that. Whether he's immune or not, it's wrong. He's a person. He's a human being."

"You think I don't know that?" She ran a hand back through her long, blonde hair and gave a heavy sigh. She was obviously frustrated by the situation. "Once Corden found out Noah was bitten, it was only a matter of time

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before he did something like this."

Devin shook his head. "You told me those bites weren't from those freaks. You lied to me?"

"I'm sorry," Emily said and reached out for Devin's hand. "We found the virus in the swabs we took of the most recent wounds. He must have been bitten when he tackled them off you."

Devin looked at his sister, amazed by her revelation and yet also disappointed. She had lied to him. Slowly, he pulled his hand out of her reach and asked, "Does he know?"

"Noah? I don't know. I don't think he realizes how special he is."

"He said his family never turned. His mom, and his brother and sister, they just died." He unconsciously began to rub at his wrist. His hand was cool against the low throb.

"But his dad did," he suddenly remembered. "Why would that be?"

"It could be a gene from his mother's side.

Something all the children inherited from her," Emily mused.

"But what if you're wrong?" He leaned closer to her and gently touched her knee. "You can't just go infecting him with the virus. He might have just been lucky." He squeezed her knee as he tried to think of an alternative 77

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explanation. "I don't know. What if the virus was weaker or something? Maybe it's been diluted as it's passed from host to host. His family died. Maybe they would have come back. What if they just didn't get the chance?"

"Trust me. I've tried all that, and more. Corden's convinced someone to go ahead with it. He'll infect Noah and I don't know what else to do."

"You can't let that happen."

Emily reached out and placed her hand over Devin's

on her knee. Slowly, she closed her hand around his. She was going to ask him. "I need you to talk to Corden."

"Emmi."

"Please? Will you try and make Gabriel see sense?"

Infecting Noah could kill him. And if it doesn't? The guy will never trust us again."

"Corden's a stubborn ass," Devin reminded her.

"But he trusts you," Emily insisted. "He listens to you."

Emily's hand tightened around his. Corden wasn't

an idiot. He'd know why Devin was there.

"Will you try? For Noah? For me?" Emily shuffled closer to sit beside Devin. She rested her chin on his shoulder.

Devin raised a hand and gently twisted his fingers

in Emily's hair. "I can't promise you anything."

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"I know. That monster down there is one thing. But this is different. Noah is..." Emily lifted her head and gently ran her hand over Devin's jaw. "He can talk and feel.

He's warm and alive."

Devin looked at his sister. He had never really

wanted to ask about her work, not in detail. Despite her blindness, she'd been extremely successful in the realm of science, and although it was difficult with their now limited resources, she had continued with her desire to learn and apply what she knew.

"How did you get mixed up in all this?" Devin said quietly. "I thought we discussed this? We agreed to keep out of all the serious stuff."

"I know. I know. But you're off playing hero all the time and I wanted to help too. I wanted to be part of the solution." She was getting tearful as she pressed her face more tightly to Devin's shoulder. "I just fear there are some lines people are finding too easy to cross."

Devin sighed and looked at the sheet of paper again.

Corden would see nothing wrong in using Noah for his own gain. "I'll talk to him on one condition."

"What?"

"You stay away from this." He took her hand and pushed the paper into her palm. "You have nothing more to do with it."

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Emily closed her hand around the crumpled sheet of paper and gave a slow nod. "Okay. I promise."

Devin briefly pulled Emily into a hug. For the first time, he felt like the grown up. "Get some rest and I'll see what I can do." He pulled away and sat for a moment. What the hell was he going to say to Corden? The guy was a pig and that was on his better days.

"Thank you," Emily said.

Getting to his feet, Devin headed straight for the door. If he was going to do this, he should do it now, before he realized just how futile it was.

"Good luck," Emily called after him.

Devin pulled the door closed behind him. He was going to need it.

Gabriel Corden was the self-professed leader of the Kansas group. Of the original twenty-five survivors who came together at the penitentiary, Corden was the one smart enough to put himself forward to be in charge. He had the charm and the education, and this allowed him to stand out from

the rest. As one version of the saying goes, he could sell a refrigerator to an Eskimo. He took every opportunity to secure his position. The prison warden's office became his living quarters, and he quickly organized the

distribution of supplies and the recovery of more. Devin wasn't sure he could ever send people outside the security 80

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of the prison walls quite as easily as Corden did. But then, it was probably what was needed, someone who was

willing to make the difficult decisions.

"Come in," Corden called as Devin knocked on the warden's door. His voice was tinged with authority, and it reminded Devin of one of the many times he was called to the principal's office during high school.

Taking a deep breath, Devin pushed open the door

and looked inside. In front of a large window, Corden was sitting behind a desk. He held several sheets of paper in his hand and was formally dressed in a dark gray suit with a coordinated blue shirt and tie. Corden was the epitome of authority and leadership. It was mostly for show, but Devin understood why Corden insisted on it. He needed everyone to see he was in control.

"Gabriel, I need to discuss something with you," he started as he pushed the door shut with a click and stepped properly into the room. He stopped in front of the desk and waited. "Mr Corden. Sir?" That got the guy's attention.

"Devin. Is there a problem?" Corden asked. His tone was condescending.

Devin tried to relax as he met Corden's hazel eyes.

This wasn't going to work. "I wanted to talk to you about Noah Weber."

"Weber?" Corden feigned ignorance.

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"The guy you're holding downstairs," Devin stated.

His words were more confrontational than he intended.

Corden leaned back in his chair. "I didn't realize there was anything to talk about." He smirked, his dark, horseshoe moustache twitching at the corner of his mouth as he dared Devin to challenge him.

"You know damn well there is," Devin continued in a low voice. "Are you seriously going to go through with it?"

Corden set his jaw in an intrigued pout. "With what?"

Devin gave a humorless laugh. Why did people

have to play games? Corden was just on the right side of fifty, surely he was too old to pull this kind of crap. "You're unbelievable." He walked up behind the chair opposite Corden and rested his hands on the wooden back. "People have been talking. I know what you intend to do and I want you to reconsider."

"People?" Corden queried. "Don't you mean Emily?" He narrowed his eyes as he looked up at Devin. It was obvious who had told him.

"It doesn't matter who. He's a human being and he deserves to be treated like one."

"And he will be."

"When?"

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Corden folded his arms across his chest and

shrugged. The room was filled with an uncomfortable tension. Corden wasn't going to change his mind and Devin knew that. They were just going through the motions.

"When?" Devin asked for a second time. "You must realize this is wrong?"

"We need to know," Corden said as if that excused everything.

"Have you even told him what you're planning?"

Devin asked as he curled his hands more tightly over the back of the chair.

"Have you?"

Corden raised his hand and slowly ran a line over

his moustache, his fingertips lingering at the stubble on his chin. "Sure. I dropped by and said 'hey, mind if we infect you?' He seemed fine with it." A dirty grin spread across his face.

"You can't force this on him. What if he isn't immune? There could be a number of reasons the bites didn't infect him."

"Like what, Devin? Got anything other than the highly unlikely scenarios your sister tried running past me earlier?"

Devin briefly met Corden's eyes, before shying

away. Glancing around the room, he eyed the array of trinkets the previous occupier had collected, and stared 83

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thoughtfully at the matchstick replica of the original prison building. He couldn't imagine ever having the patience to create something so intricate.

"I didn't think so," Corden said snidely. "Not that it would matter. I believe that man down there is our

salvation. The army, the government, neither had any answers. But just maybe, he does, a farmer's son."

"But you don't know that." Devin did his best to reason with Corden. "You could kill him."

Corden drew his lower lip between his teeth

thoughtfully and shook his head. "Then that's a risk I'm willing to take."

Devin's mouth dropped open in disbelief. This guy

was serious. "How can you say that? It's someone's life."

"I thought about it long and hard, Devin. And you know what?" He looked at Devin and calmly said, "There are sixty-four people here, and they are expecting me to save them. They expect me to have an answer."

"People won't agree to this."

"You'd be surprised what people will do. I'm not an idiot. I have support."

So that was it. There was nothing Devin could say

to change his mind. "You don't have mine," he said through gritted teeth. "And you can leave Emily out of this too."

Neither of us wants any part in it." He looked at Corden.

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Something lurking in the surface of Corden's eyes told Devin it might not be that easy.

"When, and I mean when, we find this Noah is

immune he'll need to be taken to the Chicago compound."

His eyes fixed on Devin's. He wasn't asking.

"That's an eight hour drive and then some," Devin pointed out. "It's dangerous and foolish to think we can avoid those things."

"So I'll need my best man, won't I?" Corden looked at Devin and smiled, his eyes lingering on Devin's as he seductively licked a line over his lower lip.

Devin released the back of the chair and

straightened himself up. He found it uncomfortable the way Corden looked at him. Certainly after the casual suggestion of hooking up, Devin had done his best to avoid having to deal with Corden alone. Corden had said it would be for their mutual benefit. Devin was a good-looking guy, or so he'd been told, and Corden had certainly taken a liking to him. Such an arrangement would mean Corden got

something he desired, and in return Devin maybe got a little sway on things as they happened. If he was honest, the offer had been tempting. Corden wasn't completely

disgusting, and he knew it would never go beyond just the occasional fuck. But in the end, after losing Connor the way he had, the idea had never sat right with him.

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"Is there something else?" Corden chewed on his fingernail as he continued to gaze at Devin.

Saying anything else about Corden's plan was

pointless. He knew that. But he did have something Corden wanted.

"No? Then you know where I am if you want to

talk." He winked at Devin and gave him a dismissive wave.

Devin didn't leave.

"Well?" Corden said. He cocked back his head as the familiar dirty grin spread across his face. "Something you want to say?"

Hesitantly, Devin stepped forward. He considered

the man sitting in front of him and the very different man caged in solitary confinement. He just hoped he didn't regret this too much. As casually as he could, he leaned against the chair and ran his hand across the dark stained wood. Meeting Corden's eyes, he said, "There's something else I want."

Corden smiled. "Well then. Take a seat and let's see if we can't reach some kind of agreement."

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CHAPTER 7

It had grown dark outside. The August nighttime

had slowly crept in, and Noah hadn't even noticed. It wasn't until he closed his eyes for a few moments, and opened them, that he found he could barely see more than a few feet in front of him. Moonlight streamed through the small, ground level windows but offered little illumination for the basement holding cells.

With a heavy sigh, Noah leaned his forehead

against the bars of his cell and let his eyes adjust to the low light. He drummed his fingers against the bars of his cage.

When he had gotten up this morning, he certainly hadn't planned for this. His days had been pretty much the same for the last seven months. He had food and knew where to find more as he needed it, the farm had its own water supply from the well out back, and the house was safe and secure. Well it had been. If he had just locked the damn door maybe things would have gone differently. What had he been thinking? There had been evidence of those zombie things in the area. Desiccated corpses of small animals had appeared near the house from time to time, and he just thought, hoped, they were simply passing through. But just in case anything was waiting for him when he got back, he 87

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considered an unlocked door safer than spending precious moments fumbling with the lock.

Slowly, Noah turned his head to the right and

listened. His prison buddy was kicking up a fuss a few cells down. It was probably hungry. From what he could tell it was a male. Its translucent, pale skin had started to sag and hang loosely from its visible skeleton. It had been down here a while, he guessed, and hadn't been fed in a long time. He narrowed his eyes as he looked over the dark outline of the monster, and listened to the rattle of the chains it wore. He just hoped the damn thing was secure.

"Lights up," someone called out.

Noah squinted and raised a hand to shield his eyes

as a fluorescent strip flickered and glowed overhead. At the same time, the starved monster became agitated and started to pull wildly at its restraints.

"Feeding time at the zoo?" he called through the gap in the bars as the door opened and three men stepped through.

Noah warily backed away, and stood with his back

to the far wall. He waited, the men eventually stopping in front of his cell. "Hey," he said and eyed the three of them thoroughly. Two were dressed in matching dark outfits—

dark blue jeans, T-shirts in similar shades of gray, and thick, black Kevlar vests. Were they scared of him? The 88

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third man stepped forward and gave a wide smile. Though he obviously intended to seem warm and friendly, the guy came across as creepy and

deceptive.

"Noah, yes?" the man said as he stepped to the front of the small group. He was younger than the armed men, maybe in his late twenties or even younger. The man looked nervous and his hands fidgeted inside the pockets of the white lab coat he wore.

"Sure," Noah said. "Why not?"

"I'm Dr Prescott," the man said and pulled his hands from his pockets. "I'm here to help."

"Whoa." Noah didn't really care who the guy was.

The syringe the guy now held in his hand, however, that he cared about.

"There's no need to be concerned. We're here to help." The doctor nodded to one of the armed men.

"What do you want? I was told there was nothing wrong with me. I thought I'd get to go home." Something wasn't quite right with this picture. The armed man stepped forward and opened a panel.

Dr Prescott held the syringe at his side and waited as his companion inserted a key and flicked a switch.

Noah was surprised as the door to his cell slid open and the second guard stepped into the space. The man raised his gun and aimed it at Noah.

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"Hey, I'm not one of those things," he protested. "I swear."

"We know," Prescott assured him from behind the second guard. "Travis here is just a precaution." The doctor rested his hand on the man's shoulder, encouraging him to take a step sideways so he could enter the cell. "I need to give you this." He motioned to the syringe in his hand.

"What is it?" Noah asked as he eyed the needle.

There was something dark inside.

The doctor paused for a moment to consider his answer. "It's to help you sleep."

"Right," Noah said doubtfully, noticing how both of the guards' guns were aimed at him.

"It'll be okay, Noah. Just let me do my job."

Noah instinctively went to step away, but he'd backed himself into a corner. He pressed his hands to the hard wall behind him. "I'm fine. Really."

"I'm a doctor. I'm just here to help."

"You said that once already." Noah shook his head and kept his eyes on the rising syringe. "I want to know what it is!" he demanded. "Look, I want to talk to somebody. You have no right to keep me down here. I want to talk to Corden."

"Corden?" Prescott said. He seemed surprised. "If you've heard of him, then you'll know he's a very busy 90

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man."

"Then I want that other guy. Devin, right? I want to talk to him." Noah pointed vigorously at Prescott. "Bring him down here."

"Look," Dr Prescott said firmly and cast a sideways glance to his two companions. "Let me give you this." He waved the syringe slowly in front of Noah. "And then I'll see what I can do."

"I don't—" Noah stopped as a sharp pain made him flinch. Slowly, he raised his hand to his neck and pulled out a small dart that had punctured his skin. "What is this?" he stared accusingly at Prescott and threw the dart to the floor of his cell. "You..." He didn't feel right. His heart beat loud and fast in his ears as he grabbed for the side of his cell, and hung on desperately to the thick metal bars. He sank to the floor and leaned back against the wall as he looked up at the three men. "What did you do?"

"We're just here to help," Prescott repeated his earlier claim and stepped farther inside the cell. "Can we hold him, please?"

One of the guards crouched down beside Noah, and held out Noah's arm.

"It'll only hurt for a second," Prescott said.

Everything was numb, and though Noah knew his arm was being held, it didn't feel quite right. There was a 91

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strange sensation of heat, and something that felt like a hundred tiny pinpricks ran the length of his arm as the needle of the syringe broke his skin and its contents were injected into him. His eyes rolled as he slumped sideways to the ground.

"There," Prescott said as he backed away. "All done." The cell door closed, the men left, and the lights went out.

It was hard to breathe. Noah rolled onto his back as he tried to focus on the uneven ridges of the ceiling above him. He couldn't hold on. The dart, the injection, or both, were flooding his body. He was so tired. Managing to drag himself to the back of the cell, he curled up against the hard, protective surface and closed his eyes. He just wanted to sleep. Listening to his own heavy breaths, he leaned against the wall and succumbed to sleep. Maybe this was all just a big, bad dream.

Unfortunately, it was no dream. Noah woke several

hours later enclosed in the same gray space he had passed out in. Whatever they'd given him, had left him with a throbbing headache, and his whole body ached from lying on the hard floor. Groaning, he rubbed at his neck and sat up, surprised to find a woman sitting opposite him.

"You're awake," the woman said, and leaned forward slightly. "And being as you're not clawing at the 92

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bars to try and eat me, I assume you're still you."

Noah gazed through the bars. The woman looked a

little older than him, maybe in her early-thirties, with long, blonde hair and the strangest, clear, blue eyes. He tried to decide what to make of her. There seemed to be very few people in this place he could actually trust.

The woman tilted her head slightly and smiled as

she asked, "Would you like me to get you anything?" When Noah didn't answer she continued, "A drink or something to eat? I can get someone to bring it down here."

"How about a steak? Rare?" Noah snarled. He was pissed off with people pretending to be decent.

"We have soup," she said. "Our supplies are quite limited at the moment. But some of the others will head outside again soon."

Noah sighed and rubbed a hand over his face,

letting his fingers linger over the few weeks' growth on his jaw. Right now, he couldn't care less about food. "When can I get out of here?" he asked, and struggled to get to his feet. It was a little disconcerting as his world tilted.

"Soon. I hope." The woman smiled again.

"But you don't know?" He held onto the wall as he gained his balance.

"It's not my place."

"Great," he uttered and stretched the stiffness from 93

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his neck. He slowly walked to the front of the cell and looked curiously at the woman sitting in the corridor. He raised his hand and waved it around, sniffing a laugh as he realized she was blind.

"What are you doing?" she asked.

"Nothing," Noah said, and lowered his hand.

"Simply standing in my cage like a good prisoner."

The woman narrowed her eyes and glanced from one side of the cell to the other, as if searching for him.

"My name is Emily, by the way. I was asked to come and check on you. You've been out for the best part of ten hours."

"Is that because of the tranquilizer, or whatever that Prescott guy injected me with?"

"Perhaps it was a bit of both. You had some kind of reaction." Emily stood up and took a step forward. "But you're okay," she said, as if surprised. "You really are."

Noah watched her for a moment, noticing how she kept her distance from the metal bars. "So if I'm okay?"

Does that mean I can get out of here? I could really do with a shower."

Emily sighed. "How long were you alone?" she asked. It was obvious she couldn't get him out. "It must have been hard."

Noah ran his hands down the cool bars. If she

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couldn't help him, what point was there in talking? Silently, he reached his arm through the gap and curled his fingers in nothing but air. Not quite close enough. He lowered his arm. Not that he would. She had done nothing to him.

"Noah?" Emily looked through the cage, her head leaning slightly to the left as she listened for him.

Clearing his throat, Noah pulled his arm back through the bars. "Just lucky, I guess."

"How long?"

He tried to remember. "It was January. We'd just taken the Christmas decorations down."

"Seven months," Emily said. Her voice was tinged with sadness. "You were alone all that time?"

Noah leaned his forehead against the bars and twisted his head to the side. "Just me."

"I'm sorry. This must be frustrating for you."

In a low voice, he said, "I just want to go home." He stared at her through the gap in the bars. Her head was down and a thoughtful frown creased her brow. She seemed sympathetic. "Can you help me?"

Emily shook her head as she gently smoothed down

the front of her blouse. "I should go now. I just wanted to see that you were okay." She reached out for the wall of the corridor and started following it back to the exit.

"What did they give me?" Noah called after her.

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Emily stopped and turned. "It's not my place," she said quietly. Was she afraid to tell him?

Noah closed his eyes and took slow breaths. He

needed to find a way out of this hellhole. "Don't suppose you know a guy called Devin, do you?" he said loudly.

"Devin?" Emily repeated the name and smiled.

"Yeah. He's the only person I feel like I've gotten any sense out of since I got here. I thought maybe..." He chewed on his lip as he asked, "Could he help me?"

Looking over her shoulder, Emily assured him, "I'll ask him for you."

"You know him?" Noah was hopeful.

Emily nodded as she continued to make her way to

the exit. "Of course I do. He's my brother."

* * * *

It felt like an eternity since Emily left. The

monstrous thing at the end of the corridor had been making unsettling noises once it was just the two of them again.

Noah closed his eyes and listened to the monster's constant pull at its restraints. Did it realize how hopeless its situation was? Rubbing his jaw, he wondered what must go through its mind. Was it aware of the person it used to be? Was there anything going on inside its head, other than the 96

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desire to hunt and eat?

A familiar sound made Noah breathe in sharply.

Someone was coming into the cells. Patiently, he waited.

Noah heard various locks and checks being carried out, before the door finally opened and he heard footsteps approaching his cell. The monster growled as someone passed by, and eventually, to Noah's great relief, Devin stopped outside Noah's cell.

"Emily said you wanted to talk?" Devin placed his hands on his hips and stared at Noah.

Devin's presence sparked a glimmer of hope within

Noah. Maybe he could finally get out of this hellhole.

"Hi," he said, receiving a quirked eyebrow as Devin eyed him curiously.

"Hi?" Devin repeated, sounding amused. "Is that it?"

Noah chuckled and moved closer to the front of the cell. "Well, I was hoping you'd talk to me."

"You want me to talk to you? About what?" Devin asked.

"I can't sleep. Will you read me a bedtime story?"

His voice was humorless.

Devin rubbed at his face.

"Joke," Noah said, realizing Devin wasn't in the mood. The guy seemed paler than he remembered and there 97

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were dark rings under his eyes as he looked wearily at Noah. With a sigh, Noah leaned against the bars. "Why am I still here? Is there something wrong with me?"

"You think I know?"

"Please?" Noah asked. "I might not have been doing great out there, but I wasn't locked up like some animal, like..." He glanced to the side and toward the sound of rattling chains. "Like him."

Devin looked at the chair behind him, and dragged

it forward. "You aren't like him," Devin said and sat down.

He leaned forward and rested his elbows on his knees as he rubbed at his wrist.

"Does it hurt?" Noah asked, noticing the pained expression on Devin's face.

"A little," Devin replied and met Noah's eyes. He released his wrist and let his hands hang loosely between his knees.

"Do you always carry that with you?" Noah pointed toward Devin's thigh.

Devin looked down at the gun and leaned back as

he rested his hand over it. "It only takes one drop of blood or saliva, and it could all go to hell in here." He stared at Noah through serious blue eyes.

"Yet you risk having that in here?" He nodded down the corridor.

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"I'm not risking anything," Devin said defensively.

"What others do—"

"Doesn't concern you?" From what he had seen of Devin, he doubted that was true. "You have a sister here, don't you?" He stared thoughtfully at Devin through the bars. "Emily." As Devin leaned forward and into the light, Noah admired the similarities in the siblings. They both shared the same dark blond hair, clear blue eyes, and the same straight nose, and full lips.

"What of it?"

"I know you wouldn't put her in harm's way. You look out for her."

Devin narrowed his eyes. He was clearly suspicious.

"I don't mean anything by it. Just if something did happen. I'm sure you'd be prepared to—"

"Don't even ask me." Devin met Noah's eyes.

"But could you?" Noah asked. "If she turned?"

Devin tightened his hold over the gun. "I hope I don't have to find out."

"I killed my dad," Noah reminded Devin. "He turned and I killed him."

Devin lowered his eyes.

"I never thought I could kill someone. But as his teeth tore into me, I just did." He held out his arms. New 99

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and old marks littered his skin. "I beat in his head with my mom's marble ballerina. She loved that ornament." He slowly pulled back his arms. "Was that wrong?"

It was clearly difficult for Devin as he lifted his head and met Noah's eyes. "I can't judge you. I've killed people."

"People who weren't really people anymore," Noah reminded him.

"Maybe."

"They were dead," Noah stated. "One way or the other, the virus killed them and then they became

something else." Noah looked Devin up and down. He seemed tense and wore a serious frown on his face. Devin really didn't want to be down here. "You ever had to kill someone who's infected but hasn't turned?"

Devin stared at his lap. Something troubled him.

"Never," Devin said.

Noah sighed and rolled his eyes upward to the dark

ceiling. "So, any idea what's going to happen to me?" he asked. "I mean, you don't plan on keeping me down here forever, do you?"

"You won't be down here forever," Devin assured him. "In fact you'll be leaving in a few days."

"Home?" Noah asked hopefully.

Shaking his head, Devin informed him, "No.

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Illinois. You're being moved to Chicago."

It was as if Devin had punched him in the stomach.

Hell, a punch would probably have been less of a shock.

"What? Why?" He looked pleadingly at Devin. "You can't let that happen." He waited but was left disheartened as Devin looked away.

"They're better equipped to deal with this. If there was some other way, or something closer, we wouldn't have to risk it. But they have the people and the equipment we need there. You can help them. You can help everybody."

Noah looked at Devin and shook his head. "I can't go to Chicago. I can't help anyone."

"You really don't know, do you?" Devin narrowed his eyes. He was suddenly suspicious.

"Know what?"

"You were bitten, right? Your dad bit you?"

Noah looked down at his arms. Now he understood.

"You know what should have happened?" Devin questioned.

Noah met Devin's eyes. "Yes."

"Corden thinks you could be our salvation."

"And what do you think?" Noah needed to know.

Devin met Noah's eyes. He didn't seem to know what to say.

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Noah leaned his head against the bars and looked

into Devin's eyes. The color of them was a beautiful deep shade of blue, and Noah wasn't sure he had ever seen anything quite so exhilarating, and yet so incredibly sad.

Devin was a good-looking guy, but he radiated so many layers of emotion, and already had visible stress lines around his eyes and mouth. Bad things had happened to him, but then, bad things had happened to a lot of people recently.

Eventually, Devin got to his feet and walked up to

the bars. He stood for a moment before warning Noah, "I think you should watch your back." He pulled a key from the back pocket of his dark jeans and stepped to the side.

"Whatever Corden says, just be careful." He flicked a switch and the cell door slid open. He stepped back and motioned for Noah to step forward. "Instructions to get you cleaned up."

Noah looked at the open cell. With Devin's warning

fresh in his mind, he wasn't sure what to think. "I have a question."

"Sure," Devin said.

Cautiously, he stepped out of the cell and looked up at the small window. "What did they inject me with?" He could probably guess.

Devin closed the cell. He hesitated, turning the key 102

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over in his hand, before he finally confessed, "The virus. It was the virus."

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CHAPTER 8

For fifteen minutes, Noah had been immersing

himself in the warm water of the shower. Devin wasn't entirely sure what was taking Noah so long. The guy was going to look like a shriveled prune if he was in there much longer. Devin was sitting on the floor outside the guards'

shower room with a hunting knife in his hand. Distracted, he pressed the point into the grout of the tiled floor and scored deep lines into the soft surface.

"Hey," Kerry said cheerfully as she appeared in front of him. "What are you doing?"

Devin leaned back against the white, painted wall and looked up at her. "Waiting."

"For what?"

Devin smiled as Kerry slid down the wall and sat

beside him. He let her take the knife and watched as she turned it over. Light bounced off the blade and reflected on the wall opposite them. "Noah."

"The guy I shot?" Kerry quizzed. "He's out?"

Devin gave a tired nod and took back the knife.

"He's showering and then I need to find him something to wear and a room."

"How is he?" Kerry asked, as her knee nudged 104

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against Devin's.

It was a question Devin wasn't sure he knew how to

answer. Noah seemed okay, but he'd been through a lot in the last couple of days. "Better," Devin decided was the best answer. Because right now, anything had to be better than being locked up in the basement.

"How's his head?" Kerry gave a sheepish look.

With a laugh, Devin reached out and squeezed her

leg. "No permanent damage," he said and strained to hear inside the shower room. The water had finally stopped running.

"Good," Kerry said with a relieved sigh. "Yours okay now?" She raised a hand and gently touched the cut on his forehead.

"I'm fine," he insisted and moved his head away.

"Are we still heading out?"

"Crap." There had been other things on his mind.

He had forgotten about the arranged run. "Yeah. I need to finish up with Noah first. Give me an hour?"

"If your mind's elsewhere, then—"

"No, it's fine. Just let me finish here and I'll see you at the car."

Kerry bit thoughtfully on her lip.

"I'm fine," he said to reassure her. "Really." He rested his hand on her shoulder. "Okay?"

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Kerry opened her mouth but didn't get the chance to say anything else. She jumped as Noah sharply pulled open the door. "Hey," she said and scrambled to her feet. Was she blushing?

Laughing, Devin stood up and met Noah's confused

eyes in amusement. "I'll catch you later, Kerry," Devin said as he turned to her and smiled.

"Right," she said. She looked embarrassed. "Sure.

Later."

Devin watched as she walked quickly down the

corridor and disappeared around a corner.

"Is she okay?" Noah asked.

Nodding, Devin turned back to Noah, just as he ran

a hand through his wet hair, pulling his bangs from his forehead. He hadn't noticed just how handsome Noah was beneath the grime. Suddenly, Devin felt a little flushed himself. Water hung in droplets across Noah's broad

chest, and he was wearing nothing but a pale blue towel around his waist. "She's fine," Devin managed as he tried to find anywhere else to look.

"Oh, okay," Noah said and folded his arms across his chest. He seemed embarrassed. "So, clothes?"

"Yeah, this way," Devin said and led him a few doors down. "Just have a seat and I'll find you something."

He nodded toward one of the comfy chairs in the corner of 106

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the locker room and made his way to one of the lockers.

With a sigh, he pulled open the narrow door and stared at the piles of spare clothes. Glancing over his shoulder, he eyed Noah, trying to decide if they had anything that would fit. He would happily share his own clothes but Noah was larger in all directions. He let his gaze linger on Noah a moment more. Devin had always liked tall, strong men. It was what had drawn him to Connor. Devin turned back to the locker and closed his eyes. Now wasn't the time.

"I don't suppose there's anything to eat, is there?"

Noah asked.

Devin opened his eyes and pulled a lightweight

pullover and pair of jeans from one of the piles of clothes.

"Food is only served at scheduled times throughout the day.

Cooking in bulk is just easier. Usually a couple of choices though," he explained, grabbed a pair of size ten sneakers, and pushed the locker shut by leaning against the door.

"But I should be able to arrange something now if you want. I don't suppose you've eaten in a while." Had it already been a day since Garnett?

Noah looked up at Devin and nodded. "Please."

Devin smiled and stepped forward, holding out the clothes he had found. "Here, try these. They're not great but they're clean."

Noah took the clothes and ran his hand over the

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soft, woolen pullover. "Thank you."

"I'll just..." Devin drew circles in the air as he turned around. "I'll see if there's anything else lying around for you that might fit." He stared at the back of the door and heard the rustle of Noah's towel falling to the floor. "At least it's not one of the fetching orange jumpsuits."

"Oh, that would have been nice," Noah said with a chuckle. "Really would have put me in my place."

Devin lowered his head as he chewed thoughtfully on his thumbnail. "Yeah. Sorry."

Noah pulled on the jeans. "Relax. I was just messin'," he said. "I think orange might have suited me."

Smiling, Devin continued to talk as he kept his back turned. "Other than food, you can pretty much do as you like."

"You mean while Mr Corden lets me?"

"No," Devin said as he turned around, stopping as he watched Noah roll the pullover down over his tanned stomach. Noah's hipbones were on the wrong side of

noticeable. The guy needed a good meal. Clearing his throat, he protested, "It's not like that."

"Then tell me what it is like."

There was nothing to tell. "Let's go get you something to eat." Devin decided to change the subject.

"Then I'll show you your room."

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"You mean cell?"

"I mean room." He looked firmly at Noah. Yes this used to be a prison, but for the last several months it had become a home to him and the others.

"Where's your room?" Noah asked.

"Why do you want to know?"

"No reason," Noah said.

It was late in the afternoon and Devin needed to

wrap this up soon if he and Kerry were going to have enough hours of decent daylight remaining. It was too dangerous to be out after dark. The cooler hours saw the monsters more active than ever.

"Do you have somebody here? Someone special?"

Devin raised an eyebrow. The question seemed

strange. "No."

"Got any zombie girlfriends running around out there?" Noah asked with a dimpled smile, and scratched at his chest beneath the clean material of the dark blue pullover.

Taken aback, Devin stared at Noah. From what he

had grasped from talking to the guy, Noah was in his late twenties and had moved back home to help out on the family farm. Right now, however, Noah was more like a child, all wide-eyed and inquisitive, with no idea of inappropriate questions.

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"No girlfriends, zombie or otherwise," Devin said firmly.

"Boyfriend?" Noah asked as he bent down to pick up his discarded towel.

Devin cleared his throat and ignored the question.

"You want that food, or what?"

Noah met Devin's eyes and smiled mischievously.

"A boyfriend," he concluded.

Devin didn't say anything. Noah had no right asking.

"Did you have to kill him?" he asked as he looked Devin up and down, and gave a small shake of his head as he made a decision. "No. You couldn't, could you?"

Devin sighed, watching as Noah moved closer.

"What are you doing?" he asked as he leaned back, a little surprised as Noah entered his space.

"Nothing," Noah said as he continued to look at Devin. "My boyfriend dumped me a couple of months before the shit really hit." He rolled the sleeves of the pullover up to his elbows. "The last time I saw him, he was in town. The eighteen year old he'd cheated on me with was eating his insides."

"I can see you're real torn up about it," Devin said and stepped away, trying to put a little space between him and Noah. So Noah was gay.

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"Maybe at the time, but that was several months ago. There's been so much other crap since then. I guess I'm just immune to it all." He grinned at the word. "And in more ways than one it seems."

With a sigh, Devin rubbed a hand across his eyes.

He wasn't going to play games today. "Noah, I'm tired, and not in the mood for this." He looked at Noah. There was a strange expression on the young man's face. Behind all the bravado and dry humor, Noah was really overwhelmed and lost. "If you want food follow me. Otherwise—" He stopped as Noah wrapped a hand around his wrist. He turned and met serious, brown eyes. He didn't know what to say to Noah.

Lowering his head, Noah apologized. "I'm sorry."

He pulled back his hand. Warily, he met Devin's eyes, asking, "Do you ever think about him?"

Devin walked away from Noah and pulled open the

door. He breathed in deeply, before looking over his shoulder. "All the time," he said. For a moment he closed his eyes. He didn't like these feelings Noah had managed to stir in him. Devin never spoke about his relationship with Connor. Emily and Jack knew better than to ask. He didn't talk about Connor, because what was the point? That was no longer his life.

Silently, Devin stepped into the corridor, aware

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Noah had decided to follow him. It remained that way for several minutes, Noah following as Devin navigated

through the warren of corridors and security doors. As they stepped into the open dining hall, Noah quietly came to stand at Devin's side. He hesitantly looked around.

"Wow," Noah said. "Kinda..."

"Yeah," Devin agreed. The hall was big and decorated in an uninviting shade of gray. He indicated a long table to his right. "Take a seat. I'll be back."

He waited for Noah to sit at one of the benches,

before heading to the far side of the room and through the door to the kitchen. The door continued to swing behind him as he stood and stared at the dirty dishes piled up in the large, rectangular, metal sink. Lunch had been served a couple of hours ago, so someone had fallen behind with their chores for the day. Stepping farther into the kitchen, Devin opened the first cupboard he came to. Crouching down, he looked over the cans of food and sucked in the corner of his mouth as he tried to make a choice. In the end, he opted for tomato soup, and found a can opener and clean bowl. Now it just needed two minutes in the microwave.

"Here," Devin said as he returned with the bowl of heated soup and placed it on the table in front of Noah.

With a smile, he held out a spoon he'd found and then sat down opposite Noah. "It was that or spaghetti hoops."

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Noah took the spoon and leaned forward to sniff at the warm scent of the soup. "It's fine," he said and slowly stirred the liquid.

Satisfied, Devin leaned back in the plastic seat, his gaze drifting over the grim interior of the large hall. Maybe he could pick up a few pieces of art, a throw, and some scatter cushions on his next run. He smiled to himself as he thought about the time Connor came home to his first attempt at interior decorating, and the look of disgust as he had found an array of brightly colored cushions on their bed. That was their one and only argument. Ridiculous, really.

"What are you thinking about?"

Devin blinked as he looked back at Noah, his smile fading as he pushed the memory of Connor from his mind.

"Nothing," he lied and slid down a little in his seat.

"You don't have to sit with me. I'm used to being by myself."

Devin considered how sad that last statement sounded. "Here you don't have to be," he said. "Besides, I'm fine here."

Noah nodded and took a spoonful of the warm soup.

"So, you said I'd be expected to go to Chicago. What exactly is in Chicago?" Noah asked before he filled his mouth.

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"Apart from one of the biggest known feeding grounds of infected?" Devin said as he folded his arms.

"It is?" Noah looked shocked.

"Cities mean people and warmth. They seem to be drawn there. If you aren't in the city, you generally don't go there."

"So, why do I have to go there?" Noah lowered his spoon. Devin suspected Noah had lost his appetite.

"There's this guy there. He's supposed to be some Government genius who knows about the virus. I mean, Emily and Prescott are great at what they do, but we live in a prison. They don't have the resources here to do anything with you."

"Can't you just take some blood or something? And leave me here?"

Devin laughed. "I don't know if that would be enough."

Looking nervous, Noah bit on his lower lip. "What is enough? I just..." He sighed as he rested his spoon in the bowl. "I feel like some lab rat they're going to dissect."

Devin shook his head. "It's not like that. You're not like that."

"Right, because being locked up and injected with some screwed up disease was my idea? They didn't care.

What if Chicago's worse?"

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"It won't be," Devin said with a firm quietness.

"Yeah, right." Noah looked down at the food he had been given.

"I won't let it."

Noah frowned and shook his head. "Like you could do anything," he stated.

Devin briefly met Noah's eyes as he thought about

the comment. Maybe he couldn't, he decided, but hell if he wouldn't try.

* * * *

At this rate, Kerry would still be waiting on him

tomorrow morning. Devin gently rapped his knuckles on the back of the door to Emily's room and stepped inside.

Lingering in the doorway, he looked to where Emily was lying on the narrow bed at the far side of the room. Quietly, he crossed the room and sat down on the edge of the mattress. He looked down at his sister and comfortingly ran a hand over the back of her head. His fingers brushed over her silky hair, before he pressed his hand to her forehead.

She was a little warm. Emily stirred slightly beneath his touch.

"Hey," Devin said and leaned down to gently kiss her cheek. A smile spread across his face as her eyes 115

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opened and she looked up at him.

"Devin," she said and rolled onto her back.

"How do you feel?" he asked, and gently brushed back a strand of Emily's hair from her forehead.

"I'm okay," she said and held a hand over her stomach as she tried to sit up.
"I just got a little dizzy."

Devin sighed and helped her to sit up properly.

"Yeah, Jack came and told me. You had me worried."

"I'm fine. I promise." She gave a weak smile and rubbed at her eyes.

"Have you eaten today?"

"I'm just tired," she insisted.

Devin eyed his sister thoughtfully. It wasn't often he got the feeling she was keeping something from him, but there it was, a lingering doubt in his mind.

"I heard you got Noah out. You must have
bargained hard."

Devin shrugged. It probably would have happened
on its own eventually. "We came to an understanding."

Emily rested her hand on his arm as she turned her

head inquisitively. "What kind of understanding?" She leaned closer and raised her hand to cup the side of his face. "What did you do?"

"Nothing." How many lies had he told today? He tried to move away from Emily's touch, but she caught his 116

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chin as she narrowed her eyes and stared through him.

"Promise me you didn't do anything foolish."

"Emmi," was all he managed.

"You warned me away, and yet you do this?" She knew exactly what he had given Corden and Devin just hoped she'd forget about it. He certainly planned to after tonight.

"I know what I'm doing."

"I really hope so. I thought you hated him?" she said.

"No. I hate what he does," Devin pointed out as he looked at her pale eyes. Was she disappointed in him? He looked away as he realized it was worse. She was upset *for* him. "Besides, it's nothing I need."

"Don't say that." Emily opened her hand and pressed her palm to his jaw. "You can't keep doing this."

He closed his eyes and insisted, "I'm not doing anything."

"You need to look after yourself. *I* need you to look after yourself." She smiled as she curled her fingers against his cheek. The motion soothed him. "I need you. I can't do this alone."

"You're not alone," he reassured her. "You have Jack."

Emily nodded. "I know. But I can't do this without 117

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you. You need to quit with this stoic BS. Stop pretending like you don't give a crap."

"I do."

"I don't believe you," Emily admitted. "And the thought of you being out there surrounded by all that horror scares me. One day you might not come back." Her bottom lip trembled and she leaned forward and pressed her forehead to his. "I'm terrified one day you'll just give up."

He wanted to tell her she was wrong, but he was

very aware of the heavy feeling of despair weighing down his heart. Before he could stop himself, he was asking her,

"What else is there, Em? The horror out there is all there is.

For months all we've seen is blood and death."

"No, Devin. There's also life," she said. "The life we have here with these people. The life you still have to live."

"It's all gone, Em. They're all gone."

"No." She wrapped her hand around his and pulled it toward her stomach.
"It goes on. We can make it all better. You just need a little faith."

Devin looked down at her hand over his. Her
stomach was firm and warm through her loose clothing.

"Em?" His voice was almost a whisper as she held his hand tightly to her.

Emily nodded. "I'm pregnant."

"Oh, Em."

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"I know." Emily looked tearful.

"How long?"

"Almost four months. I wanted to tell you, but I didn't know how."

"Does Jack know?"

Smiling, Emily gave a slow nod. "He wanted to be here when I told you, but we decided maybe it was best I did it. He seemed to think you might hit him."

The thought hadn't even occurred to him. "Does it scare you?" Devin asked and curled his fingers against Emily's stomach.

Leaning back, she rested against the wall behind her bed. "No," she said honestly.

"How can you be so okay with this?"

"Because I know everything will work out fine. I'm having a baby, and I will love my child as much as I possibly can. He or she will have the best life I can give them. They'll have a mommy and a daddy." She nudged her foot against Devin's leg and looked at him firmly. "And they'll have an uncle who will love them just as fiercely."

"I could teach them how to use a shotgun," Devin joked, though it wasn't funny. What kind of future did any child have? "I have to go," he started making his excuses to leave. He couldn't discuss this with Emily. He feared he might say something he didn't mean.

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"Now? But it's getting late."

There were still a few hours of daylight remaining.

"We're not going far. I'll come and check on you later. Tell Jack he better take care of you. Or I will hit him." He leaned forward and kissed Emily on the cheek. He smiled, realizing there was something he still needed to say.

"Congratulations," he said as he got to his feet.

"Congratulations, Emmi."

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CHAPTER 9

Vodka was evil. That was the first thought that

came to mind as Devin opened his eyes. He had drank way too much of it, and it hadn't even been the good stuff.

Grimacing at the nasty taste that stung at the back of his throat, he hugged the pillow and looked across the room to the door. The room was dark and it took him a moment to realize where he actually was. His heart sank as he heard the soft snores behind him. He curled his fingers in the material of the pillowcase and shook his head. What the hell had he been thinking?

Emily was right, in fact, she was always right.

Despite all the excuses and rationalizing, he suddenly failed to see how what he had done was okay. In the end it came down to one thing. He really did hate the man. Corden was an insufferable, power hungry bastard, who used and took advantage of scared and desperate people. He had

manipulated everyone, putting himself forward as the one supposed strong, sane voice in the chaos that surrounded them. Though he'd never admit it, at first Devin was happy to go along with the crowd. With everything else that was going on, it seemed the lesser of two evils, and gave him and Emily a sense of security. But that was then, and Devin 121

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wasn't a complete fool.

Slowly, Devin pulled back the lightweight cover

and slid his legs out from beneath the bed sheets. He sat on the edge of the bed and listened to the sound of Corden sleeping. What's done is done, he told himself. The memory of himself on his knees for Corden, letting him have that power over him, made his guts clench. He felt cold as he stood up and searched out his clothes. He began to get dressed, pulling his dark jeans up over his underwear.

He looked back over his shoulder as he rolled down his thin, black T-shirt and brushed back his ruffled hair. The sight of the man lying in the bed made his stomach turn over. He hadn't known what else to do. Emily had begged him to find a way to help Noah. He'd done what she

wanted, but somehow he doubted this would be the end of it. Corden had gotten a taste of something he desired, and from experience, Devin knew Corden would find a way to manipulate this to his advantage. He would want more and to keep Devin in his bed.

Devin fastened his jeans and silently pulled on his heavy boots. He needed to get some sleep. There was a lot to do in the next few days. The final plans for the drive to Chicago had to be arranged, and he was sure there were a million and one things to check about the route and equipment the group needed. He picked up his jacket and 122

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held it to his chest. Quietly, Devin made his way to the door, biting his lip as he pulled it open. He slid through the gap and out into the corridor. Holding his breath for a moment, he closed the door.

"Hey."

Devin jumped and spun around. The blood rushed from his face as he found himself face to face with Noah.

"I thought it was just me up prowling the corridors,"

Noah said with a smile as he looked Devin up and down.

"Where are you going?" He noted the jacket.

Devin grabbed Noah by the shoulder and guided

him away from the closed door. The last thing he needed was Corden waking up. "I was just heading to bed actually.

Lots to do tomorrow." He moved his hand downward and pressed it against the small of Noah's back, nudging the man toward the staircase at the far end of the corridor.

"Your room isn't up here?" Noah asked as they started down the stairs.

Devin shook his head and risked glancing back over

his shoulder at Corden's closed door. "Just visiting a friend," he said quietly, and quickly descended the stairs.

"Oh," Noah said and followed Devin.

"What were you doing up there anyway?" Devin asked curiously.

"I couldn't sleep," Noah said with a sigh. "Thought 123

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I'd explore a bit."

As they reached the ground level, Devin smiled.

"You sound like a kid."

"You've got to admit this place would be awesome for a game of Hide and Seek."

"If you say so," he said amused, and looked at Noah and laughed.

Noah smiled. "Made you laugh though."

Devin let the laugh fade, his head lowered as he

considered what he had done that night. "You okay getting back to your room?"

Noah looked Devin up and down. Could he see

what Devin had done? "Do you mind walking me back there?" Noah asked, shyly dropping his head. "I think I might be a little lost."

Devin pressed his mouth into a firm line as he

pulled on his jacket. He just wanted to go to bed. "Sure. I'm heading that way anyway." He untwisted his sleeves and straightened his collar before nodding in the direction they needed to head. "You should probably try and get some sleep."

"Try being the key word," Noah said. "Place gives me the creeps. I swear I felt safer sleeping back at the farm."

Devin shrugged and pushed his hands in his jeans

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pockets. "It'll get better."

"When?"

Devin didn't know what to tell him.

"It must be nice to have someone here with you,"

Noah pointed out. "Your sister. It must help."

Devin stopped and turned to face Noah. "I don't know what I'd do without her sometimes," he admitted as he leaned back against the side of the corridor. "We've always been close. Guess it's the twin thing."

"You're twins? I didn't realize."

Devin shrugged. He was sure he and his sister did

have some things in common. "We get that a lot. I think people see her as the more mature one and therefore the oldest."

"You're lucky you have her." Noah lowered his head. "I miss my sister. She was a pain in the ass, but I loved her."

"I'm sorry," was all Devin could offer. Emily was his reason for living, so he couldn't imagine how Noah must feel.

"Shit happens, right?"

Devin looked down at the ground, a gentle sigh as

he considered the phrase. He wondered if it was all an act, or if Noah really was past letting things bother him. He pushed himself away from the wall

and started walking 125

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again. He didn't know what to say anymore. He wasn't sure there was anything anyone could say to make Noah feel less helpless or alone.

Noah continued to talk as he followed Devin. "What was your boyfriend's name?" he suddenly asked. Devin flinched at the question. "I mean, what happened to him? I know he was infected, but people have different stories to tell."

Devin glanced over his shoulder. He slowed down

as they reached the row of converted cells. Why was Noah doing this to him? "Why would you ask that?"

"I just thought you might want to talk."

Devin shook his head as disbelief knitted his

eyebrows together in a frown. "Talk? I lost someone I loved, someone I planned to spend the rest of my life with, and you thought we could talk?" His chest tightened and he could hear the dull throb of his heart in his ears. Devin's patience for Noah and his questions quickly turned to anger. He was angry with Noah for asking, angry with Connor for leaving him, and angry with himself for what he'd just done back in Corden's room. "He's dead and he's not coming back. There's nothing to talk about."

"I didn't mean to upset you." Noah tried to apologize, but Devin just wasn't in the mood.

Noah could find his own room from here, Devin

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decided, and pushed past Noah, heading for his. It didn't take Devin long to find the familiar sticky white label with his handwritten name on it. He pushed through the door forcefully, and was surprised when the door didn't close behind him.

"What are you doing?" Devin asked as he turned to find Noah leaning against the doorframe.

"Apologizing, remember?"

"I don't want your apologies. I want you to go and sleep. You'll need it. The drive to Chicago could be difficult."

"Why do you change the subject so quickly?" Noah questioned.

"Why do you have no concept of privacy?" Devin retorted.

Noah shrugged and stepped into the room, pushing the door shut behind him.

"What happened to you, Noah? What the hell was it that made you not care anymore?" Noah met Devin's eyes and for the first time Devin really looked at Noah. Maybe he had been wrong. There was something there, lurking in those soulful brown eyes as Noah shared his story.

"I saw my family ripped apart. My father was bitten by the mailman. Can you believe that? The fucking

mailman," Noah said flatly, his voice emotionless. "It was 127

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my mom first. She sat and nursed my father as he died. And when he turned, he smashed her skull in against the kitchen floor. After that it was my brother's turn. He bled out from a bite to his throat. Then he came for me and Casey. He tore her up real good, me too, until I wrapped my hands around his neck and..." He looked from Devin to his hands.

"And for good measure I picked up the nearest thing and I just smashed it down so hard, over and over." He stepped farther into the room and Devin matched it, stepping back to keep a comfortable distance between them. "It took over an hour before Casey finally gave up. All I could do was sit and hold her hand until she was gone."

Devin closed his eyes and folded his arms across his chest. What did Noah want him to say?

"Everybody I know is gone. And now I find myself someone's science project. Tell me, Devin, how should I feel?"

Devin shook his head and opened his eyes. "I won't let that happen." He met Noah's eyes, a lurking vulnerability behind the strong, deep brown. "I swear. But you have to understand I've lost people too. I won't risk anything happening to Emily, or anyone here. I might not agree with Corden's methods, but I do understand them.

And because of that, I need you to go to Chicago." Noah could put an end to this nightmare.

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Noah raised his hand to his mouth and nervously bit at the side of his thumbnail. "But why me? I've never been special. How can I help anyone?"

Relaxing, Devin unfolded his arms. Noah's presence

was less intimidating than it had been. "Because I believe you can. Something in you is special. You have the chance to save us all." Devin realized just how overwhelming the idea must be.

Noah swallowed nervously, his voice unsteady as

he declared, "I'm just one man."

"But you are the one man we need. You can stop all this chaos." He stepped toward Noah. "It won't bring them back, we all know that. But you could help other families from suffering the same fate."

Uncertainty flickered in Noah's eyes. "It's hard."

"I know," Devin said and rested a hand

comfortingly on Noah's shoulder. "But it's all we've got."

He didn't know where it came from, but Noah was

suddenly in his space, his hands reaching out to cup Devin's face as he leaned in and...

Devin froze. Noah's warm hands on his face and the

feel of Noah's mouth smothering his left him wide-eyed with surprise. He didn't know what to do. He didn't return the kiss. He simply stood and let Noah kiss him. It was strange. Noah held and kissed him so gently. He could feel 129

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stubble scratching against his face, and a familiar warmth radiated from within him. It took a moment before he found the strength to stop what was happening, and pushed against Noah's chest as he sought freedom. "I can't," he said and turned his face away. It was too soon. "I'm sorry. I just can't."

"I'm sorry," Noah apologized as he pulled away his hands. "I just—"

Devin held up his hand. "Don't, please." He pressed his other hand to his mouth, the feel of the kiss lingered on his lips. He missed having that. He missed having someone to kiss.

"Did I hurt you?" Noah asked, concerned.

"No. No, you didn't."

"You miss him."

He wasn't going to deny it. Devin sadly smiled as he looked at Noah. The guy just wanted to feel something, he figured. Just like everybody else in this decaying world.

"It's complicated." For the second time tonight, he had betrayed Connor. He just wasn't sure which betrayal was worse.

"He wouldn't want you to be alone," Noah stated and moved closer, resting his hands on Devin's waist.

Devin closed his eyes, savoring for a moment the warm touch of Noah's hands through his T-shirt. Connor 130

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wouldn't want him to be alone, he knew that was true. It was just hard, because knowing it was one thing, accepting it meant something else. It meant Connor was gone. It meant he was moving on.

"You're not dishonoring his memory. You won't forget him."

With a steadying breath, Devin reached down and wrapped his hands around Noah's wrists. He hesitated a moment as he opened his eyes and raised them to meet Noah's. Noah had a look on his face Devin couldn't quite make out. Was he disappointed? "I can't do this right now.

It's been a long day. Just go, Noah. Please," he said calmly.

It wasn't Noah's fault, and Devin didn't want to encourage him or give him false hope. Nothing was going to happen between them. Not here, and not now.

Noah slowly pulled back his hands and stood uncomfortably in front of Devin. He seemed embarrassed.

"Get some sleep," Devin suggested. "Okay?"

Noah gave a short nod. "Of course." His eyes lingered on Devin's.

"Goodnight," Devin prompted and waited. He needed some space.

"Yeah, you too." Finally, Noah turned on his heel and left the room.

As the door closed behind Noah, Devin sank to the

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bed and held his head in his hands. He was so damn tired.

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CHAPTER 10

Since quarter past twelve, the dining hall had seen a steady flow of people coming and going as they ate their meals. Noah had been sitting at one of the tables for the past thirty minutes. He hadn't spoken to anyone all day, and certainly no one wanted to speak to him. He looked down the long table at the assortment of people as they tucked into their bowls of stew. The prison, so he'd been told, had its own supply of fresh vegetables—a project for the inmates to work on no doubt. With a sigh, he watched as the group talked and laughed. It was all so normal.

"Hello, Noah."

Noah looked up from his half-eaten bowl of food.

He was surprised to find Emily standing over him with a smile on her face. Beside her was a man sitting in a wheelchair. He didn't recognize the guy and his eyes fell to the pinned back legs of his pants, even though he really didn't mean to stare.

"Can I join you?" Emily asked, pulling Noah's attention back onto her rather than her companion.

"Oh, sure," he said, and waited as Emily leaned down and kissed the wheelchair-bound man who had

brought her over to him.

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"That was Jack." She felt out a chair and sat down opposite Noah. "He's my fiancé. So hands off."

Noah watched as Jack weaved his way back through the rows of chairs. "What happened to him?" Noah asked.

"I mean, if that's okay to ask?" he added, realizing he was asking personal questions again.

Emily rolled her eyes up to the ceiling as the smile on her face widened. "I believe Jack would say, it was a, insert various profanities, zombie dog," she said in a deep voice.

Noah couldn't help but smile. "He's okay, though?"

"It was difficult for him at first. Difficult for both of us," she said openly. "But it's getting better. I constantly remind myself what the alternative might have been."

"I didn't realize it was possible to live after..."

Emily rested her elbows on the edge of the table. "It takes about a minute for blood to circulate the body. Devin had mere seconds to make the decision."

"That's a big decision."

She tucked a strand of her blonde hair behind her

ear and leaned forward. "That's what Devin does." Emily paused for a moment. She rested her chin in her hands and curled her pink-painted nails against her cheeks. "What did you say to Devin last night?" she finally asked and knitted her eyebrows together in a curious glare.

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What should he say? "Nothing," Noah lied in a quiet voice. "Nothing happened."

"Something did happen." Emily's interest was piqued. "I knew it. He's been acting sheepish all morning."

"What?" Noah was confused. That wasn't what he said. "No. Nothing happened."

"And that would be because of Connor, right?"

Emily guessed as she leaned back in her seat, and tapped her fingernails on the surface of the table.

Noah lowered his head and focused on moving a

soft lump of carrot around his bowl. His silence, however, confirmed what Emily already knew.

"Ah, Connor." She sighed as she ran her hands slowly back and forth over the hard surface. "I wish Devin could find a way to let him go," she started and settled her eyes on Noah. "Plenty of other crap around here without continually carrying around the past."

"What was he like? Connor?" Noah asked.

Emily smiled, her features softening as she

remembered Connor. "He loved Devin, and I suppose that's the most important thing. He made my brother incredibly happy." Her words were

coated in a warm fondness for the man she spoke about. "Devin loved him too. And I mean, really loved him. He would have done anything for

Connor." She leaned forward again and reached out across 135

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the table. "But some things aren't meant to be. So instead, he does everything he can to protect me and everyone else here."

Noah looked at Emily's hand and asked, "Do you think he can protect me?"

Emily tilted her head to one side as she considered the question. "Do you think you need protecting?" she asked him in return.

Noah thought about it. "I think the idea of Chicago scares me."

Emily smiled. "It shouldn't, not in the way you think anyway. Nobody wants to hurt you. I can promise you that."

"I don't know what it is they expect from me." Noah dropped his spoon in the bowl. "Do you?"

"Don't worry," she said. "They'll take a fresh blood sample, that's all. Use a machine to separate the plasma and draw that off. Then they will find something, or even someone, who's infected, but not yet dead and turned.

They'll then inject it as a serum into the virus's host and hope for the best. If the body can, it will use your antibodies as a temporary immunity to fight the virus."

"You make it sound easy."

Emily shrugged. "If it works, it works. People have tried and failed with the virus itself. But maybe with you it 136

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could be different." She sounded hopeful. "And from there it might be we can create vaccines, or perhaps something that could be safely dispersed into groups of the infected, killing the virus, and therefore them. We just don't know yet." They sounded like grand plans.

"What about me?"

"Then Devin will bring you home," she said as if it was obvious.

Noah looked thoughtfully at Devin's sister. "He said he wouldn't let me become some lab rat. He promised to keep me safe."

"Then that's what he'll do," she insisted.

Noah sighed as he pushed the bowl across the table.

He wanted to believe her, but a feeling of foreboding hung in his gut, and it refused to go away. "What makes you think he will?" he asked.

Emily reached out and gently touched the back of

Noah's hand. Her fingers were cool against his skin. "I know he will." She circled her thumb in the space between his thumb and index finger. The sensation of her touch made him shiver. "Because," she continued, "he already is."

* * * *

He already is, Emily had said. Noah stood quietly

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behind one of the SUVs and watched Devin on the other side of the yard. A frown creased his forehead. Devin was engaged in an argument with an older man. Noah wasn't sure who the man was, but he already disliked him. The guy matched Devin in height, but was stockier in build, with a broad chest, and a roll of flesh beneath his shirt, hanging over the belt of his pants. Noah smiled inwardly.

His eyes were drawn to the guy's top lip and to one of the most stupid moustaches he thought he had ever seen. The argument had been raging for several minutes and Noah was becoming restless. He couldn't quite make out what was being said, but he had heard a few words, one being his name. Leaning against the back of the car, he contemplated intervening. The argument was escalating.

The guy reached out with long, thick fingers for

Devin's face. Devin jerked his head from the guy's reach and batted the offered hand away. Devin looked upset and pointed an accusing finger at the guy's chest. More heated words were exchanged, until angrily, Devin shook his head and stormed away from the man and back toward the

building.

Noah silently continued to watch, unsettled as the

man followed Devin and grabbed him by the wrist. He didn't like the thought of this guy touching Devin, especially like that. Devin spun around

and was roughly 138

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pushed back against one of the cars. They then disappeared from Noah's view as they moved behind one of the prison buses. Hesitantly, Noah stepped out from where he'd been hiding, and headed over. He wasn't sure Devin would appreciate him wading in and playing hero. As he

approached, he strained to hear their voices. Concerned by the silence, Noah quickened his pace and rounded the bus.

He stopped, surprised to find Devin with his back against the side of the vehicle, the guy leaning in close and speaking into his ear. Who the hell was this guy? He was reluctant to get involved. Not that it mattered. Devin's eyes met his over the stocky man's shoulder.

"Noah," Devin said loudly. His body relaxed as the man released his wrist and stepped back.

Noah approached and carefully eyed the man with

Devin. He raised a hand and offered a pathetic wave as he returned Devin's greeting. "Hi."

"I'll talk to you later," the man hissed and shot a hateful look over his shoulder toward Noah. The look slowly gave way to something else, as if the man realized who had interrupted them. "Noah," he said and straightened the collar of his buttoned shirt. He glanced between Devin and Noah and began to back away. "Later," he repeated, emphasizing the word. He looked at Noah, before walking away.

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"Are you okay?" Noah asked as he looked Devin up and down.

Devin nodded and leaned his head back against the bus. "I'm fine. Just a small disagreement."

"Anything I can do to help?"

Devin rubbed at his forehead and shook his head.

"No. Better you stay out of it," Devin warned as he pushed away from the bus and headed back toward the car he'd been working on.

"Is everything ready for tomorrow?" Noah asked.

"Are we still heading out?"

Leaning inside the car, Devin pulled a lever. "Yes,"

he simply said as he walked to the front of the car and lifted the hood. He stared at the engine for a moment, though Noah didn't get the impression he was looking at anything in particular. "Everything has been arranged," he added, and cleared his throat as he dropped the hood. "There'll be fourteen of us now. Corden insists on coming along and..."

He hesitantly met Noah's eyes. "Emily will be with us."

"What?"

Devin ducked his head inside the SUV. He wasn't

happy.

Noah opened the passenger door and looked across

at Devin. "Why?" There was a checklist in Devin's hand, and he was doing his best to ignore Noah. "Hey, what's 140

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going on?"

Frustrated, Devin threw the clipboard onto the

driver's seat and stood back up. He met Noah's eyes across the top of the roof and gave a shrug. He looked lost and confused. "Corden seems to think he needs one of his people there. Apparently, Emily is the best person to keep an eye on his..." He looked at Noah and sighed. "His find."

Well, that made absolutely no sense to Noah. "No offense. But how exactly is Emily going to keep an eye on anything?"

Devin sniffed a laugh. "I'll pretend I didn't hear that," he said, before lowering his voice to a more serious tone. "Emily is brilliant. She's been fascinated by science her whole life. 'How's this work?' 'What's this do?'" He smiled. "She refused to let a silly thing like not being able to see get in her way." His smile faded. "But she has to have and do things her way. Here she has the equipment she needs. It's pointless her going too."

Noah shifted his weight. This was his fault. "It's because of me, isn't it?"

Devin raised a curious eyebrow. "You?"

"I was talking to Emily in the dining hall. She said some things."

"I bet she did." Devin shook his head. "This isn't because of you. It's my problem."

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He wasn't so sure. Noah continued, "She said you were already trying to protect me. What did she mean?"

Devin leaned his arms on the roof of the car and rested his chin on top of them. He didn't look like he wanted to talk.

"Is she going because of me? Is Corden doing it on purpose?" Noah pursued. "He was Corden, right?" Despite the brutish actions toward Devin, the man had held an air of authority throughout.

Devin took a deep breath and met Noah's eyes. He

narrowed them as he chose his words. "Yes, that was Mr Corden. All you need to know is what he says goes around here. And if not, he finds a way to make it happen."

"How?"

Guardedly, Devin said, "He's a business man. He knows how to get what he wants, and he loses very little in return."

Curiosity swelled in Noah. "Would I still be in the basement?"

Devin looked at him, taken aback by the question.

"What?"

"I'm here because of you, right? So, if you hadn't intervened, would I still be in that cell?"

"I don't know." Devin seemed genuinely clueless as he shrugged. "Maybe, but I can't be sure."

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"What did he get for me?"

Devin shook his head. "Nothing."

Noah watched Devin. He wasn't convinced. "Liar."

He folded his arms across his chest. "You didn't have to do anything for me. Why did you?"

Devin averted his eyes and stared out of the yard

toward the large gates at the end of the drive. Did he care about Noah? "You shouldn't have been down there. It's my fault. If we hadn't shown up at the farm..." He lowered his head and rested his brow against his hands. Guilt radiated from him. "I'm sorry." He pushed himself away from the car and made for the prison building.

"Devin!" Noah shouted after him. "What's going on?" He ran around the car and quickly caught up to Devin.

He grabbed for Devin's wrist, catching it and pulling the man toward him. "Hey, what's wrong?"

Devin tried to pull his hand free. A look of discomfort creased his brow as Noah held onto him.

"Nothing. Okay." He stopped struggling, and let his arm hang limply in Noah's hold. "I did something I'm not proud of. I didn't think I'd care, but..." He couldn't look at Noah as he turned toward the building instead. "I do."

"What did Corden get?" Noah didn't like the idea of Devin giving Corden anything.

Devin sighed, and Noah relaxed his hand. It seemed

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less likely Devin was going to run away.

"He got what he wanted. That's all you need to know."

"And he let me out?"

Devin nodded and finally looked back at Noah.

"But I swear I won't let him put you back down there. Not here, or in Chicago."

"What about Emily?"

"I'll think of something." He looked at Noah's hand around his wrist.
"Things will work out. I have faith in that."

"Faith?" Noah mused. "You still think God has a hand in anything?"

Shaking his head, he met Noah's eyes. "Who said anything about God?"

Devin began to struggle and tried to pull his arm

free. Noah released his grip and said, "We'd go to church every Sunday."

Rubbing at his wrist, Devin gave a sad smile. "I stopped going the day my mother stood up in front of the congregation and told them I was possessed by the devil."

Noah was shocked. "Why would she do that?"

"Because I'm gay, that's why." He sounded bitter. "I never saw her again after that. I never saw either of my parents again after I moved here to be near Emmi."

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"So, where's home?" Devin didn't seem to have any distinguishing accent.

"Here," Devin said firmly. "Well, Kansas City."

Noah asked, "Do you wonder if they're okay?"

Devin's shoulders dropped as he met Noah's eyes. "I know I should. But what they did hurt me. I would never wish them any harm, but I don't want

or expect to see them again. I'd already decided that when I moved out here."

"You met Connor in the city." It was a sensible assumption.

Devin smiled. "He was an ER doctor and I was in private security. Our jobs kind of collided one day." He brought his hand down to his hip and Noah eyed it

curiously. "I was stabbed. Connor was there when they brought me in."

"I'm sorry if I upset you last night." Noah needed to apologize. He had never intended to make Devin feel uncomfortable. "I didn't mean to."

Devin sighed and glanced around the large garage

area. His attention briefly turned to the handful of people busying themselves with the vehicles heading to Chicago.

"It's not just you," he finally admitted. "It's several things actually."

Noah nodded. A lot had happened. "I guess."

"Shit happens," he repeated Noah's words from the 145

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previous day. "And then just keeps happening." He looked at Noah. It was as if he was searching for something. "I need to finish getting things together." He regained his focus as a serious expression crept over his face. "I need you to promise me something. If anything were to happen to me—"

"Don't say that." They'd only just met, but Noah wasn't sure he could stand to lose Devin. Not after everything else. He couldn't quite explain it, but he cared about Devin. Maybe it was just their situation. Maybe it was the fact Devin was the only gay guy he had met in seven months. Whatever the reason, he wasn't going to deny the attraction. "Nothing's going to happen."

Devin smiled. He seemed comforted by Noah's

refusal to accept the reality of the situation. "Just promise me you'll look out for Emily. Please?"

Noah eventually gave in. "Okay," he agreed. He didn't like it and a knot tightened in his stomach.

Devin gave a warm smile and stepped forward. He

rested his hand on Noah's shoulder. "Thank you."

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CHAPTER 11

It was an hour past sunrise, and the final pieces of equipment were loaded into the three SUVs. Devin sat in the driver's seat of one of the cars and looked in the side mirror. He smiled, watching as Kerry guided Emily toward the car. Glancing sideways, the movement of people behind the car caught his attention. He sighed as he spotted Noah.

Corden was talking to him as he opened the door of one of the other cars. Noah looked toward the front SUV and their eyes met in the mirror. Devin didn't like the idea of Noah being separated from him and in the car with Corden and his cronies, but unfortunately, Corden wasn't about to let Noah out of his sight any time soon. He looked over his shoulder as Kerry opened the back door and helped Emily inside. At least he had managed to keep his sister close.

"I packed light." Emily laughed as she slid across the backseat.

Devin smiled and reached his hand through the

space between the front seats. "You okay?" he asked. He rested his hand on Emily's knee as she clipped in her belt.

Emily smiled sweetly, and looked toward the front

of the car. "Everything's going to be fine. Can't you feel it?"

Devin considered the knot in his stomach. "Yeah, I 147

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guess maybe I do," he lied, and gently squeezed her knee before turning around. He waited for Kerry to pack up their things and then started the engine.

"Man, that's a lot of crap in the back," Kerry huffed as she got in the car. The space in the trunk was filled with weapons, ammo, extra gas, equipment, data for Emily, a few personal items for the intended two night stay, and several boxes of goods for trading in the city. "It's nice to see Corden and his personal guard lending a hand." She gave a weary sigh as she sat back in her seat.

Devin grinned. "They're just a meat shield," he joked. "Freaks have to eat their way through those guys before they get a taste of his ass."

"Play nice," Emily interrupted from the backseat.

"We have company, remember?"

Kerry gave a low chuckle as she pulled on her belt.

"Where are those two losers anyway?"

"Yo," a tall, blond guy said cheerfully as he pulled open the back door.

Kerry jumped and looked over her shoulder. "Flynn, you ass," she huffed.

He and a second guy slid in beside Emily. "Scare ya, sweet cheeks?" Flynn said in his monotone voice.

Devin shot Kerry a look, begging her not to talk to him. Flynn's voice grated on him worse than any other. The 148

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guy was dull.

Ignoring their new companions, Kerry sat back in

her seat and leaned her head against the padded rest. She knew as well as Devin did this was going to be a long drive.

Devin waited as the first gate rolled open. "Here we go," he said, and put the car in drive.

"Woo." Kerry mockingly fist-pumped the air, as she gave an empty cheer. She rolled her head and grinned at Devin. "Road trip."

This was not a road trip any of them really wanted

to take. It was dangerous and foolish. Devin didn't understand why it had to be made into such a huge thing.

Two people and one car would have been enough. Safety in numbers was not always the correct assumption. Instead, too many people could lead to unwanted attention, and although more people meant more guns, the need to look out for everybody could just as easily distract you and get you killed. He was the lead in a parade of vehicles, and Devin just hoped nobody came out onto the streets to see them pass by.

"What's on your mind?" Kerry asked in a hushed voice as they exited the second gate and made their way to the interstate.

"I need you to stay sharp," Devin said, keeping his 149

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voice low. He trusted her more than anyone else right now.

"Of course." She glanced behind them at their three passengers. "Whatever you need."

Devin twisted his hands around the steering wheel

and cast a glance in the rear mirror. He looked at the two men in the back with Emily. Both had their eyes closed. He then looked beyond them and out the back window, and at the two vehicles following behind them.

"Are we nearly there yet?" Emily piped up from behind Devin.

Devin briefly looked over his shoulder. "Cute, sis,"

he said and turned back to the road.

"Will we stop before Chicago?"

Shrugging, Devin told her, "Only if we have to."

There were several rest-stops along the planned route. It wouldn't be too difficult to find one secure enough to stop at.

Kerry added, "So, now's not a good time to say I didn't go before we left." She grinned as she slid lower in her seat and rested her head in her hand as she propped her elbow against the car door.

Emily sighed. "So, does anyone want to play I-spy?"

Devin rolled his eyes. This was going to be a long ride.

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* * * *

They had been traveling for almost five hours.

Apart from a few abandoned cars, which had been cleared to the edge of the highway, there were no signs of anyone, infected or otherwise, along the long stretch of road.

"Something beginning with the letter K." Emily was on her seventh attempt at engaging the other passengers in a game of I-spy.

"Kerry," Devin guessed.

"Nope."

"Key."

"Nope."

Flynn called from the back, "Kevlar vest."

"Wrong."

Devin looked around the car. There wasn't anything

else. "Are you sure it's not Kerry?"

"Not Kerry," insisted Emily.

"There is nothing else," Devin huffed and rested his elbow on the car door.

"There is," Emily said as she leaned forward.

Devin considered the letter.

Kerry laughed at the siblings before turning around and trying, "Keychain?"

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Emily kicked the back of Devin's seat. "We have a winner."

"What the hell? You didn't know that."

"I could hear it jingling,"

Devin sighed and stared at the road ahead. He gave

an annoyed grunt as Emily kicked the back of his seat again. "Fine," he huffed.

Kerry smiled, and gave a silent cheer as she raised her hands in victory. She smirked as Devin shot her a look, her smirk fast-fading as they approached their first major obstacle. "Jesus," she said breathlessly as she sat upright.

Braking, Devin slowed the car to a stop. This was

going to be a problem.

"What is it?" Emily asked from the backseat.

"Nothing," Devin said as he glanced in the mirror, watching as the other cars lined up behind him. Corden's plan was about to turn to shit.

"Can we get through?" Kerry asked.

A mass of cars blocked the way. Something must

have happened. A truck lay on its side across both lanes at the front of the blockage. Its cab was black and deformed from fire damage.

Devin looked past the truck and at the backed-up

cars. There'd been a terrible accident. "People have traveled out this way before," he assured her.

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Kerry sniffed a laugh. "Yeah, right. And how many came back?"

"Can we go around?" Flynn asked with a yawn as he leaned through the gap between the front seats.

Devin sighed and considered their options. St Louis was always Corden's preferred route between states. It was the most direct route over the Mississippi before heading upstate to Chicago. It could take up to an hour, maybe more to find a safe place to cross the river, especially if they were to find another major highway. Large roads meant open space and security. Raising a hand, he pressed the mic he wore more firmly to his throat. He doubted Corden would like his suggestion. He spoke to the other cars. "I think we need to head back and try a different route. The Sixty-one north of Wentzville—"

Straight away Corden interrupted. "No," he said over the radio. "We push through."

"Sir, there is no way through. It's backed up for God knows how far."

Corden ordered, "We are not going back."

There was a rustling sound and Devin waited.

Corden would have a map. He had to see it made sense to head north. "Sir?"

"Is now a good time to ask for another toilet break?"

Kerry added humorlessly.

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"Where are we?" Corden asked.

"I-270. Florrisant." Devin already knew what Corden was going to suggest. He had spent hours looking over Corden's route across the country.

"Devin, take us through the city. We can take the bridge."

Corden was a reckless fool. "Are you insane?"

Corden's voice became louder in his ear. "I want you to head back to the interchange and get off. Take us through the city. "

"Sir, I don't think that's a good idea."

Another voice joined the conversation. It was Hank

in the third car. "Maybe Devin's right, sir. There's no saying how far back this goes. It seems foolish to think—"

"You're not here to think," Corden said. "You're here to shoot any of those things we come across. Okay?"

And the longer we're on the road the more chance there is of running into them. Now, Devin, you have my

instructions. I expect you to follow them."

Devin silently stared out the front window and

listened to the sound of his sister humming behind him, something she did when she was nervous. This was a stupid and dangerous idea, but then Corden was a stupid and dangerous man.

"Devin."

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Things

Meredith

Russell

"Crap," he hissed and looked at Kerry. He didn't have a choice. "Remember what I said?"

She nodded. She'd stay sharp.

"Fine!" he harshly spat into the mic. "But whatever happens, this is on you." Roughly, he put the car into reverse and turned the wheel, circling around in the space to face the other cars. He stared at the dark-tinted window of the vehicle in front of him. This was not a good idea.

Shaking his head, he switched to drive and accelerated past the cars and back to the last exit.

"This is messed up," Flynn muttered, and his partner grunted in agreement.

Devin wasn't going to argue with either of them. He felt the same. As he left the interstate, he followed the signs for the city center. Slowly, he drove forward,

uncomfortably aware of the scenery closing in on them.

Occasional buildings gradually became long lines of buildings, each one wider and taller than the last.

Narrowing his eyes, he leaned forward against the steering wheel. The road was becoming cramped. He continued

forward cautiously, turning the wheel as he weaved through the debris. Vehicles lined the street; bloody smears marked the windows and paintwork of some. Shop fronts were smashed and their contents scattered across the sidewalks.

St Louis was in a bad way.

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Meredith

Russell

Since leaving Kansas City and heading across the

border into Kansas, Devin had done his best to stay out of the city. Big populations and built up areas were notorious feeding grounds, and he doubted St Louis was any

different. This was a stupid idea. He should not have listened to Corden.

The SUV suddenly jolted as he clipped the wing of

one of the abandoned cars. "Shit," he hissed at the sound of metal hitting metal. The space was tight but he managed to get through. He breathed out steadily as they moved past the car, and took advantage of the open space before the next blockade of abandoned cars.

Kerry ducked her head as she scanned the street.

"Those poor people," she whispered, drawing Devin's attention to the rotted bodies in some of the cars. There was nothing anybody could do for them now.

"You all okay back there?" Devin spoke into his radio. He listened as both drivers confirmed they were through and following him.

Suddenly, Kerry sat up in her seat. "I think I saw something," she said, unclipping her belt as she kneeled in her seat to look out the back of the car.

Devin checked his mirrors. He couldn't see

anything. "We're nearly through," he told Kerry and glanced back at his sister. "Em, you okay?"

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Meredith

Russell

"You just drive, yeah?" she said with a nervous edge to her voice. She hadn't been outside the prison's walls in almost six months. Devin had taken her there in the beginning and he had kept her safe ever since.

Devin watched the road, occasionally checking the

spaces between the cars as they drove by.

"I think I see something—" Kerry screamed as something hit the passenger window with a tremendous thud. "Fuck!" The dirty teeth and bloodied hands of an infected man clawed at the glass beside her, leaving dark, viscous smears across the surface.

Devin swerved slightly and nudged the side of the

car into the snarling monster. Losing its balance, the freak fell to the ground and landed on its back. "You okay?" He checked in the mirror. The second SUV accelerated hard and rolled over the infected male's legs. There was a terrible scream as flesh and bone were crushed beneath the tires of the heavy car. He knew he shouldn't, but he felt bad.

Emily leaned forward and gently touched Devin's

shoulder. "I don't like this," she whispered. She wasn't the only one.

Devin talked to the other cars. "I'm gonna try and push through," he told them. "Where there's one there'll be more." He didn't like the look of the path ahead. The street 157

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Russell

was narrowing. Buildings and abandoned vehicles funneled the group into an even smaller space.

"I don't feel so good," Emily complained.

Devin nodded toward Kerry. He had other things to

worry about.

"It's okay," Kerry said comfortingly as she leaned through the gap to take Emily's hand in hers.

Devin revved the engine, forcing a path through the wrecks. "Hang on." He accelerated in a short burst. The front of the SUV smashed into the trunk of a large Ford and shunted it up onto the sidewalk. "Sorry," he apologized as the car jerked and metal scraped against metal.

Emily held tightly to the back of Devin's seat.

"Dev."

"It's okay, Em—" Something hard impacted the car and it began to tilt. On only two wheels, Devin struggled with the steering, desperately trying to correct the vehicle from sliding sideways.

"They're on you!" a shaken voice called over the radio as Devin frantically accelerated. A dozen or more bodies slammed into the side of the car, shaking it.

"Fuck." Devin pushed down his foot. The car sped forward, escaping the undead horde. Shots were fired behind them as the passengers of the second SUV tried to clear the large pack.

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Russell

"Where the hell did they come from?" Kerry sat back in her seat and stared open-mouthed ahead of them.

At least twenty more undead freaks had appeared in the street in front of them. "They must have been among the cars," she guessed and pulled her

gun from the side of her seat. "Shit. They're everywhere." She looked through each window. "What should we do?"

Devin looked around. They'd gathered quite a

crowd. "It's the whole fucking town." He forced the car forward. They had to get through before they were

completely pinned down. He assumed they were through the worse, as the road began to open up, and the cars and bodies began to thin out. He sped up, desperate to clear the area, as he came to a bend. "Hold on," he insisted and grabbed the wheel tightly. He breathed in sharply as he rounded the corner and met more than he bargained for.

"Oh, shit!" Kerry screamed as she grabbed for the side of the car and protectively brought down her head.

The SUV collided with the side of a wrecked truck.

Its front wheel hit the broken bed of the truck and began to lift off the ground. The SUV careened out of control as it started to turn over.

Devin's seatbelt tightened across his chest as he was flung forward. The car flipped over, unbalanced by the impact. He released the wheel and brought his hands up to 159

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his face. It did little to protect him. His head bounced off the side window as the SUV rolled onto its roof. Dazed, he could hear the muffled cries from within the car. Emily and the two guys were thrown around in the back. Kerry

bounced off the dash while the windshield shattered in front of them. He reached out as he watched her fall. She had taken off her damn belt.

Kerry fell hard against the roof of the car, and

landed in an awkward ball beneath Devin. She groaned as she lay on the roof and the car skidded to a halt. Her eyes widened, and she struggled to sit up. She looked up at Devin and panicked as she urgently reached out to him.

Kerry's fingers slid through his as there was an

almighty crash. Devin was barely aware they'd come to a standstill, before he found himself spinning all over again.

The second SUV had driven quickly around the corner.

There was nothing they could have done, as they slammed into the side of the crippled vehicle.

"Devin. Devin!" a voice yelled through the earpiece he wore.

"Fuck," he groaned as the car came to rest among the debris. He tried to clear his head. His arms swung in the air beneath him as he was held in place by his seatbelt.

"Kerry," he groaned, and coughed violently. His chest hurt as he tried to reach down to her. His hand brushed her 160

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curled up body. "Kerry." She didn't answer. Straining, he reached around his waist in search of the clip to his belt.

Bracing himself as best he could, he released the clip. He couldn't hold his weight. His arms weakly gave out and he fell heavily down onto the roof beside Kerry. He rolled onto his back. Above the ringing in his ears, he could make out the sound of raised voices and guns being fired. "Kerry, get up." Kerry wasn't moving. "Hey." He nudged her with his arm and her body limply uncurled. Please, God. He reached over her and gently held her face. He pressed his fingers to her neck, relieved to find she was just

unconscious.

"Devin," Emily said from the back of the car.

Devin looked behind him to find Emily and the two

men hanging awkwardly from their seats. "Shit." He tried to drag himself forward. "Flynn." He hit the man's boots with his hand. "Wake up, you fuck!" That worked. Flynn opened his eyes and stared down at Devin. He looked confused. "You okay?"

Flynn reached down and released his belt, falling on his hands and knees beside Devin. "I'm good."

"What about him?" Devin nodded toward the second guy. Blood was running down the side of his face.

The second SUV had hit the side of the car hard, buckling the metal chassis inward. He waited as Flynn reached up

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Things

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Russell

and felt for a pulse. Flynn shook his head.

"Get Emily."

Flynn nodded and moved beneath Emily who was struggling to escape from the locked belt. "It's okay. You're okay," he said, trying to reassure her.

"My baby." She reached out and found Flynn's shoulders. "My baby."

"You're both okay." Flynn caught her hand. "I promise. Now hold onto me."

Devin moved back to Kerry's side and gently shook

her. "Come on," he begged. They needed to get out of the damn car and find somewhere safe to lay low for a while.

"Devin!" an urgent voice called as someone banged on the outside of the vehicle. "You okay in there?"

"Yeah," Devin called. "Get us the fuck out of here."

The door was yanked open and he looked up to see

Corden and his two men. He held out his hands and was dragged to his feet. He rubbed uncomfortably at his chest and looked around. He could hear shots from around the corner. The third SUV must be in trouble. Surprised, he flinched and looked around to see Noah standing beside him. Noah looked shaken as he checked the wound on the side of Devin's head. Devin gently dismissed Noah's concern and turned around to watch Emily and Kerry as they were lifted from the crumpled vehicle by Corden's 162

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men.

"The others?" he said and pulled his gun from his side, blinking as he tried to shake the fuzzy blur from his vision.

"Our SUV's as fucked as this one," Corden stated and edged behind his two men.

Devin looked at the two women. Emily was holding

onto Flynn and Kerry was held limply between Corden's men. "That's not what I asked. Where's the other car?"

"You hear that?" Corden said as a barrage of shots rang out. "We can't get to them."

Devin looked nervously around the street. The

majority of the zombie flash-mob was interested in the car blocked in around the corner. But it wouldn't be long before the strays realized there was easy prey. "We need to get off the street."

Corden moved closer. "And go where? This whole town is crawling with those things."

Devin raised a hand to his head and winced as he

touched broken skin. Fresh blood would draw those things to them soon. "We can't stay here," he hissed. "We're outnumbered. We get inside, get on the radio, and get the fuck out of here."

Noah stepped forward. "Devin's right."

Flynn cleared his throat and nodded behind them.

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"Guys, now would be a good time."

Devin spun around to see twisted bodies weave

from side to side as they hunted through the street of the broken town. They were sniffing the air. They had smelled blood. "Move, now!"

The small group headed quickly to the sidewalk.

They stayed low as they followed the line of storefronts.

"Here," Devin said and stopped outside a pharmacy.

He held his gun ready in front of him and beckoned for someone to lead the way.

Corden quickly pushed forward and grabbed hold of

the door handle. It turned and the door opened easily.

"Thank God." He pushed and let it swing open.

Taking over, Devin nudged past him and scanned

the small store. There was nobody there. "Clear," he confirmed. The group moved inside, and Devin quickly locked the door behind them and lowered the blind over the glass pane in the door. With a heavy sigh, he leaned back against the door and slid to the ground, watching as his sister was guided to the other side of the store. He raised his hand to his throat and straightened his mic. Into the radio, he said, "Hank, can you hear me?" He waited, hoping to hear something. "Hank, do you hear me? Hank?

Anyone?" He leaned his head against the back of the door.

"Fuck," he hissed.

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Meredith

Russell

"What?" Corden asked. He rubbed the palms of his shaking hands together.
"What the fuck's going on?"

"What's going on?" Devin looked up at Corden. If he wasn't so tired, he would swing for the idiotic fool.

"Two of the SUVs are fucked and the other isn't talking."

"They'll be fine," Corden insisted. "They just have to sit it out and come get us."

Devin shook his head. "Those freaks were hungry."

Do you have any idea the last time fresh meat probably walked into town?"

"Will they be safe?" Emily suddenly asked.

A video he'd seen of an octopus and a closed bottle came to mind. The octopus eventually found a way in. "I don't know." Devin sighed as he pulled up his knees and rested his arms loosely on top of them. "I just don't know."

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CHAPTER 12

"How are you feeling?" Devin kneeled beside Kerry and gently pulled back her long, curled bangs from her forehead. He checked the Band-Aid at her hairline and ran his thumb over the already curling edge. "Did your mother never tell you to leave these things alone?" he teased warmly.

Kerry smiled. "I'm fine," she said as she leaned back against the counter. "It's just my wrist. I think it might be broken."

Devin looked down at the delicately held arm. She'd landed heavily when the car flipped. "I'll see if there's anything to brace it with," he said, and got to his feet. He looked around at everybody else. It had been almost thirty minutes since they'd taken cover in the pharmacy and the third car still hadn't checked in. His eyes settled on Noah, who was keeping watch at the window. He strolled around the store, picking up items from the shelves that could be used to support Kerry's arm.

"What are we doing here?" Corden appeared at his side. "What are we waiting for?"

Devin did his best to ignore Corden and picked up a third roll of bandaging.

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Dead

Things

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"Hey," Corden snapped and grabbed Devin's arm, pulling him to the end of the short aisle.

Roughly, Devin pulled his arm from Corden's hand.

"What exactly would you like to do?" he hissed. He searched Corden's face, but found no solution to their current situation. "I thought so. Until we know what happened to the other car, we're not going anywhere." Even if there was another solution, he wouldn't just leave them behind.

"There are dozens of cars out there," Corden pointed out in a hushed voice.

Devin snorted a disbelieving laugh. "Well,

assuming you can get to one without being spotted and there's enough gas to be of any use, oh, and the owners kindly left you the keys, then be my guest." He stood his ground, waiting to see what move Corden might make. He was surprised as Corden backed down.

Corden stepped away and smirked. "I need the

bathroom," he announced loudly and wandered toward the front of the store. "Seriously, I need to piss," he shared with the rest of the group as Devin followed him out of the aisle.

Sighing, Devin looked to the right of the service

counter at a door he assumed led out back. There'd

probably be an employee bathroom. He looked at the group and eventually nodded toward one of Corden's men. "Fry, 167

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right?" Devin checked. He received a nod in return.

"Accompany Mr Corden to the bathroom."

Fry rolled his eyes and looked at his partner.

"Lukas?"

Corden's second man simply grinned.

Neither man wanted the job of playing babysitter,

but Lukas seemed to have the advantage of age and

authority. With a heavy sigh, Fry conceded. "Sure," he grudgingly agreed, and jumped down from where he was perched on top of the counter.

Corden looked from Devin to Noah. "Don't go

leaving without us," he said with a smirk, and followed Fry to the back of the pharmacy and through the door.

Devin waited for the door to swing shut, before

letting himself relax. Rubbing a hand over his stiff neck, he walked over to the window. "Anything out there?" he asked Noah.

Noah shook his head. "I don't think they know we're in here."

"I need to get back out there," Devin said quietly. "I can't get through to anyone. I don't know if those things could have flipped the car. I need to know so we can figure the best way out of here."

"Let me go," Noah suggested. "I'll be okay."

Not a chance. "I can't let you go out there. You 168

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Things

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might be immune, but they can still rip you apart. If you die, all this was for nothing," he said in a hushed voice.

"I'll be okay." Noah did his best to look confident.

Devin didn't believe it for a second.

"No," Devin said and pulled down one of the slats in the blind. A handful of freaks milled between the cars.

With nothing out there attracting their attention, they were happy to amble slowly along the street. "I'll give it another five minutes. Hopefully, these guys will pass right on by."

Noah didn't look so sure. "Please don't go out there."

"It'll be fine. I need you to stay here and keep an eye on things. I don't trust Corden or his men." He looked behind him. Corden's second man, Lukas, hovered beside the door, waiting for Corden and Fry to return.

"The idiot led us into this nightmare." Noah folded his arms across his chest as he leaned against the

doorframe. "I don't think you should have to clean up his mess—" He flinched as there was a sudden, loud bang followed by raised voices from behind the closed door at the back of the store.

"Stay here," Devin insisted as he quickly headed toward the sound.

Lukas was already in the door as a terrifying scream echoed through the pharmacy. The scream startled the rest

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

of the group and they moved closer together as Devin rushed past them, following Lukas. In the back of the building, Devin was faced with a narrow corridor and a choice of four doors. A further commotion came from one of the rooms on his right and he and Lukas burst through the door.

"No!" Lukas roared as he entered the room.

Devin quickly followed him inside and watched as

Lukas fought with a thrashing child who had locked

himself around Fry's body. His thin arms and legs were wrapped tightly around Fry, and his face was buried in the side of Fry's neck as he tore into the man's flesh with his teeth. He watched as Lukas grappled awkwardly with the wild child, managing to loosen the boy's hold enough to pull him free and throw him onto a pile of empty packing boxes. The small boy's eyes were pale and blood-shot. His skin was equally pale, and his torn pants hung off his emaciated waist. Had he been trapped back here all this time? Devin flinched as a shot was fired, the boy's blood and brains blowing out over the wall of the room in a red mist.

"What the hell happened?" Lukas demanded as he wrapped his arms around Fry's chest, supporting his weight as he lowered him to the floor.

Devin stepped farther into the room, his heart

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beating rapidly as he looked at the red-spattered chaos laid out before him. He looked from the boy to where Fry lay across his partner's legs. Blood had soaked into his clothes and was beginning to spread outward across the tiled floor.

"Fuck," he hissed and reached for his gun at his side.

"Shoot him!"

Devin turned to find Corden sitting on the floor

behind the door. Sweat coated his brow as he pointed forcefully at Fry.

"Shoot him!" he demanded for a second time, grimacing as he held his wrist tightly in his hand.

Devin looked his boss up and down. "Are you hurt?"

Shaking his head, Corden told him, "I fell."

"Why the hell were you in here?" Lukas soothed a hand through Fry's hair, as he pressed his mouth into a firm line and fixed his sight on Corden.

"It's not my fault," Corden insisted. "Fry heard something and wanted to check it out. I told him not to.

That kid came out of nowhere. He was thrashing around all over the place." He got to his feet and smoothed his folded jacket over his arm as he hugged it to his chest.

Devin turned away in disgust. Even now, Corden's

expensive suit meant more to him than anything else. No matter what, Gabriel would always hold on to his precious

Dead

Things

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Russell

appearance of position and power. Devin met Fry's scared, young eyes. He was just a kid. He drew his gun from its holster.

"Lukas," he said. "Take Mr Corden to join the others."

Lukas went to argue. "But—"

"Now," he instructed. "I want you to check on everybody else. Make sure we didn't attract ourselves any unwanted attention."

Lukas looked down at the dying man in his lap.

Tenderly, he cupped Fry's face and leaned down,

whispering words into his ear. Lukas raised Fry's hand and pressed it tightly to the deep bite to stem the blood flow and then carefully slid his legs from under Fry. He got to his feet. His hands were covered in Fry's blood. He came to stand at Devin's side and looked back at the young man.

"Make it quick." He couldn't save Fry. The wound was too severe. He looked mournfully at Devin before leaving the room.

Corden walked with an arrogant swagger toward the

door. He stopped in the doorway and looked back over his shoulder. "Shoot him already. He's as good as dead anyhow."

Devin tensed his jaw and gave Corden an angry

look. "Get out," he said firmly.

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

With an indignant huff, Corden stormed out of the room, slamming the door shut behind him.

It was a never ending nightmare. Devin tightened his grip on his handgun and moved closer. Glancing at the dead boy, he crouched down beside Fry. "I'm sorry," he said as he looked down at his gun. He could hear Fry fighting for every breath.

Fry pawed at Devin's thigh with a bloody hand, struggling to speak. "Cor... den."

Devin looked down at the young man. "Corden's fine." Fry had done his job. He had kept the bastard safe.

Fry pressed his hand to his throat as blood oozed between his fingers. He opened and closed his mouth as he tried to say more. "He..." Fry took short, sharp breaths as he reached out to Devin. He curled his fingers around the corner of Devin's jacket. He'd seen the gun in Devin's hand.

"Don't... please. Please—" He was struck with a coughing fit as he weakly held onto Devin.

There was nothing anyone could do for him now.

Devin rested his hand over Fry's and waited. He comforted the man as best he could, holding onto Fry's hand until the man had no strength left. Fry's hand went limp in Devin's, and he took his final breath. Slowly, Devin released Fry's hand and got to his feet. There was no time to wait. Raising his gun, he aimed it at Fry's head. He stared at the open 173

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eyes of the dead man. There was so much blood.

Reaffirming his hold, he took a steadying breath and pulled the trigger, firing a single round into Fry's forehead. They needed to get out of here.

Devin left the room and pulled the door firmly shut behind him. Things were getting out of control. Silently, he made his way along the short corridor. He stopped in the doorway and leaned against the frame, looking over the rest of the group. Kerry and Emily were sitting together on the floor with their backs against the counter, Corden paced the aisle beside the window, as Flynn and Lukas were standing huddled together at the far side of the store, and Noah was exactly where Devin had left him, keeping watch at the front of the store.

"Hey," Noah said, forcing a small, sympathetic smile as Devin made his way toward him. "I'm sorry."

Lukas had already told them.

Devin gave a short nod. There was nothing either of them could say to make this okay. "Anything change out there?"

Noah seemed hesitant to change the subject so

quickly. But eventually, he must have reached the same conclusion as Devin. There was nothing more to say or do for Fry now. "They heard the gunshots. But when they couldn't find us, they moved on."

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Things

Meredith

Russell

Devin edged closer to the door and looked out at the street. There was nothing out there now. "I'm going to make a run for it," he suddenly decided. "We need to get out of here."

"Do you really think that's a good idea?" Noah reached past Devin and leaned against the door, blocking the exit.

"You got a better one?"

Noah didn't have anything.

Devin gently pushed against Noah's chest. "Get out of the way."

"Please think about this," Noah begged. "It's suicide."

"We can't just sit in here," Devin said. "Fry is dead.

I'm not just going to sit around with my thumb up my ass and wait for something else to happen. I'm going out there."

"Then let me come with you."

Devin looked past Noah at Corden and the others. "I need you to stay here."

"But—"

"No 'but's." Devin met Noah's worried eyes. "I'll be back soon," he promised, waiting for Noah to relent.

Noah reluctantly pulled back his hand. "Be careful."

Devin nodded and slowly pulled open the pharmacy door. "Keep this shut," he said in a low voice, before he

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Things

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Russell

stepped out onto the sidewalk. Waiting for Noah to secure the door behind him, he looked up and down the street.

There was nothing obvious moving amid the chaos.

Keeping close to the building, he made his way along the street. He stopped as he came across the upturned SUV.

Keeping low, he stepped off the sidewalk and made his way to the side of the car. He got down on his hands and knees and looked inside. The body of the man they had left behind was gone. A bloody trail remained where it had been ripped from the car and dragged away. There was a twinge of regret as Devin realized he didn't even know the man's name.

Quietly, he got back to his feet and made his way

toward the end of the row of buildings. Stopping, he slid down the wall, crouching low as he cautiously looked down the adjoining street. He eyed the scene in front of him.

There was the third SUV, wedged at an angle between two abandoned cars. He carefully catalogued the car's damage.

The front windshield had been smashed on the passenger side, and cracks ran in jagged lines from where something had impacted the glass with force. He narrowed his eyes as he strained to see inside the car. The doors on the driver's side were open, so he assumed the group must have made a run for it. There had been five people in the car. He edged forward into the street and sought cover behind a nearby 176

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vehicle. He craned his neck to see the Buick. There were dirty marks across the black paint, and from where he was he could see blood on the backseat. A large, brown-red patch had pooled on the ground beside the car. He frowned as he considered what to do. The SUV would fit the seven of them easily enough. But he wouldn't just leave people behind.

Devin squinted as a bright light flashed in his face.

Raising a hand to shield his eyes, he assessed the building in front of him and noted the sunlight reflecting off something inside. Checking around him, he slowly edged forward, narrowing his eyes as he peered up at one of the windows. Someone was alive in there. He lifted his hand and motioned toward the door, only for the light to hit him in the face again. He looked up at the window and watched as Hank stepped forward and pressed his hands to the glass.

Having Devin's attention, he then pointed down to the back of the SUV.

Craning his neck, Devin caught a glimpse of what

Hank was trying to warn him about. There were at least three freaks to his right and between the cars. Devin raised his hand to indicate he had seen

them, before cautiously starting forward. He stopped behind the abandoned SUV

and listened. He could hear a strange squelching sound at the back end of the vehicle. Slowly, he got to his feet and 177

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stared at the infected freak pressed up against the back window. He swallowed back the nauseous feeling as he realized he knew the woman. They'd played cards just the other night. He watched as she opened her mouth against the glass and her tongue snaked out to lick at a bloody mark on the surface. The right side of her face was shredded, and the left side had fared no better. Her nose was gone, as were her eyes and part of her right cheek. Those fucking monsters had eaten away her face. She wouldn't be able to see a thing, just smell and taste the blood on the car.

Leaning up, he grimaced. Her right arm was also missing, and wet, dark blood glistened on the torn stump. Taking a moment to compose himself, he ducked around the front of the car and ran to the other side of the street. He didn't wait to see if anything had spotted him, and quickly pulled open the door to the building and rushed inside.

Breathlessly, he leaned back against the door and

waited. He prayed nothing had seen him, because although he knew the walking corpses had no grasp of how to open a door, if they wanted in, they'd find a way. He scanned the hallway he found himself in, and examined the nude

artwork hanging along the white, painted wall. Not quite what he had expected to find.

Taking a steadying breath, he looked up the narrow staircase. "Hank," he whispered urgently, relieved as two 178

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Russell

people appeared at the top of the stairs. "Where's your radio?"

"Here," Hank said and tossed it toward Devin. "I could hear you. Guess you couldn't hear me. Was afraid you might leave without us."

Devin turned the battered radio over in his hand. "Is it just you?"

Hank made his way down the stairs, nodding as he

tucked a loose strand of his long, dark brown hair behind his ear. "Just us. You?"

"Seven of us," Devin said quietly.

"Fuck," Hank's companion said as he followed him down the stairs. "Travis Norris," he introduced himself.

Devin gave him a short nod. He'd seen him around,

another one of Corden's men. But he had never worked with him until now. "This makes nine of us."

"You got a plan?" Hank asked as he lowered the rifle from his shoulder and readied it by pulling back the slide.

Devin glanced between the men and considered

their options. A grenade or two would be handy right about now. "The SUV, where are the keys?"

"Here," Travis said and pulled a bunch of keys from his pocket.

"Okay. It's gonna be our best shot at getting us all

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out of here."

"A little cramped though don't you think?" Travis pointed out.

They didn't really have a choice. "It seats eight if it has to. We'll make do."

Hank stepped forward. "So, what's the plan?" His hand tightened around the rifle.

He had a plan. Devin released the clip of his gun

and checked the ammo. Forcefully, he pushed the clip back in and met Hank's eyes. "You ready to run?"

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CHAPTER 13

"You really think he's going to come back for us?"

Noah looked over his shoulder and watched as

Corden paced the aisle behind him.

Corden continued, "Why would he risk trying to get back here? Assuming he's not dead already."

"Will you shut up?" Kerry hissed. Corden's pessimism had finally gotten to her.

Corden came to a halt in his pacing and shook his head. "We're all going to die."

Noah rolled his eyes upward and took a deep breath.

Devin would never leave them. He would never abandon his sister. "Please, can you give it a rest? You know as well as I do, Devin will do everything he can to come for us."

"He'll be here," Emily added.

Kerry smiled and pulled her close. "Of course he will."

Corden didn't argue and came to stand beside Noah.

"Chicago will be eager for your arrival," he said as he attempted to create conversation. "Very important, that's what you are." He scratched at his chest and leaned farther forward into Noah's line of sight. "It's amazing really, a whole family immune."

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"My dad tried to have me as a snack," Noah reminded him. He continued to stare out the window.

Devin would come back for them.

"Still, four out of five isn't bad." Corden laughed, only for it to fade quickly as no one joined in. He shifted uncomfortably at Noah's side.

Noah tensed his jaw. Corden disgusted him. He

couldn't remember a time when he had considered someone to be as vile a creature as he did Corden right now. "It didn't do them any good," he said quietly. "What makes you think anything good will come from this?" He turned from the window and looked at Corden. Sweat clung to the man's forehead and his mouth twitched beneath his heavy moustache. "Devin will return and we'll get to Chicago."

He leaned close to Corden as he firmly said, "And I won't ever have to see you again."

The color drained from Corden's face. He looked

like he had more to say.

"A car." Both men turned to look at Emily as she grabbed at the counter to pull herself up and onto her feet.

"There's a car."

Corden sniffed rudely. "There's no car."

Noah looked out the window and searched the

street, he couldn't see anything. "There's no one there," he said, disappointed. There was nothing moving out there at 182

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all.

"Listen," Emily insisted as she linked her arm in Kerry's and made for the door. She smiled. "Devin."

"If you can hear me, you might want to get out here!" Devin's voice came loud and clear over the radio in Lukas's hand, and everyone turned to the door in surprise.

A car horn frantically sounded as the surviving SUV

suddenly pulled up in the street in front of the pharmacy.

"They're ringing a fucking dinner bell!" Corden yelled as the group rushed for the door.

"Then what the hell are you standing there for?"

Lukas growled as he helped Kerry with Emily.

Noah pulled open the door and checked the street.

He hurried the group on. They wouldn't have long. "Come on," he urged. He held open the door, getting the others out one by one. A pissed-off looking Corden was the last. They moved as a group. Kerry and the two armed men

protectively surrounded Emily, with Noah and Corden right behind them.

The back door of the SUV swung open and a guy

jumped out, motioning them forward. He held out his arms ready to guide them inside to safety. "Hurry!" he ordered.

There was movement among the cars. The dormant monsters began to stir.

The front passenger door of the SUV opened and a

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man got out. His dark hair was tied back from his face in a ponytail and he wore body armor over his clothing. He aimed his gun across the top of the car, covering the fleeing group. "Come on. Move it!" he shouted, and fired his rifle.

His shot hit the lead monster before it had managed to gather speed.

"Seriously, come on!" the man by the back door yelled. He held the second row seat forward as Flynn, Lukas, and Kerry climbed into the back. Panicked, Kerry fell across the two guys' laps and Corden was pushed into the car after her.

As Emily was helped into the second row, the

driver's door flew open and Noah stopped suddenly,

surprised as Devin appeared in front of him with his gun raised. He flinched. Devin's shot rippled through the air beside him. He followed the line of Devin's aim, and almost stumbled over his own feet as he found where Devin's bullet had hit. A monstrous freak crumpled to the ground a few feet away. As Noah reached the car, there was a shared moment of relief. Noah met Devin's eyes. He wanted to say something, anything, but all he could do was stare at the man he'd feared he might never see again.

Devin pressed a hand to Noah's back and curled his hand comfortingly in the material of Noah's shirt. Despite the madness around them, a small smile flashed on Noah's face 184

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as he got in the car. Everything was going to be okay.

"Let's get the hell out of here!" Kerry screamed as the pack of undead monsters grew in size, their pace gaining momentum as they rushed toward the SUV.

Noah slid in beside Emily as Devin slammed his

door shut and waited for the two men to do the same, securing the group in the SUV. Forcefully, he put the car into reverse, spinning the wheel as he retreated from between the crumpled cars. He quickly shifted into drive, accelerating hard as he avoided the chaos of bodies and vehicles littering the downtown streets. He held the car steady as the SUV jolted. The front bumper struck the soft flesh of one of the pursuing freaks as Devin sharply took a corner. Finally, there was an end in sight. A sign clearly stated the bridge and interstate were a short distance ahead.

Noah sat in the second row of seats, between Emily

and a guy who briefly introduced himself as Travis. He reached out and held onto the headrest of Devin's seat as the SUV swerved through the streets. He stared straight ahead and caught his breath as a streak of blood sprayed across the windshield. The car hit something with a loud thud and Noah craned his neck to see a body tumbling to the ground. He quickly turned away and focused on the front window again. The body was wearing the familiar dark vest Devin and the others wore. He wondered if Devin 185

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had known the man, but he daren't ask. Devin's only focus was on escaping the overrun city.

It felt like an eternity as Devin drove the group to safety. The pack of freaks was far behind them and the car was filled with a tensely charged silence. Noah ducked his head and looked out the passenger side window. He sadly gazed up at the Gateway Arch, overwhelmed by the

thought he might be the last person to ever look on the giant landmark. What the hell had he gotten himself into?

The SUV accelerated up the ramp and out onto the

interstate. Noah looked down at the river as they passed over the bridge. There were still some things in the world that the madness could never touch. He found himself smiling as Emily wrapped her slender fingers around his hand. She was warm and her touch comforted him. He

edged closer to her, seeking contact. He rested his chin on her shoulder and closed his eyes. He was exhausted.

Holding onto Emily, he let himself relax as he realized he was not alone.

Noah couldn't remember when he fell asleep,

neither could he quite figure out how he managed to in the crowded space in the back of the SUV, but when he woke, the car had stopped. Opening his eyes, he smiled as Emily squeezed his hand. "Where are we?" he asked, squinting as 186

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he ducked his head to look out the window.

"Where do you think?" replied Corden harshly from behind him.

He ignored the man and looked across at the city

skyline. Was that Chicago?

"Chicago, come in," Devin said. "This is Reid.

Anyone copy?" He waited.

"Chicago, we have Mr Corden and his package en route to you," Lukas added from the backseat. There was no emotion in his voice as he continued, "Do you copy?"

Noah swallowed nervously, but found himself

comforted as Emily tightened her hand around his. He could just make out the sound of a voice over the radio earpiece, though he couldn't make out exactly what was said. Instead, he had to make do with hearing only the one side of the conversation.

"Package is intact," Lukas told them. Noah knew they were talking about him. "Nine of us," he reported.

"Can you confirm any activity in the city? We're three miles out on the Eighty," Devin interrupted. He listened to the radio and tapped his fingers on the steering wheel. Noah hoped it wasn't bad news. "Keep us informed if the situation changes. We should be with you in twenty."

Devin looked back over his seat. "Everybody okay back there?" He looked at Noah and smiled, though his smile 187

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quickly faded as he turned his head to Corden. "Gabriel?"

"I'm fine," Corden snapped. He looked anxious as he fidgeted in his seat. He couldn't be comfortable back there, and Noah was kind of happy about it. "Just want out of this fucking car."

Devin smirked before turning and sitting back in his seat. He caught the eyes of the guy in the seat beside him, and gave a short nod. "Not long now."

* * * *

Noah kneeled on the backseat of the SUV and

stared out the rear window. He rested his chin on his arms and silently watched people busying themselves in the large parking garage. Chicago didn't seem all that different from Garnett. It was just a hell of a lot bigger.

"Hey."

Noah jumped as there was a tap at the window and he looked up to see Devin grinning.

"Are you okay in there?" Devin asked in a raised voice through the window. Noah nodded.

"And are you planning on coming out any time soon?" Devin asked and quirked an eyebrow as he looked into the car.

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Noah sighed. "Do I have to?" he said loud enough for Devin to hear.

"Come and have something to eat." Devin smiled but Noah didn't feel encouraged.

"I don't feel all that hungry," he said, and turned around to sit down on the backseat. He waited as Devin opened the car door and slid into the seat beside him.

"Sorry."

"For what?" asked Devin.

"Messing up your life."

Devin laughed. "Seriously?" He obviously didn't appreciate Noah's self-pity. He smiled as Noah lifted his head and met his eyes.

"You're here because of me. Emily's here because of me. People have died getting me here." He was surprised as Devin's smile grew warmer. "What?"

"You're right." Devin leaned forward. "I am here because of you."

Noah was confused. Devin sounded happy.

"If you hadn't shown up back there, at the farm, I'd be dead. So maybe, instead of you apologizing, I should be saying thank you." Devin seemed genuine. "So, how about you stop hiding in here and we go have a look around?"

Shaking his head, Noah looked down at his hands.

He had been ordered not to go too far. "They want the 189

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blood sample soon." He was surprised as Devin reached out and laid a hand over his as he tried to reassure him.

"It's just blood."

There had been so much blood already. What was a

little more, he figured. Slowly, he turned over his hand and closed it around Devin's. "I know you're busy." Devin's hand was warm in his. "Would you come with me?"

"Me?" Devin asked.

"I trust you. I don't trust them." He looked past Devin to where Corden was standing with two men in

white lab coats.

Devin looked over his shoulder. "Emily says they're okay, but if you want me there, then sure."

Noah let out a relieved sigh and slid lower in his

seat. He'd feared Devin would say no. "Where did my life go?" he wondered. "I mean, I was doing okay. I'm not super smart or good-looking, but I had a job, a family, an ex." He laughed to himself. "Why me?" He looked at Devin. "I'm not special. I'm not important."

Devin shook his head and shrugged. "I don't know, Noah." He leaned closer and looked into Noah's eyes.

"Some things are just meant to be." He smiled. "Besides, everybody's important to somebody."

"Once upon a time," Noah said quietly, and thought about the man he had once called lover.

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Devin smiled and shyly looked away. "I'm sure you will be again."

"You mean to Corden, and his dreams of a cure?"

"Not just him," Devin said.

"What about you?" He hadn't meant to say that.

"Noah, I..."

Embarrassed, Noah pulled his hand away. "It

doesn't matter." He sighed as he leaned his head back against the headrest. He had all these emotions inside him and he wasn't sure how to express his feelings. "I know I sounded like an ass before," he started. "I thought it would be easier." He rolled his head to one side and looked at Devin. "I thought"—he rubbed tiredly at his forehead—"I didn't want anything to do with any of you. I just wanted to go home."

"And now?"

What answer did Devin want to hear? "I think I don't want to be alone anymore." He looked hopefully at Devin. Maybe it was just the intensity of the day, but he found himself more and more drawn to the man. Devin was strong and brave and kind. Noah needed that right now. He was in a strange place with strange people and Devin was the only person he felt a connection to. "Maybe there are some things left worth fighting for."

Devin closed his eyes. That was the wrong answer.

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"This isn't a good time, Noah." He opened his eyes and turned to look out the back window. Devin still carried around Connor's ghost, Noah could see that.

Things suddenly felt tense and then Noah noticed

Corden approaching the car. "Crap." Bad timing.

"Look," Devin started, as if sensing Noah's apprehension. He gently rested a hand on Noah's shoulder.

"You'll be fine and then, maybe later, we can talk. Okay?"

There was a glimmer of something behind Devin's

eyes, and to Noah it felt like hope. He smiled as he decided he wanted to take the chance being offered him. "I'd like that."

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CHAPTER 14

"Wow," Devin said to himself as he admired the view from the apartment balcony. Chicago was really something. He gripped the railing as he leaned over the edge and looked down at the river. The room he had been given was on the forty-first floor of one of the twin sixty-five story buildings. It was fascinating, a city within a city.

One side was protected by the river and all but one of the bridges over the water had been raised. The roads leading into the city block had been blockaded, offering security to almost three hundred survivors.

The sun edged behind the line of buildings across

the river, and the air was tinged with summer heat. Smiling, Devin turned and went back inside, sliding the door closed behind him. He stood in the room and rubbed a hand over his shower-damp hair. It felt good to be clean, and he was grateful for the fresh set of clothes he'd been given to change into. Opening the towel around his waist, he rubbed at his damp skin, before tying the towel more tightly around him and making his way to the bed. He sighed as he looked down at the simple white T-shirt and dark

sweatpants. They reminded him of simpler days, of days he had spent with Connor doing nothing but sitting on the 193

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couch and eating popcorn, while watching some badly acted horror movie. He picked up the T-shirt. Now he was living one of those movies.

"Devin."

Devin spun around, surprised to find the door open

and Corden standing in the space. The guy hadn't even knocked. "What do you want?" he asked, and checked the towel around his waist.

Corden seemed taken aback by his tone. "Did you misplace your manners on the way?"

Devin sniffed a laugh. His manners? "Maybe, as you seem to have forgotten how to knock." He eyed Corden warily, before pulling the T-shirt over his head.

Coughing, Corden stepped farther into the room,

and pushed the door to close it. A soft click sounded behind him. "I wanted to see how you were," he said as he soothed his chest in between coughs. He looked like crap. "Things got a bit messed up back there."

Devin couldn't disagree. "You look like you need some rest." He grabbed the sweatpants and his underwear off the bed and went into the bathroom. He slid the lock into place and stared at the door. He wasn't really in the mood for Corden. With a heavy sigh, he dropped the towel to the floor and quickly finished dressing.

"I was hoping maybe..." Corden raised his voice as 194

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he called through the door. "I've been thinking about you."

Unlocking the door, Devin pulled it open and

looked defiantly at Corden. He had a good idea what Corden had been thinking about. "I don't think so."

"What would you want?" asked Corden.

What would he want? "I don't want anything,"

Devin said clearly.

Corden stepped forward and reached out to Devin's

cheek. A layer of sweat glistened across his skin. "There must be something," he prompted and moved his thumb in a line over Devin's freshly shaved jaw. "Name it and it's yours."

Stepping back, Devin pulled his head away from

Corden's touch, and looked at him indignantly. He had nothing Devin wanted. "Don't touch me," Devin said in a calm voice and moved past Corden. "You don't get to touch me."

"You do realize if I chose to, I could make your life very difficult."

Devin laughed as he turned around. "More difficult than zombies? I'd like to see you try."

"Don't test me, Devin," Corden warned. "I'd hate to see Emily get caught in the middle of this."

Devin shook his head. When had Corden become so

twisted? "This has nothing to do with her." He narrowed

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his eyes as he watched Corden move toward him.

Something didn't feel right. "I think you should leave."

"Already?" Corden stopped in front of Devin and leaned forward.

Devin turned away in disgust, avoiding Corden's

mouth as he tried to kiss him. "Get out," he insisted and folded his arms across his chest. He wasn't interested, and never would be. Corden would get nothing more from him.

"Don't be like that, sweetheart," Corden said. The tone of his voice became more menacing. He moved

forward and wrapped his hand around Devin's wrist,

pulling it toward his chest. "You liked it. You know you did."

Devin shook his head again and pulled away his

hand. "I hated every second," he spat, grinning as he looked into Corden's hazel eyes, his disgust for the man etched clearly on his face. It was a mistake. He caught his breath in surprise, as Corden struck him across the face.

"You don't get to make a fool out of me!" Corden screamed.

Stepping back, Devin found the end of the bed. He

pressed his hand to his jaw as Corden paced wildly in front of him. The guy had actually slapped him. What the hell?

He went to say something more, but decided against it. He was too tired for this crap and as angry as he was, he 196

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couldn't risk escalating the situation. Corden was behaving like a weak and pathetic man, but Devin was still wary.

Corden could be a petty bastard. There were other people to think about in all this.

An intense anger radiated from Corden as he stalked a path toward the bed. "You don't. You respect me. You do as I say. I am important," Corden continued his rant as he crossed the room. "I am important." He looked at Devin and suddenly stopped. He'd seen something he didn't like.

"I'm sorry," he managed. His eyes darted around the room as if he was unsure where he was. Sweat clung to his brow and he stepped away. "See what you made me do." He pointed accusingly at Devin, before pulling his hand sharply back and heading for the door. "I have to go," he snapped. "I have to go."

Devin curled his hands into fists against his legs and watched Corden leave the room. When he was finally

alone, Devin let out a frustrated sound. He looked down at his hands. His knuckles had turned white and his fingers had dug into his palms. Taking steadying breaths, he lifted his head and stared at the open door. He was filled with anger and shock, and he resented Corden for making him feel that way. He hadn't expected Corden to backhand him.

Corden was an arrogant pig, but never violent. The façade of a man with power and control had always been

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incredibly important to Corden. Sitting down on the edge of the bed, Devin closed his eyes as his shoulders slumped.

Suddenly, he missed Kansas and the strength and security of the prison walls.

There was a knock on the door. "Devin?"

Devin opened his eyes, relieved to find only Noah

standing in front of him. "Hey," he said and cleared his throat. He rubbed tiredly at his eyes and forced a friendly smile. Corden's outburst had been out of character, and it left Devin feeling uneasy.

"Are you okay?" Noah asked as he stepped into the room, pushing the door closed behind him.

Devin breathed in deeply as he lifted his head. "I'm fine," he lied and looked at Noah. "Everything's fine."

Noah, however, didn't seem convinced. "What

happened?" he asked. "I passed Corden on the stairs. He seemed agitated."

Ignoring Noah, Devin sighed and fell back on the

bed. He laughed as he stared, surprised, up at the mirrored ceiling. "Well, that's different," he said. The bed dipped and Noah sat down beside him.

"What is?" Noah asked as he looked up.

"Not quite what I was expecting." Devin laughed as he struggled to sit back up.

Noah grinned. "Fancy."

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Devin sighed. "I'm kind of tired, Noah. You think we could do this some other time?"

Noah sat quietly beside Devin for a moment before

asking, "Was Corden here? Just now?"

Devin tensed his jaw, but found he couldn't lie this time. "Yes."

"And?"

"He was acting kind of weird." Noah was watching him. "It's nothing."

"It doesn't look like nothing."

Instinctively, Devin reached for his jaw. His skin

was warm beneath his touch. Corden's blow must have left a mark. "It's complicated." He turned slightly and met Noah's eyes, before steering the conversation elsewhere.

"So, how are you feeling?"

Noah shrugged. "I'm still in one piece," he said with a grateful smile.

Devin returned the smile. "Glad to hear it."

Noah cleared his throat and rested his hands in his lap. "Thanks for coming with me, before."

"It's fine," Devin said. "They have what they want, and you're okay. Win-win, right?"

Noah nodded. "Devin." He looked hopeful. "I want... I thought..."

Devin shook his head. "I can't."

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"You don't know what I want to say."

Devin closed his eyes. He could guess.

"Do you think he'd want you to be alone?" Noah paused, as if waiting for Devin to say something. "Connor, right?" he pressed. "You think this is what he would want?"

It wasn't just about what Connor might have

wanted. Devin sighed and turned to look at Noah. "You don't understand."

"What? That you loved him?" Noah watched Devin.

"It's been nearly nine months."

"I know, and maybe if he was..." Devin raised a hand to his mouth, emotion getting the better of him as he curled his shaking hand into a tight ball.

"He's still out there."

"You wish he was dead? For real?"

"It'd be easier," Devin admitted. "Because all I can think is part of him is alive."

"It's not him anymore," Noah said. "You know that."

"You'd think so by now. But if you'd seen him and the way he looked at me." Devin leaned forward. "There was something there."

Noah rested his hand on Devin's back. "You really believe that?"

Devin stared down at the ground. "I don't know. I 200

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have this dream. It was just like what happened. He'd been sick in bed for a couple of days. A patient from the hospital had attacked him and several other staff."

"He got bitten?"

Nodding, Devin continued, "People had gone crazy.

Even in all my time in Afghanistan, I'd never seen anything like it. I got back late from a job and fell asleep on the couch. When I woke he was standing over me. In my

dream he knew me. He talked to me, but then..."

"What?"

"I'd take my eyes off him for a second and he'd rip out my throat. I'd wake up hating him," he said sadly, and lifted his head. "Do you feel like this about your dad? He hurt you and your family, right?"

Noah removed his hand from Devin's back and

scratched behind his ear. "He turned so quickly. Mom was with him. I was upstairs. All I could hear was her

screaming for her children, sobbing as her husband died in her arms." He held his arms out in front of him and gently rolled up his sleeves. "This is what I have to remember him by." He looked down at the marks across his skin with Devin. "I tried to protect myself and then Casey came into the room. She was crying and there was blood on her hands from trying to help our brother. Dad stopped and went for her instead. I couldn't stop him. He was so damn fast."

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Noah looked down as Devin reached over and pulled his sleeves back down over the bite marks. "Then he came back for me."

"I'm sorry," was all Devin could say.

"Bad things have happened to a lot of people. I know that. In a way I feel lucky I didn't have to watch them all come back. I mean, with Dad I was so angry and scared.

I didn't even realize what I'd done, until I was standing over him with his blood on my hands."

"I couldn't kill him," Devin said of Connor. "He came at me and we fought. He just kept coming and I didn't know what to do. I shot him. Here." He pressed a hand to his chest. "He just kept coming. I ran. I wonder if I'd known then what I know now, whether I could have done it. A shot to the head. But he was still Connor then, my best friend and..." He met Noah's eyes. "I loved him. I suppose I still do."

Noah caught Devin's hands as he went to pull away.

"You should love him, love who he was." He squeezed Devin's hands in his before releasing them.

Smiling warmly, Devin raised a hand and gently

touched Noah's face. "You sound so much like him. He always was the smart one," he said, his eyes lingering on Noah's mouth. It looked warm and inviting. "I miss him. I just want him to tell me how everything's going to be 202

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okay." He curled his fingers against the warmth of Noah's cheek and looked at Noah's lips, imagining how it might feel to be kissed by them. He shouldn't think like that.

"Things will be okay." Noah smiled and brought his hand up to rest over Devin's. He leaned forward, all the time looking into Devin's eyes as he closed the gap between them. He stopped, tilting his head as he looked at Devin. Was he asking permission? "I promise," he whispered and leaned in for a kiss.

A rush of heat spread through Devin as Noah's lips

locked with his. He closed his eyes and allowed himself to be absorbed into the kiss. His heart and head were in conflict. Should he be doing this?

Noah broke the kiss as he said, "You never have to stop loving him. But please, I don't want to be alone anymore."

Devin reached up with his other hand and held

Noah's face. There was a vulnerability he'd never seen before. For the first time he was seeing Noah. "You aren't alone."

"I feel alone." Noah squeezed Devin's hand.

"Except when I'm with you."

"Noah," Devin started, surprised as Noah kissed him again. It was soft and comforting. Closing his eyes, he slid his hands around the back of Noah's neck, pulling him

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closer and deepening the kiss. Was it really so wrong? The kiss turned to light pecks, coming to an end as Devin pulled his hand from around Noah's neck, and gently raised it between them. Noah's breath fell across his fingertips as he held up his hand. Things weren't okay. He doubted they ever could be.

"What's wrong?" Noah asked as Devin turned away.

"I'm sorry." His heart couldn't take it. "I can't go through that again."

"Through what?"

Getting to his feet, Devin hugged his waist. "I can't risk something happening to you."

"Is that what's stopping you?" Noah smiled. "I'm immune, remember? They can't hurt me."

Devin shook his head. He also remembered what happened to Noah's family. "You can still get hurt."

Noah reached out and touched Devin's hip. "So could you. We don't have the luxury of waiting to see what might happen. We don't get second chances."

If Noah was hinting at living in the moment, then

Devin wasn't really in the mood. Sighing, he rubbed a line over his forehead and looked down at Noah. He was ready to make his excuses to cut the visit short. "I'm tired, Noah,"

he said and pinched the bridge of his nose for good effect.

"You should probably get some sleep too. It's been a long 204

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day."

"Are you going to be okay?" Noah was concerned.

Devin nodded. "We'll talk some more tomorrow."

He noted how hopeful Noah still looked at the suggestion.

"I can't promise you anything. I hardly know you."

"I know," Noah agreed as he got to his feet. "Sleep well," he added and leaned forward, kissing Devin's cheek.

"And thank you for everything. I mean that."

Devin gave a small smile and watched as Noah

walked toward the door. Stopping, Noah looked back over his shoulder. It was as if he wanted to say more, but instead he turned and left the room. As the door clicked shut, Devin dropped down onto the bed. He was exhausted. How did things continue to become more difficult?

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CHAPTER 15

Devin woke with a start. A strange noise echoed in

his ears as he sat up in bed. It took a moment for him to figure out what the irritating sound was. It was an alarm.

Curious, he swung his legs over the side of the bed and made for the door. He cautiously opened the door and looked along the corridor. The hallway was in darkness except for a red light above the elevator. This couldn't be good. Shutting the door securely behind him, he quickly found his clothes from beside the bed. Once dressed in his jeans and T-shirt, he hunted for his gun and radio. He found them quickly.

"Can anybody hear me?" He spoke firmly into the mouthpiece as he released the safety on his handgun.

"Anyone?" He waited, hoping someone was listening.

"Who is this?" a male voice answered abruptly.

Devin gave a relieved sigh. "Reid. I came with Corden."

"Where are you?"

What difference did that make? "My room. Why is the power out?" Devin pressed his hand over his ear. "And what the hell is with the alarm?"

The guy simply said, "Everything is under control."

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Under control? Devin looked at his door as there

was thud from the other side. "What's under control?" He slowly moved toward the door.

"Please stay where you are. Security is on their way up."

Security? "What's going on?" he demanded. What weren't they telling him?

"We have people on their way to you," the man said firmly. "I must insist you stay in your room."

Fear tightened in Devin's chest, and frustrated, he threw the radio onto the bed. Fuck. Devin stared at the door. There was a loud knock. Someone was outside.

Raising his gun, he approached the door and leaned against the back of it. He squinted as he looked through the peephole. All he could see was darkness.

"Please!" someone cried through the door, accompanied by frantic banging.

"Who's there?" he called above the alarm. No one answered. What the hell was happening? Stepping back, he reached out for the door handle. This was such a bad idea.

He forcefully pulled open the door and pointed his

gun into the dark space. There was barely time to adjust his eyes to the thick blackness, before his heart jumped high in his chest. Altering his aim, he looked wide-eyed at the hand wrapped around his ankle.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

"Jesus," he gasped and grabbed the man by the shoulders. The guy was torn up pretty good, and a dark smear colored the pale carpet as he dragged the man inside the room.

Securing the door, Devin crouched beside the man.

"What happened?" The man wrapped his bloody, shaking hands around Devin's. Devin suddenly recognized him.

This man had been there when they took the sample of Noah's blood. "Where's my sister? Where's Emily?" He squeezed his fingers around the man's cold hands, trying to force the man to focus. "Hey!"

The man's eyes snapped open as he took in a sharp

breath. "It's too late," he wheezed and pulled Devin's hands tight to his chest. His blood was thick and sticky.

Devin grimaced as his hand pressed into the

mangled flesh of the man's chest. What had they done?

"He turned," the man suddenly said.

"What?" Who had turned? Who the hell had even been infected?

The man coughed. Dark red bubbled up out of his

mouth. "Corden." His bloodshot eyes fixed on Devin's. "It was Corden."

"How?" Devin didn't understand.

The man clutched at Devin's hand. He knew he was

dying. "Don't let me." He strained his neck as he leaned 208

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

forward. "Don't let me..." Strange sounds gurgled up from his throat as his head rolled limply to one side.

"Crap." The man was gone, and yet Devin

continued to hold onto his hand. It was already cold. He leaned forward and took up his gun, waiting those few inevitable moments to pass until the man's fingers jerked between his. There it was. Getting to his feet, Devin put a little space between him and the dead man and did what he had to. He fired his weapon.

For a moment he stared at the blood soaking into

the light-colored carpet. This wasn't supposed to happen.

Not here. Grabbing the radio from the bed, he spoke desperately into the mic. Security was heading up. Did they know they had a fucking zombie to deal with? "Hey, anybody still there? There are infected inside the tower. I repeat, there are infected inside the tower."

"Devin?" Kerry's tired and confused voice came through the earpiece.

"Kerry!" Thank, God. "Where are you?"

There was a silence before Kerry confessed, "I'm with Lukas." She fell silent again, before adding, "In his room."

"Good." Lukas had been given a room in the other building. "I need you to listen to me. I need you to find somebody, anybody, and get the second tower locked

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

down."

"What?"

"There's a dead guy in my room." He looked at the lifeless body beside the door.

"I'll be right there." Kerry suddenly sounded wide awake.

Devin shook his head. "I don't want you up here.

Lock the building down. No one gets in."

"Or out?"

There were over a hundred people in the tower.

"That's up to you. But..." He wrapped his hand around the door handle. "Be sure." They couldn't risk the infection getting out the building. He pulled open the door and looked into the dark hallway. "I'm going to find Emily."

"Wait—"

He wouldn't leave Emily alone. "I'll see you

downstairs," he insisted and ended the conversation, ramming the radio into the pocket of his jeans. He raised his firearm and squinted as he looked through the

blackness. His eyes slowly adjusted to the low light. The emergency light cast an eerie, red glow over the doors along the corridor. Carefully, he made his way forward, pushing every door he passed. Each one was securely shut.

Circling the floor, he found his way to the fire exit, and stepped out into the stairwell. Bloody handprints were 210

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

smear across the wall and around the railings. He contemplated what to do. Emily was in a room two floors below, Corden, however, had been placed in a large suite several floors above, and Noah, he had no idea. He stood and listened. Frustratingly, he couldn't hear anything above the continual ring of the alarm.

He shouldn't hesitate. Right now Emily was his

priority. Devin made the decision and quickly descended the stairs. Not looking where he was going, he was

surprised as his feet slipped on the stairs. Crashing into the corner of the stairwell, he turned and looked, wide-eyed upward. Fear swam at the back of his throat as it became clear the blood was not from one man making his way up to Devin's room. A dark puddle had run from one step down to another and then another. Someone was attacked here, maybe more than one person.

With a new sense of caution, Devin made his way

down another floor. Cautiously, he approached the sliver of light that shone into the stairwell. He hadn't expected to find the door open, and as he stood in front of it, he really wished he hadn't. A bloody leg was caught in the

space between the heavy fire door and the doorframe. How the hell had they let this happen?

Hugging the wall, Devin peered through the gap in

the door. The body trapped in the exit wasn't moving and 211

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

there didn't appear to be anyone else around. He hoped the alarm was warning enough for people to stay inside their rooms. Slowly, he pulled open the door, and leaned through the gap. There was no one there. He pulled the door open farther and slid through, allowing the door to fall back against the body lying on the floor. He checked out the man, grimacing as he noticed the man's barely attached head hanging at a strange angle against his shoulder.

Christ! Had Corden done that? Forcing himself to stay calm, Devin held his gun out in front of him and made his way along the corridor.

Emily was in room 3918 and Devin counted down

the numbered doors until he was standing outside her room.

Fear hit him hard as he stared at the busted door. He checked the number, hoping it was a mix up, but no, this was Emily's room. He entered the disheveled room.

Furniture had been knocked over and dark patches stained the floor from bloody shoes. This wasn't happening, he told himself, and edged inside. His eyes darted around the room, half-relieved when he was unable to find any more blood.

He stood in the middle of the room and closed his eyes. His heart beat loudly in his chest, and he focused on it as he took deep breaths. He needed to stay calm and clear-headed.

Opening his eyes, he looked at Emily's bed and

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

smiled. When they were children they would play Hide and Seek in their grandparents' house. Emily would always find the best hiding places. Crouching down, he lifted the edge of the valance and looked under the bed. Emily. She screamed wildly as he reached for her, and his fingers brushed her cool arm.

"Hey, no, it's me. It's me," he said in a hushed voice and pulled her toward him.

Emily grabbed at her brother and wrapped her arms

around his neck as they held each other close. She sobbed against his shoulder and clung fearfully to him.

"Shh, you're okay," he said and ran a hand over her hair and down her back "I'm here."

"Something was here," she said in a shaky voice.

"Something was here."

The alarm suddenly shut off and the lights in

Emily's room came on. "It's okay," he assured her, taking the chance to check her over in the light.

"It attacked those men. I was with one of them.

Craig. He was just showing me to my room. I'd been in the lab, working. We were right outside when someone

screamed. He told me to get inside and hide. He said it would be okay." She spoke quickly as she held Devin tight.

"I did what he said, but it got in. I heard him scream. It got in."

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Devin leaned back and cupped Emily's face in his

hands, wiping away her tears. "You're okay. Whatever it was, it's gone—"

Emily screamed again, as Devin was yanked from

her arms and thrown to the ground. "Devin!" she cried and frantically scrambled on her hands and knees across the room.

A fog settled over Devin's eyes and he struggled to shake it. Dazed, he looked up from where he had landed.

Corden was in the room, separating Emily from him. The only problem being, what was standing between them was no longer Corden. He looked at the newly-made monster's pale, bloodshot eyes, slowly reaching out for his dropped gun. It was as if it knew his intention.

"Fuck!" Devin yelled as Corden leapt forward and grappled him backward to the ground. He was insanely fast and stronger than ever, and Devin could do little to protect himself from Corden's clawing hands and snapping teeth.

Crying out, Devin forced his hand against Corden's jaw, struggling to hold back the man's head. He could hear Emily calling for him from across the room as he continued to fight off the attack. The weight of Corden bearing down on him was too much. His arm gave out and pain shot through his body. Corden's teeth tore into his hand and he desperately tried to shake the monster off.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

"Devin!" Emily continued to scream and for once Devin was glad she couldn't see what was happening.

"Run!" he roared. "Fucking run!"

Emily hesitated, and raised her hands in his

direction. He couldn't go with her, not this time.

"Run, Emily!" He cried out as his other arm bent back on itself and Corden fell heavily against his chest. He cried out as Corden's teeth sank into his shoulder and hit hard bone. "Run!" he screamed and held onto the feeding monster, locking its jaw into his shoulder. What did it matter? He was already dead.

Emily got to her feet and felt out the edge of the

room, until she found the door. And then she ran.

Devin held his breath as Corden's teeth grated

against his shoulder and toward his neck. It hurt like hell.

He had to give Emily as much time as he could. Wrapping his arm around the back of Corden's head, he pawed at the ground with his other hand in search of his gun. Where was it? His attention snapped back to Corden, as blunt

fingernails dragged down his arms and Corden's curled hands pushed hard into his stomach. Devin's hold loosened for a split second. Suddenly, the weight of Corden lessened and he was left reeling as a chunk of flesh was tore from him. He grabbed for his abused shoulder, trying to stem the blood-loss as he rolled onto his side. No. Corden was no 215

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

longer interested in him. He watched helplessly as Corden jumped sideways and started running, gaining momentum as he managed to get himself upright.

"No!" Devin called after him.

There was nothing he could do, and Devin watched

in horror as Corden fled through the broken door in pursuit of Emily. He couldn't lose her like this. With his remaining strength, he pushed himself onto his knees, before

struggling to his feet. He picked up his gun and supported his weak arm, holding his elbow as he took an unsteady step forward. Blood soaked into his T-shirt and rolled down his arm. He had time to set things right.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

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CHAPTER 16

What the hell happened? Noah raised a hand to his

mouth as he swallowed back the bile that stung the back of his throat. When the lights had gone out he hadn't known what to do, so he'd stayed hidden away in his room, sitting opposite his locked door with the heavy base of his bedside lamp in his hand. He wasn't an idiot. Alarms and power cuts were very rarely a good thing. When the lights came back up, he had dared to venture out of his room and into the elevator, making his way down to Devin's floor. Now, staring at the dead man in Devin's room, he kind of wished he hadn't.

"Devin?" He looked around the room. Devin and his gun were gone. Silently, he made his way along the corridor, following the intermittent trail of blood toward the fire escape. He stopped and stared at the shut door.

"What's going on?"

Noah jumped and spun around, surprised as he

came face to face with a young girl. She couldn't have been more than twelve years old and she was dressed in pink pajamas, with her blonde hair tied back from her face in two bunches.

"Who are you?" She tilted her head inquisitively 217

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

and looked past him at the blood covered door. "Is that blood?" She took a step back and looked nervously around her. "The alarm was going. But then it stopped. That means it's okay now, doesn't it?"

Noah wasn't sure what it meant. "I want you to go back to your room and lock yourself in," he suggested.

"Wait until someone comes to tell you it's safe."

"Where are you going?"

Locking himself in a room would be a pretty good

idea right now. He looked back along the corridor. "I need to find my friend." He had to be sure Devin was okay. The girl chewed on her bottom lip as she stared at him. She probably thought he was crazy. "Go back to your room.

Everything will be okay. Okay?" He waited, until the girl eventually nodded and headed back inside her room. Once the girl's door was securely shut, Noah turned back to the fire exit. The blood unsettled him. He just hoped Devin was safe.

The stairwell was poorly lit, and the enclosed space did nothing to calm his nerves. Resting against the railing, Noah leaned forward and looked up and then down at the spiraling stairs. Which way? His eyes settled on a line of blood on the steps below him. Down seemed as good a direction as any other. He followed the trail of blood down one floor and then a second. He stopped, his hand circling 218

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

the railing tightly as he strained to listen. Someone was shouting. The door on this floor was ajar and Noah

grimaced as he found the reason. Carefully, he pulled open the door and stepped over the dead man blocking the exit.

He leaned back against the side of the corridor and listened.

There it was again, a voice. Someone was crying out.

Stepping away from the wall, Noah started to make

his way along the corridor. As a child he had this recurring nightmare. He was lost in a maze of never-ending

corridors. One would always lead into another and another, and he was never able to find his way out. This building reminded him of that, the circular corridor looped around and around the building, with dozens of like-doors and identical light fixtures. You only knew you were on a second loop around when you came across the elevators after several minutes of walking.

"Run!"

Noah halted. There was no mistaking the urgency of

the voice. He stood and considered what to do. As Devin had pointed out, he was immune not invulnerable. He stared along the corridor and listened. Someone was heading toward him. He moved cautiously forward,

surprised to find Emily running in his direction. Her arms were outstretched as she kept her distance from the sides of the hallway. Stepping out, he blocked her path and caught 219

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

her in his arms. "Emily!"

Emily gave a half-scream, before she realized it was Noah. "N-Noah," she said breathlessly and reached up for his face. She flinched and whipped her head around as a wild cry echoed from behind her and something bounced hard off the side of the corridor. "It's here."

Noah narrowed his eyes and slowly pushed Emily

behind him. Along the hallway, the wailed cries were closing in on them. "Follow the wall on the left. You'll find a body and a door to the stairs," he instructed.

"What about you?" she asked, and tightened her hold on the back of his shirt.

There was no time to discuss this. "Get to another floor." He caught his breath as the monster finally appeared from around the bend. "Go now." He stretched his arms wide, protectively blocking Emily from the raging monster.

"Go!"

The blood-coated freak veered from side to side as

it made its way forward. Fresh blood covered its mouth, and had run down its neck and collected in the collar of its shirt. It took Noah a moment to realize who it was. Corden.

"I won't leave you!" Emily grabbed hold of Noah's hand.

Corden was nearly on them. "Fuck!" Noah held Emily's hand and pulled her by the arm. "Run!" They ran 220

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

together, but it was too late. Corden was there.

A burning heat soared through Noah's body as he

was flung sideways. Lights burst behind his eyes as his body crashed against the side of the passage. He was shaken, but Emily's screams quickly snapped him out of his daze. He leapt from against the wall and grabbed Corden's waist, tackling the dead man to the ground and away from Emily. Noah violently pounded his fists against Corden's head and back, before trying to wrap his hands around Corden's sticky, blood-slicked neck. He couldn't get a grip.

His hands slid across Corden's stained skin. Damn. Noah was surprised as the monster thrashed beneath him, and he was toppled sideways. In a mere second, Corden had

recovered and flew at Noah. His body pinned Noah's as his hands clawed at Noah's face. Noah tried to protect himself, but Corden smashed his hands down hard, slamming

Noah's head back against the solid floor.

Spots of color swirled across Noah's vision as he

reached up above him, frantically trying to keep Corden off him. He pressed firmly against Corden's chest and kicked out his legs as he tried to free himself. Corden's mouth opened wide as his full weight leaned forward, and Noah fought to keep him at a distance. His arms were failing him.

He didn't want to die like this. Bracing himself, he gave one last frantic push, hoping he could shift the man from on top

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

of him. But he couldn't. He had nothing left. Emily was sobbing behind him and all he wanted to do was tell her how sorry he was. He couldn't protect her.

Noah flinched and Emily screamed, as two gunshots

echoed around them. Noah looked up at the monstrous corpse. It had been hit. One bullet had blasted through its neck. The second had hit it in the head, leaving a bloody mess slowly trickling downward between its eyes. Noah lifted Corden's body upward and pushed it away. He leaned up on his elbows and looked down the corridor. "Devin,"

he said in between heavy breaths, and watched as Devin moved forward. "Devin?" He narrowed his eyes and looked at the gun Devin held in his bloody hand. He looked upward, following the blood up to Devin's shoulder. Blood glistened beneath the corridor lights, and Noah was hit with the terrible reality of what had happened.

Devin stood over the lifeless corpse and stared

blankly down at it. He raised his gun and aimed it at Corden's head, discharging the weapon and the remaining ammunition in quick succession. When there were no

bullets left, he looked at Noah and gave a sad smile.

Stepping back against the wall, he dropped the gun and slowly slid to the floor with a soft thud.

"Devin," Emily said. Slowly crawling forward, she reached out to her brother.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Devin looked at Noah and shook his head. She

shouldn't touch him. Noah caught Emily's hand and held it to his chest, guiding her toward him instead. He understood Devin's fears.

"What?" Emily asked. "What is it?" Noah held her hand tightly. He wasn't going to let go. "No," she said tearfully. "Please, no."

"It'll be okay." Noah pulled her close and comforted her. He watched Devin as he stared down at his shaking, bloodied hand. If that had been the only bite then maybe there would have been a chance. Noah swallowed

uncomfortably. Would he have been able to do what Devin had done for Jack?

"Reid."

Noah lifted his head and watched as two men

appeared from the stairwell. He looked at their guns and then back at Devin.

"Yeah," Devin said and leaned back his head.

"What the hell happened?" Noah recognized the man from St Louis. The second man, however, he didn't know and he watched as the guy kicked at Corden's lifeless body.

"He's dead, Travis."

"That'll be the six bullets in his face," Devin told him, and looked accusingly up at Travis. "Did you know?"

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Travis lowered his head, before giving a short nod.

"Then why the fuck wasn't he locked up?" Devin sounded defeated. "He should have been locked up."

"It was Mr Corden." Noah thought that wasn't nearly a good enough reason.

"I don't care if he was the fucking Pope," Devin said as he struggled to take full breaths. "You should have said something. You had no right to risk everyone's life."

Noah watched as Travis stepped back and raised his gun. He knew.

"Your shoulder." The gun was aimed at Devin's head. "What happened to your shoulder?"

Devin was finally getting angry. "What the fuck do you think happened?" He flinched as the safety was released on Travis's weapon.

"No," Emily pleaded. She had recognized the sound. "Don't."

"He's infected," Travis's companion stated.

"Wait," Noah said, leaning forward to position himself between Devin and the armed men. "Wait." He raised his hand and held it in front of the muzzle of the gun.

"Get out of the way," Travis insisted. "Devin's right."

I fucked up. I won't do it again."

"Do as he says, Noah," Devin said tiredly as he tried and failed to get to his feet.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

"No." Noah looked along the barrel of the gun. This was probably one of the stupidest things he had ever done.

"Don't you get it? Corden knew he was infected. Why do you think he had the blood sample taken so quickly? He would have put a rush on it, right?" He met Travis's eyes.

"He made you keep his secret. He needed time to find a cure."

Devin's hand came to rest on Noah's shoulder. "But he ran out of time, Noah." His grip on Noah's shoulder tightened as he broke into a coughing fit. "I've a couple hours, tops," he said as he caught his breath. "I've lost a lot of blood."

"No. You have to hold on." Noah turned back to Travis. "Let them try. Please. Give him a chance. If he turns before they finish, I'll shoot him myself."

Travis looked from Noah to Emily's tearstained

face. They all knew what his orders were, what he should have done when he found out Corden was infected, and what he should do right now.

"Please." Emily kneeled before them. She was willing to beg for her brother's life. "Give them, and me, some time."

"Fuck," Travis spat as he lowered his gun. He ran his hands back through his hair, before giving rushed orders. "Take him to his room, and he doesn't come out."

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

He turned to Noah. From the look in his eyes, it was clear he hoped he wouldn't live to regret his decision. "He's your responsibility." He held out his gun. "Take this and my radio."

Reluctantly, Noah reached up and took the gun. It

was heavier than he imagined. "Thank you." He glanced over his shoulder at Devin. He didn't seem as happy with the reprieve.

"Thank you," Emily chimed in. "It's going to be okay." She tried to reach out for her brother, but Noah once again blocked her hand.

"You should go," he prompted her. They were already short on time.

"I need to get to the lab. I can help."

"I'll take you." Travis reached out and took Emily's hand. "Adams will escort you two back to your room."

Emily leaned toward Noah. She reached out and

rested her hand gently against his chest. Her touch was warm through the material of his shirt. "Look after him."

She curled her hand against his chest. "Please."

There was nothing to say. If the doctors didn't come up with something in the next couple hours, Noah would probably have to kill her brother. They both knew that. He simply watched as Travis helped her to her feet and guided her back along the corridor.

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

"We should go," Adams said. He looked pale and eyed Devin nervously.

"Are you sure everywhere is clear?" Noah asked.

"There are a lot of people in this building."

Adams gave a firm nod. "The alarm was tripped on Corden's floor. The guys up there say it looks like he followed his guard into the stairwell and then down to this floor."

"And his guard?"

A grim expression passed over Adams's face. "He's the guy back there." He nodded past Noah and toward the dead body lying near the fire door. "I think we should get you both somewhere safe."

"My room would be best. There's kind of a dead guy in his," Noah pointed out.

"Whichever, but we should get moving."

Noah agreed and moved to Devin's side. "We need to go." Devin raised his eyes to Noah's. "It's okay." Noah reached out and held Devin's hand. His fingers were already cold and pale in comparison to what Noah

remembered. Getting to his feet, he pulled Devin with him.

"Let's get you cleaned up." He squeezed Devin's hand and pulled him close, hoping to elicit something from him, but there was nothing. Devin had already given up. "Don't you dare," he whispered in Devin's ear. He leaned back and met 227

Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

Devin's eyes. Devin might be ready to give up, but the hell if he was.

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Russell

CHAPTER 17

"Devin." Noah gently brought his hand up and beneath Devin's chin as he tried to get him to look at him.

"Devin," he said again and gave a small smile as Devin finally turned his head. They were sitting in the corner of Noah's room. Devin had his back against the large, glass balcony doors that overlooked the city. He didn't say anything, simply winced as Noah pressed a towel to the wound on his shoulder. "Hold this," Noah instructed as he focused on bandaging the bite on Devin's hand. "The bleeding's less."

Devin didn't seem to care and silently watched as

Noah wrapped his hand. As Noah tucked the bandage

securely under itself, Devin looked at him. "Why are you doing this?" he finally said.

"Your wounds need looking at."

Devin shook his head. "I mean, what's the point?"

"Why are you even bothering?" He curled his injured hand into a fist. "There is no point."

"How can you say that?" He just wanted to shake some sense into Devin.

"Look at me." When Noah couldn't, Devin roughly grabbed his arm, forcing him to look. "Look at me. It's 229

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Meredith

Russell

over, Noah. I'm done."

"No. Emily and the others, they'll—"

"What? Find a cure?" He leaned his head back against the drape over the balcony door. "It's too late. I know it, and so do you." He looked sideways at Noah. "I don't want to be one of those things."

Noah shook his head. He refused to let Devin just give up. "There's still time. Give them a chance."

"I don't want to hurt anybody. Just give me the gun and I'll do it myself."

There was still time, Noah reminded himself.

"You're not going to die. I'm not going to let you."

Laughter turned into a coughing fit, and Devin released Noah's arm. "You're a fool."

"Maybe, but you're all I've got." It was true. In this messed up world, Devin was the first good thing to come along in a long time. "I need you."

"Guess we're both screwed then," Devin said with a crooked smile. He groaned as he held his shoulder. "My arms gone to sleep," he complained.

"Here." Noah started to rub Devin's arm. He had never seen someone die of the virus, not slowly. Loss of blood and their injuries usually killed them first. "That help?"

Devin shook his head. "Not really." He was 230

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Things

Meredith

Russell

shaking.

"Are you cold?" Noah moved closer, and gently ran his hands up and down the length of Devin's arms.

Stopping, he looked into Devin's eyes. He struggled to remember the shade of blue they used to be. They were paler, almost silver-gray in color. "It'll be okay." He said it for his own benefit as much as Devin's. Things could still be okay. He had to believe that. Without thinking, he leaned forward and pressed his mouth to Devin's. Devin's lips trembled against his. They were cold and tasteless. He gently brought his hands up to Devin's face and held him steady, lessening the kiss before leaning back. "Sorry. It seemed like I had nothing to lose."

Devin looked at him thoughtfully. "I loved him, you know?"

"I know." He made comforting circles with his thumbs against Devin's cheeks. "He loved you too. I'm sure of that."

Devin smiled and rested his good hand over Noah's
against his cheek. "Thank you."

Noah returned the smile, before sliding into the

space beside Devin. He held Devin close, sharing the heat of his body as he wrapped his arm around Devin's shoulder.

He knew Connor had loved Devin, because how could
anyone not?

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Dead

Things

Meredith

Russell

They sat together for what seemed like an eternity, until the early morning sun rose, and cast a hazy glow through the half-drawn drapes and across the room.

Noah rested his head against Devin's and listened to the shallow breaths of the man beside him. He gently hummed to himself, a comforting tone for both of them as he held Devin's hand in his lap.

"Noah. Can you hear me?" Kerry's voice came across the radio he'd been given.

"Kerry. Hey," he said, looking down as Devin stirred beside him. "Please, tell me you have something." It had been just over two hours since he and Devin had been confined to the room. He was about to give up hope.

"Lukas is on his way up. They have something
but... there's no guarantee."

"I understand." But at least there was a chance. As Kerry went off the radio, he turned his attention back to Devin. "Devin." He gently nudged Devin's shoulder with his own, eliciting a small groan from Devin as he slowly opened his eyes. "Lukas is on his way."

Awkwardly, Devin tried to sit up. "They did it."

There was no relief in his voice. In fact, there was no emotion at all.

"They're on their way. It's going to be okay."

It suddenly became clear Devin didn't share the

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Things

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Russell

sentiment. With a pained expression, he insisted, "It's too late."

"You don't know that." Noah squeezed Devin's hands. They were deathly cold and drained of color.

"You don't either," Devin pointed out as he struggled to breathe.

"You can't give up. We're so close. They're on their way."

Devin dropped his head to Noah's shoulder and

reached across his legs. "Where's the gun?" he asked. "Give it to me."

Noah instinctively moved his hand to his side and

tightened his hold on the firearm. "No."

"Please. I don't want to spend even a second as one of those things," Devin said. He was obviously hurting.

This was crazy. Lukas was on his way. "You're still alive."

"I don't feel it."

Noah pressed a kiss to Devin's sweat-damp

forehead. "No offense, but you don't look it either," he forced the joke, and managed to smile as Devin laughed against his shoulder. "See, you're alive."

Devin seemed to accept the observation. "But if it doesn't work, I need you to promise me you'll get Emily home. Her baby needs its daddy."

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"Okay," Noah agreed. "But if it does, can you promise me something?"

"What?" His breathing sounded off.

"You'll give us a chance?" Devin's silence was deafening. "Could you do that?"

Devin moved awkwardly beside him, but eventually agreed. "Okay. If that's what you want."

It was what Noah wanted. He just hoped Lukas

would be here soon. He listened to Devin breathing, suddenly aware of how heavy Devin was against him.

"Devin." He looked down at the man beside him. "Devin."

Devin didn't answer. "Hey." He gently tapped the side of Devin's face. "No time to sleep."

Devin fought to open his eyes. "Just a little while," he managed.

"You have to stay awake." Noah rubbed his warm hands against Devin's cheeks. "Come on." He feared if Devin fell asleep, he would never wake up. Not as Devin.

He was suddenly surprised as Devin burst into life.

"I don't feel so good," Devin managed as he pushed away from Noah, just as the contents of his stomach erupted across the floor.

"It's okay." Noah held Devin's hand tightly and placed his other on his back. "Just hold on. Kerry," he spoke urgently into the radio mic. "Where the hell's 234

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Lukas?"

"He's right outside."

"Devin," Noah turned back to the man beside him.

"Come on, don't do this."

Devin groaned and leaned to one side as he vomited

for a second time. "Oh, God," he mumbled. The vomit was speckled with thick clots of blood. "Please." He grabbed at Noah's shirt. "You have to end this. I don't want to be one of them."

"You won't." Noah looked up as he heard a key turn in the door. It was going to be okay. The door opened and Lukas and Adams entered the room. "Hurry, please," he begged, as he pulled Devin to him.

Lukas stepped forward with a syringe gun in his

hand. "Get his arm," Lukas instructed, and waited for Noah to hold Devin steady. Lukas grabbed Devin's arm by the elbow with a gloved hand and pressed the syringe roughly against Devin's skin. Pulling the trigger he administered a serum into the sick man.

For a moment, the world slowed down, and Noah

was fooled into thinking this was it. It was going to be okay. That belief, however, was quickly ripped away from him as he was gripped with panic. Devin's whole body started to shake and convulse as Noah held him in his arms.

"Devin!" He wasn't going to let go. "Devin!"

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Noah felt heat explode across Devin's skin as he

thrashed in Noah's arms. It was the longest moments of Noah's life, until just as suddenly as they had begun, the convulsions stopped and Devin fell limp in his arms.

"He dead?" Adams asked as he raised his gun and stared down the sight of his automatic weapon.

Noah looked nervously up at Lukas and then back

at the unconscious man in his lap. His hand fell to the gun at his side, as he cautiously leaned forward. Closing his eyes, he listened. Devin was still

breathing. Thank God.

Relief washed over him as he looked at Adams. "He's alive."

Reluctantly, Adams lowered his weapon and

hitched the strap a little higher over his shoulder. He looked warily down at Devin and simply stated, "I'll be outside if you need me."

With Adams gone, Noah looked hopefully up at

Lukas. "Will you help me?" He looked past Lukas and to the bed.

Lukas looked Devin up and down, and then at his

own gloved hands. "Sure," he decided and stepped forward.

He wrapped his hands around Devin's ankles as Noah got to his feet and lifted Devin's shoulders. "You think he's gonna be okay?" Lukas asked as they carried Devin toward the bed.

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Carefully, Noah lowered Devin's shoulders to the

bed, and fixed the pillows. "He will be." Stepping back, he looked at Devin's peaceful face. "He's Devin."

"Do you need anything else?" Lukas asked as he began to edge toward the door.

Noah shook his head and then leaned down and

gently pulled back Devin's bangs. "We'll be fine." He let Lukas leave and listened for the sound of the door being locked, before bending down and kissing Devin on the forehead. He wasn't as cold to the touch anymore. There was warmth to Devin's skin, and maybe it was foolish, but Noah was happy to believe everything was okay now.

Affectionately, he brushed back Devin's hair and watched the small rise and fall of the man's chest. Devin was alive.

* * * *

Noah slowly opened his eyes to a new morning. It

had been a day since Devin had been injected with the serum created from his antibodies, and Noah was anxiously waiting for Devin to wake. He watched the gentle throb at the side of Devin's throat. His pulse was strong. He smiled and rested his hand on Devin's chest as he breathed. The motion was comforting. Devin was still with him.

A sharp intake of breath from Devin surprised him,

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and Noah found himself looking into curious eyes.

"Devin." He reached up and touched Devin's face.

Devin appeared disorientated as he looked around

the room, and then back at Noah. "What happened?"

"What do you remember?" Noah answered with his own question.

Devin slowly raised his bandaged hand and looked grimly at it. "Corden."

Taking Devin's hand in his, Noah held it tenderly.

"It's okay. He's dead. You're safe."

"Emily?" he remembered.

Noah smiled. "She's fine. She came to see you last night. You were sleeping."

Devin looked down at himself. While he'd been asleep, Noah had cleaned him up and changed his clothes.

"How long was I out?"

"A little over a day. You had us all scared there for a while." He moved his head against the pillow and looked at Devin. He tried hard not to stare, but he couldn't help it.

It was strange seeing Devin looking back at him.

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing." He never was good at lying.

"Am I?" Devin looked at his hand beneath Noah's.

His memory was returning. "I should be dead."

Noah shook his head. "You're fine."

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Wearing a frown, Devin rolled onto his back. "Then why do I feel like you're not telling me everything?"

He wasn't. "You're okay and that's all that matters."

"Tell me." Devin held his hand out in front of him and slowly closed his palm around the bandage.

"The serum they created worked. It fought off the virus."

"But?"

What was he supposed to say? "It's nothing." It was such a small thing. It didn't make a difference to him and it shouldn't to Devin or anyone else. Devin turned his head and looked at him, waiting. "Your body was dying. Some damage was just irreparable, I guess." This hadn't sounded so clinical in his head. "Your eyes."

Devin looked confused. He could obviously see just fine.

"I mean the color of them." He looked into Devin's eyes. The man he knew was still behind them. It shouldn't matter. "I don't know why, but they've changed."

Devin sat up and stared across the room to the bathroom. He didn't have the energy just yet.

"Maybe you should rest."

"I want to see."

Noah sat up and contemplated the request. There was a mirror on the dresser. "Okay," he decided and got out 239

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of bed. "You shouldn't worry." He picked up the heavy mirror from the dresser and carried it toward the bed.

Carefully, he climbed back onto the bed and shuffled to Devin's side, resting the mirror across their legs. He looked at Devin in the silver surface. "See."

Devin leaned closer to the mirror and gently lifted his brow and opened his eyes wide. "I look like one of them." He leaned back from the mirror and pushed it away from him. He had seen enough.

"Are you okay?" Noah remembered when he'd first seen Devin's eyes. The deep blue had been replaced with a murky gray, and the all too familiar red and gold flecks of undead eyes now littered his irises.

Devin took a deep breath, composing himself before

he turned back to Noah. "Like you said, I'm fine." Noah wasn't convinced. "So, what's a guy got to do to get something to eat in this place?"

Noah considered Devin for a moment and the

change of subject. He obviously wasn't okay, but there was nothing Noah could do to fix that. He figured Devin just needed some time. "I'll get you

something," he offered and took back the mirror as he got to his feet.
"Maybe I should get someone to check on you."

That had been the wrong thing to say. "No. I don't want to see anyone,"
Devin insisted and pulled the bed 240

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sheets tighter to his waist. "I just want to be left alone." He turned to face Noah. The look in his eyes wasn't subtle. He didn't want to see anyone, and that included Noah.

"Sure. I'll get someone to bring you something up."

He slid the mirror back onto the dresser, before collecting his clothes from the floor. "I won't go far," he assured Devin as he quickly pulled on his jeans, a pale green T-shirt, and black-trimmed tennis shoes. "So, if you need anything, you only need to ask." He smiled warmly as he walked around the bed, though he knew Devin would never ask for anything.

"Thank you," Devin said and averted his eyes toward the balcony. He was already hiding.

Hesitating beside the door, Noah looked at Devin.

He doubted there was much he could say right now that would help. "You're okay, right?"

"Of course." Devin looked over his shoulder and gave a small smile as he pointed out, "I'm alive."

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CHAPTER 18

Another two days passed, and Devin was ready to

head back to Kansas. He hated how people acted around him here, and wished things could just go back to normal.

Normal. What the hell was normal anymore? He sat silently in the driver's seat of the fixed up SUV and ran his hands over the steering wheel. He liked the solid feel of it beneath his fingers. It was safe and secure. He watched the people moving around the parking garage. A group was heading out to bag themselves one of the walking freaks so they could test the serum on a fully changed being. They wanted to see if the serum would attack the virus and kill it. Maybe then, with the infection gone, the mutated human body would return to nothing more than a rotting, very dead corpse. Emily, however, had her doubts. Devin had been alive when injected with the anti-serum so his body had been able to process and use it to fight the infection. She questioned whether there was any way a reanimated dead body would actually be able to metabolize it.

Devin pushed the sunglasses he wore farther up his

nose, and leaned back in his seat. Noah was standing in front of the car. Was it too late to duck? Noah stared at him through the new windshield, his hands on his hips as he 242

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pursed his lips and rolled his eyes. It was definitely too late.

"So this is where you've been hiding." Noah sounded relieved as he slid into the passenger seat and pulled the door closed.

"I wasn't hiding," he lied and rolled his head to the side, looking at Noah through his dark glasses. "I just needed some space." Noah smirked at him. "What?"

"I'm not sure this thing would be the first place I'd go looking for space," Noah laughed.

Devin sighed and curled his hands more tightly

around the steering wheel. "I meant from people. I feel like everybody's looking at me."

"Maybe that's because they are. Devin Reid, zombie survivor. And hopefully the first of many."

Devin shook his head. That wasn't the impression

he got. "More like, Devin Reid, is he going to rip my face off?" He grinned. He at least had thought it was funny.

Noah gave Devin a despairing look. "No they don't."

Devin shrugged and looked at Noah. He looked different. "You shaved."

"Stop changing the subject."

Devin sighed. Everything seemed weird. He felt

strange and couldn't shake himself out of it. He'd nearly died and become one of those freaks. But he hadn't. He'd 243

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survived. Why wasn't he happy about that?

"Have you ever felt completely lost?" he asked. It wasn't just his eyes that had changed. He couldn't explain it, but he just didn't feel right or how he remembered.

"In what way?"

"I don't feel like me anymore," Devin admitted.

Leaning forward, Noah raised his hands to Devin's face. "You are you."

Devin caught Noah's wrists. "Don't." He hated his eyes, and began to pull away as Noah's fingers brushed the frame of his dark glasses.

"They don't scare me."

Devin closed his eyes, and let Noah remove the shades. He let out a soft sigh as Noah ran a thumb gently over his cheek.

"Open your eyes," Noah prompted.

He wasn't sure he wanted to see the sympathy in Noah's eyes. He just wanted to feel like himself again.

"Devin."

There were some things he could never run from.

Admitting defeat, he dropped his shoulders and opened his eyes. He was uncomfortable and embarrassed. "They're disgusting."

Noah shook his head and looked fondly at Devin.

Devin's repulsion of himself was not reflected within 244

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Noah's eyes. "No, they're not." He leaned forward and kissed Devin's cheek. "They're kind of cool actually," he said with a reassuring smile.

Devin lowered his head. He didn't want Noah

treating him with kid gloves. Emily had done plenty of that already. He was suddenly surprised as Noah leaned farther into his space. "Noah."

"Don't say anything." Noah moved closer and rested his forehead against Devin's. Noah was warm and the closeness was comforting. "Just let me be here. Just this once," he whispered as he pressed his face to Devin's.

Devin closed his eyes and tried to let himself enjoy the closeness. He'd felt numb since waking up after what happened. Noah's lips trailed down the side of his face and to the curve of his neck. Slowly, he opened his eyes and stared out the front of the car. People would see. "Noah, stop," he said in a low voice, and pushed his hands between them. "Not here."

"Do you want to go upstairs?" Noah lowered his head, embarrassed. "That came out wrong."

Devin laughed as he rested his head on Noah's

shoulder. "Actually," he started. "I'd like that." He had thought hiding from Noah was the best for both of them.

He now realized how wrong he'd been. Noah was solid and real, and made Devin feel halfway normal.

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"Is this you running away again?" Noah asked suspiciously, and looked out the front of the car.

Devin took the sunglasses from Noah's hand. He

wasn't going to lie. "I've had enough weird looks for one day." Sliding them back on, he reached for the car door handle. "But I made you a promise." He got out the car and pushed the door shut with a purposeful thud. Without another word, he started to walk away. Risking a glance over his shoulder, he felt kind of relieved. Noah was right behind him.

* * * *

Devin kept his promise to Noah. Though difficult at first, he gradually opened up, allowing Noah to ask his questions about Devin's family, Connor, his home, and then about the two of them. Could there be a future for Noah and Devin to share together?

Devin let Noah in and he knew Noah was unlikely

to leave without a fight. The more they talked and the closer they became, made Devin aware of how grateful he was of Noah's company. However, it left an uneasy feeling in his chest.

He'd never really relied on anyone before, not even Connor. He'd been a soldier and it had been his job to look 246

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after everybody else. But being here now and having Noah care for him, he didn't want lose that just yet. After that realization, something changed and forty minutes of talking turned to gentle touches of their hands, and then to kissing.

Noah leaned back and looked at Devin. His deep

brown eyes radiated warmth. "That okay?" He ran his hands over Devin's thighs and leaned forward for another kiss.

The kiss was feather-light. "It's fine," Devin said honestly. "I'm fine."

Noah smiled. "We can stop if you want."

Devin shook his head. "It's fine. Really." He leaned forward, kissed the corner of Noah's mouth, and gently touched his face. Never letting his lips leave Noah's, he shuffled a little closer, and cupped Noah's jaw. Noah breathed slowly through his nose and his small breaths blew against Devin's cheek. Devin moved his hand

gradually backward and around Noah's neck. His fingers curled in the back of Noah's hair as he pulled him close, and he began to tease his tongue against Noah's mouth.

Closing his eyes, Devin eased Noah's lips apart. His tongue was granted access to the warm, wet cavern of Noah's mouth. His body ached as he arched forward and began to work his tongue in waves against Noah's. They stayed like that for a long moment. Each man tasted and 247

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kissed the other, accompanied always by warm touches of each others' skin.

Devin breathed in deeply and then slowly pulled

away. There were still so many conflicting feelings running rampant in his head. Noah continued to caress the nape of Devin's neck with his fingers and Devin was reluctant to say what he was about to. He knew it would change the course of the moment.

"I've been thinking," he said and it was no surprise when Noah stilled his hand. "We're supposed to head back to Kansas tomorrow." He looked at Noah. Did Noah already know what he was going to say? "I want you to consider staying here."

Noah's hand fell away. "Stay?"

"You'd be safe here."

"I'm safe with you."

"You saw what happened just trying to get here, and maybe it could be a great opportunity for you." He gave an encouraging smile. "Some of the others are staying, Flynn, Travis, and Lukas."

"Emily?" Noah sounded serious.

"No, not Emily."

Noah shook his head. "If this was about safety, you wouldn't be taking Emily all the way back there."

"Emily has a reason to go back. Jack and the baby."

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Noah narrowed his eyes. "You don't think I have a reason?"

Sure he had a reason. Devin just didn't think it was a very good one. "I don't want you to make any quick decisions you might regret. It's been an intense week. I just want you to be aware there is more out there."

"More? More what?"

Devin started to wish he'd kept his mouth shut. He

hadn't meant to ruin their time together. "I don't know. Just more. More than this."

"More than you?" Noah squeezed Devin's thigh. "Is that what you think?"

Could he be honest? "I don't want you to think I'm your only option." He smiled sadly. Once upon a time he had been able to laugh and enjoy life. That part of him had died with Connor, and he wasn't sure he remembered how to love, or let himself be loved anymore. "Maybe there's better out there." He waited, watching as Noah leaned closer to rest his chin on Devin's shoulder.

"I don't want better," Noah whispered. "You're enough."

Devin closed his eyes. If he was enough, why didn't he feel it?

"You spend so much time looking out for everyone else. Maybe you should let someone look after you." Noah 249

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teasingly rubbed the tip of his nose against Devin's cheek.

"What do you want, Devin? You must have had dreams once upon a time."

Dreams belonged to children. "There's no room for dreams in this world." He pulled away and looked firmly at Noah. "Dreams get you killed. There's just blood and tears and heartache." He looked at Noah. "You know that."

"And? What would you have me do? Be like you

and give up on everything and everyone? "

"I'm just being realistic."

"No. You think it's easier to push everyone away because you're scared of losing them." Noah was agitated.

"But what's the point of all this, if there's nothing to risk?

What are you fighting for?"

"Emily—"

"No." Noah reached forward and circled his hands around the back of Devin's head. "What are *you* fighting for?" he emphasized the question as he looked deep into Devin's eyes.

He didn't know.

"I'd fight for you," Noah said seriously. "So if you think I'm going to let you push me away, then you're wrong. I won't let you leave me behind." He waited. There was hope in his eyes.

Devin relented and leaned forward. He just wanted

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to feel something again. Just for a little while. Hesitantly, he moved closer, giving Noah a timid kiss. He didn't really want Noah to stay in Chicago. He just thought Noah should have the choice. "I still think you're a fool," he said as he pulled back.

Smiling, Noah wrapped his hands around Devin's

and pulled them down to hold them against his warm chest.

"Maybe I am." He kissed Devin. "But I'd rather be a fool than be without you."

Devin searched Noah's eyes and found in them the

strength he needed. It was his turn to kiss Noah as he leaned forward and pressed his lips to Noah's. Slowly, he ran his hands over Noah's chest, feeling the material beneath his fingers. He worked his way downward,

hooking his fingers under the hem of Noah's shirt. His fingertips brushed the hot skin of Noah's stomach, and it encouraged him to venture higher. He continued to kiss Noah, and closed his eyes as he moved his fingers upward from prominent hipbones, across Noah's flat stomach, and to his firm chest. The feel of Noah was amazing. He was warm and solid and safe.

Eventually, Devin stopped and opened his eyes. Noah was looking down at him with such passion and desire. It was then Devin decided he was ready to be a fool.

Noah rested his hands over Devin's jeans. "Are you 251

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sure?" he asked. He clearly knew it was difficult for Devin.

Devin made his choice. He was sure. No more

waiting. They didn't have that luxury. Not in this world.

And he didn't need anymore regrets than he already had.

Awkwardly, he pulled at Noah's shirt, lifting the pale blue material upward as he tried to remove it. The move was hardly graceful, as Noah became twisted in his clothing.

"Stop." Noah laughed and tugged his shirt back down. "Stop." He smiled, leaning in to kiss Devin as he began to unfasten the buttons of his shirt. Getting to his feet, he kicked off his shoes and quickly removed the rest of his clothes.

Devin wasn't sure what he expected, but the sight of Noah standing before him, naked, was breathtaking. Noah was perfect. Hesitantly, he removed his own clothes. What if he was a disappointment? He knew Noah found him

attractive. Noah had never shied away from the connection between them. Hope had got Noah this far, the hope of the two of them reaching this moment. Devin met Noah's eyes as he pushed his pants and underwear down over his hips.

Noah wasn't disappointed. With a renewed confidence, Devin decided he wanted to do this for Noah, but more importantly, he needed to do it for himself. This was his chance to have something good and close to normal. What if they never got another chance?

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Taking Devin by the hand, Noah guided him farther

onto the bed. In between kisses, each man explored the other's body, their fingers pressing against and gliding over smooth skin and firm muscle. Was this real? Devin smiled inwardly as his hands moved over Noah's hard body, and across his shoulders and back. Yes, it was real. He lingered over the raised pattern of scars on Noah's arm and

shoulders. Noah was warm and alive. They both were.

Everything they'd been through had led them to this moment. It was a moment so different to any other they had shared. For the first time in a long time, Devin felt safe.

Devin caught his breath, pulled from his thoughts as Noah's strong arms circled his waist and spun him around.

He fell back onto the bed with Noah above him. It was like his skin was on fire as he arched up into Noah's heated touch. Their fingers linked together, as Noah raised Devin's hands above his head and carefully pushed them into the soft bedding. Noah stopped and looked down at Devin.

What Devin saw in Noah's eyes was almost identical to what he'd seen in Connor's eyes all those months ago. Noah wanted, needed, and, he realized

now, loved him. There was more though. The harsh reality of their world was still there, lurking behind Noah's eyes. The last several months haunted him. It haunted them both. Like so many others, they had lost people close to them—Noah, his family, and 253

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Devin, the man he had loved.

Noah gently nudged Devin's legs apart and Devin

reacted by leaning up. He caught Noah's mouth in a chaste kiss, before lying back down. Carefully, Noah slid into the space between Devin's legs and aligned their bodies. Heat coursed through him. Noah was hard, and Devin was right there with him. It was how it was supposed to be. Devin shifted uncomfortably in response to Noah grinding down, creating pressure against Devin's bruised chest and hips. He didn't mind so much. It reminded him he was alive because of Noah. Closing his eyes, he let Noah distract him with firm kisses. He curled his fingers between Noah's and arched upward, seeking out contact with the man above him.

Their arousal was gaining momentum, and he lifted

his legs to wrap them around Noah's waist. Devin wanted to keep Noah close. He wanted to protect him, and keep him safe from everything that would harm them in their uncertain world. He'd failed to protect Noah from Corden and his scheming, but not again. He owed Noah his life.

Arching his neck, he pushed his mouth to Noah's in the desperate desire to have more contact. He needed more.

Devin's breath hitched in his chest, as Noah released Devin's hands and reached down between them.

Noah gave Devin a light kiss before he paused.

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With his free hand, Noah gently stroked Devin's hair away from his forehead and pulled back. It was like the world was slowing down as Noah brushed the tip of his nose against Devin's and pecked tender kisses to Devin's accommodating mouth. "This doesn't mean you've forgotten him," he said in a low voice. "They'll always be with us."

Devin pressed his mouth into a line. He wasn't the

same man Connor had loved. He knew that. So much had happened since the morning he woke in a twisted world.

From then it was about survival, his and Emily's.

Somewhere along the way he had become a little

twisted as well. Emily had seen what he was becoming, and warned him about losing himself in the horror outside. He had held on so tightly to his memories of Connor, using them as an excuse to separate himself from everyone else.

The truth was his memories were all he had to keep him human. They reminded him he used to be able to feel something for someone else.

"I know," he agreed in a hushed voice and kissed Noah. He had something, someone, else to hold onto now.

It was time to start moving forward again. It was time to let Connor go.

Meeting Noah's eyes, Devin smiled. Connor would
have liked Noah. He was sure of that. He kissed Noah 255

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again and gave a half-groan as Noah brushed his fingertips along the length of Devin's erection. Noah's touch was gentle and he began a tender rhythm as he moved around Devin.

Closing his eyes, Devin enjoyed the sensation. He

didn't want to feel guilty anymore. Memories flooded through him of family and friends and of regrets and loss.

He looked at Noah. In Noah's eyes he saw the possibility of new memories, and a future he could be part of, as a friend and as a lover.

Devin wrapped his arms around Noah's neck,

pulling Noah down into a kiss. It was time to let go of all the crap he had been carrying around with him for the best part of a year. Arching upward, he nipped and sucked at Noah's lower lip. He encouraged Noah to continue and mumbled lustful sounds against his mouth. He groaned as Noah's strokes became stronger and faster.

Dropping back to the pillow, Devin pulled Noah

with him, not wanting to break the kiss. His spine curved as he lifted his hips from the bed and pressed his dick firmly into the palm of Noah's hand. It felt so good.

With a sigh, Devin separated their mouths and took

full breaths as he looked up at Noah. Should he say something? Their eyes briefly met and he realized words weren't needed. Everything was perfect—so different to the 256

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cold, unreciprocated experience with Corden. This meant something.

Devin closed his eyes as Noah leaned down and laid

tender kisses along his jaw and neck. The attention Noah gave his body was overwhelming. He licked and sucked and nipped his way across Devin's chest. Each hot kiss made Devin's skin tighten with an excited shiver. Noah pulled and teased at his erection, and a swipe of Noah's thumb across the head of his dick had Devin melting. He arched his body upward into Noah's fist. There was no going back now. He wanted more.

After a few pleasurable, but long moments, Devin

could take no more. Lifting his head from the pillow, he buried his face in Noah's shoulder and held him tightly with his aching arms. He stifled a cry as he climaxed, his teeth grazing Noah's hot skin as he held on to the only person who mattered at that moment.

A white heat sparked behind his eyelids as he came

hot and hard across Noah's hand. With panted breaths, he wrapped his arms around Noah and laid light kisses to the side of Noah's face and neck. They stayed that way for a while, Noah whispering comforting words against the side of his face as they held onto each other.

"You okay?" Noah eventually asked as he wiped his hand on the bedding. He smiled at Devin and leaned back.

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Devin felt flushed as he dropped exhausted back to

the bed. He looked up at Noah. "That was..." He reached up and gently tucked a loose strand of Noah's hair behind his ear. He smiled contently as he brushed the back of his hand over Noah's clean-shaven jaw.

Noah flashed Devin a bright smile, before leaning

down to kiss him. He pressed his lips to Devin's cheek.

"That was," he whispered. "Amazing." It definitely was.

Smiling, Devin sat up and lowered his feet to the

bedcovers. He stroked Noah's thighs as he worked his hands upward and teased his fingers in the hair below Noah's stomach. He moved lower, reaching down to hold Noah's dick. It was hard and heavy in the palm of his hand.

He locked his eyes with Noah's as he set a rhythm, and smiled as Noah's eyelids fluttered shut.

His gaze swept over Noah's face and settled on his

lips. He missed kisses. Though the move was awkward, Devin managed to maneuver himself onto his knees. He continued the caressing motion around Noah's dick as he stole tender kisses. His fingers danced in the curls of hair at the nape of Noah's neck.

"Devin," Noah managed between kisses.

Leaning back, Devin looked up at Noah. Was something wrong?

"I just want you to know I love you." He reached 258

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out and cupped Devin's jaw. "And I can wait." His eyes held hope that maybe one day Devin could say the words back to him.

Devin contemplated making a grand gesture and repeating Noah's declaration. But he knew he shouldn't.

Not until he could say it openly and honestly. Noah didn't need to be lied to, and from the look in his eyes, he didn't want that. Devin simply nodded and pulled Noah into a sloppy kiss.

"Stop talking," he whispered. "Lie down." He waited for Noah to get in position. He then edged forward and straddled Noah's thighs. God, Noah looked good

beneath him.

Devin gently teased Noah's erection. Seductive

sounds rolled off Noah's tongue and he curled his hands in the material of the bedcovers. Devin sensed the tension coursing through Noah and it excited him.

A few firm strokes later and Noah came across

Devin's hand. Devin looked down at Noah, breathless, with sweat glistening across his chest, as he gazed at Devin through his lashes. With a playful growl, Noah caught Devin off guard and wrapped his arms around his waist, pulling Devin to the bed beside him. They laughed as they rolled across the covers and into each other's arms. They lay together in a sticky mess, sharing a quiet moment while 259

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gazing into each other's eyes. Noah looked exactly how Devin felt—happy.

Slowly, Devin shuffled farther into Noah's hold,

closed his eyes, and pressed his mouth to Noah's. The kiss conveyed all the hope he had for their future. He smiled as Noah reached up and gently stroked his cheek. Everything that had gone before was forgotten. They had hope and they also had each other, and Devin knew that was enough.

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CHAPTER 19

It was time to head home. Devin glanced across the hood of the car at Noah. A wide smile spread across his face as their eyes met for a moment.

"Are you two doing the gooey eyes thing?" Devin jumped as Emily appeared at his side with Hank. She sighed as she reached out to find the car door. "You are, aren't you?" She screwed up her face, pretending to be disgusted. "Someone get me a bucket."

Devin laughed and opened the door for her. As his first three passengers got in the back of the car, he spotted Kerry crossing the garage toward them.

"You ready?" he asked, noticing the large bag of candy in her bandaged hand.

Kerry looked at the bag and shrugged. "It's for the drive," she insisted as she walked around the car. "I was going to share."

Devin grinned and pulled open the driver's side door. "Of course you were."

Sighing, Kerry got into the front passenger seat.

"The others are staying here," she stated and awkwardly pulled on her belt. Luckily, it had only been a sprain.

"Yeah," Devin said. He cast a sideways glance, and 261

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wondered how she felt about it. She had spent a lot of time with Lukas these last few days. "I guess one place is just as good as any other right now." Looking over his shoulder, he grinned. "Plus I heard they just couldn't take having to play I - spy with Emmi for the next eight hours," he teased.

Emily huffed from the backseat and folded her

arms. "You love it," she told him, and fastened her belt.

"Besides, I plan on taking a long nap, assuming you aren't planning on driving us through any freak nests on the way home."

Rolling his eyes, Devin put on his shades. "I think that can be arranged," he said as he started the engine.

"Everybody ready?" he checked. "Last chance if you want to change your mind." He waited, but nobody had any intention of backing out and staying in Chicago. "Okay then." He put the car in reverse and pulled out of the parking space. Switching to drive, he drove the car down the several floors of parking, until they got to the ground floor. Slowly, he approached the large metal barrier and nodded to the armed men sitting at each end of it. "I've been thinking though. We're going to make a stop."

"Really? Where?" Kerry asked with a full mouth.

At this rate she'd finish off the bag before they got out of the city.

"Garnett." He watched the men pull back the barrier 262

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to let them through.

Kerry glanced over her shoulder at Noah. "You mean the farm?"

Devin nodded as he guided the car forward and out onto the street.

Noah met Devin's eyes as he looked in the mirror, and asked, "Why?"

"I thought you might like a few of your things,"

Devin said as they crossed the river. "We didn't exactly stick around the last time we were there."

Noah remained silent.

"It was just an idea. If you don't want to—"

"No, I do," Noah quickly interrupted. "It's just..."

He lowered his head, and Devin could see Emily leaning toward him offering comfort. "I guess it'll be a chance to say goodbye."

Devin focused on the road and tightened his hands

around the steering wheel. He wished he had gotten the chance to say goodbye.

* * * *

"She was annoying as hell," Noah said as he picked up the family photograph from the nightstand. He raised his hand to his mouth and

pressed a kiss to his fingertips, 263

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before touching the image of his sister. He smiled and looked over his shoulder at Devin. "I miss her." He turned back and gazed mournfully around his sister's room. "I miss them all."

Devin wished he had some words of comfort to

offer Noah, but there was nothing he could possibly say to make things okay. He gently rested his hand on Noah's shoulder and looked sadly at the picture. "I'm sorry."

Wiping at his eyes, Noah breathed in deeply and

composed himself. "I should get my things," he said and held the photo to his chest. It was a memory for him to cherish. "They're just down the hall."

"I'll be right there." He waited for Noah to leave the room, before making his way to the large window at the front of the house. Everything appeared peaceful outside.

He looked down at the car. Emily was safely inside, while Hank and Kerry kept look out. He waved his hand as Kerry looked up at the window. He motioned they were heading to the back of the house and held up his hand, indicating five fingers for five more minutes. Kerry gave him a short, sharp nod, and Devin followed after Noah.

He stood silently in the doorway of Noah's

bedroom, and watched as Noah hurried around the room, quickly throwing some clothes into the black trash bags they'd found in the kitchen. It was

kind of sad to watch 264

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Noah as he collected together the contents of his life. "We have time," he said, aware Noah was rushing through each drawer.

Noah shook his head. "I'd rather get out of here," he said as he wiped his hand under his nose.

Devin lowered his head knowingly. "I'll just wait outside," he decided. Noah should have some time to himself.

Stepping out of the room, he made his way to the

top of the stairs and sat down on a step. A sense of grief washed over him as he noticed the dark stain on the carpet at the bottom of the stairs. He hadn't thought much of it the first time he was here, but now he couldn't stop thinking about all the people he and Noah had lost. He rubbed his hand against his vest, trying to ease away the low ache that spread through his chest. He needed a distraction. Getting back to his feet, he headed downstairs. Stopping by the broken front door, he looked out across the garden. It all seemed so long ago. Idly, he wandered into the living room and looked around. He chewed on his lower lip as he looked at the remains of the freak that had attacked him.

Grimacing, he examined the dead body. Someone, or rather something, had ripped out and eaten its stomach.

Respectfully, Devin took the throw from the couch and laid it over what had once been a man. Maybe this hadn't been 265

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such a good idea. Noah was obviously upset, and he was quickly becoming more and more uncomfortable with

returning to the farm. So much had happened since then.

"Done." Noah appeared at the bottom of the stairs, his gaze falling to the covered body.

"Do you have everything you need?" Devin drew Noah's attention back to him. "It might be a long time before you come back here."

"I've got what I need," Noah uttered. "But I have one thing I need to do before we leave."

"Sure," Devin said, and reached and took the black bags from Noah.

Noah looked at his belongings in Devin's hands.

"Will you come with me?"

"Where?" Devin asked curiously.

With a sad smile, Noah simply said, "You'll see."

Devin watched as Noah left the living room and

headed outside. He took one last look around the room, and tried to remember when things had been this simple. He glanced down at the corpse. How did the world get so messed up? He followed Noah out to the car, leaving Noah's belongings with the rest of the group, before heading behind one of the barns.

Reality hit as they turned a corner and Devin found himself standing in front of five slightly raised humps in 266

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the ground. Daisies and grass had grown out of the piled dirt. He watched as Noah leaned down and pulled a weed from one of the mounds. Everything Noah had once called family now rested beneath them.

"Is it wrong I buried Tasha with them?" Noah asked as he got to his feet.

It took a moment for Devin to remember where he

had heard the name. It was the name of the family dog.

Devin shook his head. "Of course not. She was family too."

Noah looked at the graves. "Dad, well, whatever he was, broke her neck. She didn't turn or anything." He turned to Devin. "I'm glad she didn't." Moving to Devin's side, he slipped his hand into Devin's.

The warmth as Noah leaned into Devin was

comforting. "Was she an old dog?" he asked in the vain hope of idle conversation.

"We had her from a puppy. I was ten at the time."

He looked from the graves out across the field, lost in his own thoughts.

Devin gently reached across and rested his free

hand on Noah's shoulder. "We need to go," he said in a low voice. "It's not safe to stay too long."

Noah closed his eyes, and a tear escaped from

between his lashes and slowly rolled down his cheek. He wiped a hand across his face and nodded. He knew they 267

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had to go. "Thank you for letting me say goodbye properly."

Devin leaned closer and pressed his mouth into a

tender kiss against Noah's cheek, before resting his chin on Noah's shoulder. "At least you got to," he said, hoping it would give Noah some small comfort. "It's more than most have."

Wiping at his cheek, Noah squeezed Devin's hand.

Devin was right.

"Let's go," Devin suggested and slowly began to walk away, guiding Noah by the hand and back toward the car. It was time to move on.

* * * *

The SUV rolled through the second set of gates and

pulled into an empty bay. Devin cut the engine, and he and his passengers sat reflectively for a short moment.

"Home," Emily said tiredly from the backseat. "Is it weird I've missed it?" She sighed as she leaned forward through the gap in the seats. "Because I have."

Devin turned and looked at Emily, Hank, and then

Noah. "I kind of missed it too," he told her, and met Noah's eyes as he smiled.

"I feel sick," Kerry suddenly moaned from the 268

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passenger seat. It was pretty clear the reason.

"You seriously ate three bags?" Devin looked at the empty bags of candy on the floor of the car by her feet.

They had stopped at the store they'd visited on their first trip to Garnett. In fact, the trunk was crammed full with all sorts of supplies. He eyed the remaining bag and laughed.

Some supplies had been more essential than others

obviously. "I need a shower and some sleep," he decided and pushed open the driver's door.

"God, yes," Kerry agreed.

"Don't go using all the hot water," Hank told Kerry with a smirk.

Devin smiled and got out of the car. He sighed as he rested his arms on the roof of the vehicle, and waited for his companions to join him. First, Hank

emerged. He gave a simple salute and a 'see ya', before disappearing into the prison building. Noah exited the car next, quickly followed by Emily, who held onto his hand as he helped her out of the car. They both looked exhausted.

"I think I need to go and throw up," whined Kerry, as she eventually appeared and rubbed a soothing line over her candy-filled stomach. There was no sympathy for her.

"There's my momma," a bright voice said loudly, and everyone turned around to find Jack rolling in their direction. "How's my baby?" he asked. There was a wide

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smile on his face as he bumped into Emily's legs and caught her in his lap. He nuzzled his mouth against the side of Emily's face, and laughed as he evoked a squeak and a giggle from her.

Devin watched the playful scene. His eyes drifted to find Noah's as he sought for a little courage. Hesitantly, he stepped forward and greeted Jack. "Be gentle with her," he suggested. "It's been a long trip."

Jack nodded happily, his expression changing as his eyes locked with Devin's in a curious stare. He'd already been warned things had gone bad in Chicago. "You know, I knew this guy once. He used to wear these tiger-print contacts all the time. I always thought they were pretty cool."

"Thanks," Devin said. He should have known he could count on Jack.

Emily seemed to appreciate the gesture as well, and wrapped her arms around Jack's neck, planting a kiss on the side of his face.

"Yes, sir," he said as he looked at Emily lovingly.

"You Reids have the prettiest damned eyes."

"How are things here?" Devin asked. Corden had left Jack in charge during his absence.

Jack smiled reassuringly. "Everything's good. No incidents our end. But we'll talk about it later, yeah?"

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Devin gave a short nod. Corden may have been a

dangerous fool, but at least he had kept everything organized and everyone in line. There was an eclectic mix of people in the group and they needed leadership. But as Jack had said, that was a conversation for later. Right now all Devin could think about was some much needed sleep.

"Good," Jack said and Emily hugged him tight as he spun around. "We'll see you in the morning," he called back to them as he wheeled him and Emily toward the building.

Devin watched as his sister disappeared between the parked vehicles. He smiled and gave a contented sigh as he turned back to Noah. "What?" he asked as he found Noah staring at him.

"Just thinking."

Devin narrowed his eyes. "Okay."

"Well, I better go too," Kerry interrupted with a groan, as she pushed the car door shut.

Devin looked at her across the car. "You all right?"

he asked, though he wasn't really concerned. Her condition was purely self-inflicted.

"Yep," Kerry decided. "I'm just going to go hug the toilet bowl for a little while, and then crawl into bed." She waved weakly and began a slow walk up to her room.

Noah rested his arm on top of the car and looked at Devin. "I think he's right," Noah said and stepped toward 271

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Devin.

"Who?"

"Jack." Devin laughed at him. "I mean it." Noah looked into Devin's eyes and smiled. "So," he continued.

"Now we're here and back in the real world, what's going to happen?"

What did he want to happen? Devin slowly slid his

hand across the roof of the car until his fingertips brushed Noah's. He glanced from his hand to Noah's, and wondered if he would ever feel about Noah the way he had about Connor. After all, once upon a time he thought Connor would be the man he'd marry. Slowly, he pulled back his hand. Maybe one day he could feel that way about

somebody else, about Noah.

"We just see how it goes," he decided. "Take each day as it comes." Noah seemed content with his answer.

"So, I'm going to take a shower, and then maybe later, if you like, we could get to know each other a little more."

"My favorite color is yellow," Noah stated. "What more do you need to know?"

Devin grinned. "Do you remember where my room is?" They could talk more there.

Noah smiled. "I do."

The choice of words amused Devin. Maybe one day, he thought. "Okay, so, twenty minutes?"

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"Yeah. Okay."

Devin leaned forward and pressed his mouth to

Noah's in a warm kiss. "I'll see you soon," he whispered, hesitating before pulling back. "I'm glad you're here."

Noah's eyes shone brightly. "Me too." He reached out and wrapped an arm around Devin's waist, hugging him close. "Everything's going to be okay now."

Devin tilted his head inquisitively. "How do you figure that?"

"I feel it." Noah tightened his hold on Devin.

"Things feel right."

"All I feel is tired," Devin teased, amused as Noah raised a critical eyebrow. "Kidding." He laughed and rested his hands on Noah's chest. Things did feel better. "Like I said, we'll see how it goes." Noah loosened his hold. "Now, go and unpack." He slid from Noah's arms, and pressed the key to the SUV in the palm of Noah's hand, before walking away. With a smile, he stopped and looked over his

shoulder. He met Noah's eyes, calling back to him, "You're home, Noah."

Noah smiled, but shook his head as he corrected

Devin. "We're home."

Devin thought on the phrase as he continued toward

the building. He smiled to himself as he pushed open the door. Yes, they were.

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THE END

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Meredith Russell lives in the heart of England. An avid fan of many story genres, she enjoys nothing less than a happy ending. She believes in heroes and romance and strives to reflect this in her writing. Sharing her imagination and passion for stories and characters is a dream Meredith is excited to turn into reality.

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ALSO BY MEREDITH RUSSELL:

Available from **Silver Publishing**:

Dead Things

with RJ Scott

The Art of Words

REVIEWS:

"Anyone who likes vulnerable male characters (as I do) should like this book. Blu is a fascinating character. You just want to give him a reassuring hug, ruffle his hair, and take him to McDonald's (ok...just kidding about Micky D's.

He isn't that childlike. He doesn't need McNuggets...just some confidence, served in abundance, please!!) He really doesn't believe in himself. He's a neurotic bundle of nerves in the beginning but by the end of the story the reader will be smiling with him.

The writers actually had me teary eyed at one point. And when a book hits me on an emotional level like that I usually rate high. They deserve it. The writing was crisp, clean, and realistic. The story wasn't bogged down with a lot of conflict, which I appreciate since it was a relatively short read. Blu's problem with self-esteem and his shameful secret was enough to keep the story flowing.

I definitely recommend this book to anyone who likes m/m romance.

And I definitely would read another book by this writing pair."

*-Hearts on Fire Reviews gives 5/5 to **The Art of Words***

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